Nobody sees you like I do

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by lowdmg

Summary

> “Three sessions.” Khaslana says at least, with his empty doll eyes under the shadow of the trees, he looks more like a ghost than ever. “I give you three sessions. If you don’t get to paint something I like, I leave.”
>
> “Hm, you really think I can’t.”
>
> “I *know* you can’t.”
>
> How terribly arrogant. Mydei grins, wild and prideful, heart thumping with what might be either adrenaline or anger. “Three sessions.” He agrees.

They say whoever attempts to make a muse out of Khaslana goes mad. Mydei thinks that’s fine. He wants less of a muse than he likes a challenge. Somewhere along the way, he falls in love.

Notes

As always, English is not my first language.

Chapter 1: The abyss down below us

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A drop of paint falls to the floor.

The sound it makes as it collides against the stone is faint. A silent *drip* drowned by the bustling of the city down below, but in the emptiness of the balcony, its non-existent echo spreads all the way from the tip of his fingers to his ears.

Mydei's eyes shift down to it. A small little round thing of blue, quickly losing its bright shine as it dries. He doesn't bother cleaning it. A futile endeavor made redundant when in view of the splats and stains of dried paint that covered the original marble stone like a tapestry. An accidental thing rather than a stylistic choice; the balcony is, after all, famous among artists—frustrated artists, to be exact, an old thing at the top of a cathedral of a long forgotten god turned cafe that oversees the city's plaza.

A view of inspiration, one of the reviews that appeared when you searched the name and was trying a little bit too hard to be poetic read, *the gentle breeze of the air carries along the lives of millions of strangers right to the infinity of the canvas.*

It's not the sort of place Mydei frequents; not the sort of place Mydei ever envisioned turning to. Inspiration is not something he tends to struggle with. He paints what he wants and what he wants he paints. Simple as that. Thoughts, feelings, views, whatever. It never takes much effort to press a brush against a canvas.

It didn't, at least.

It's not that nothing seems to catch his interest. It's not that nothing seems to spark in his mind. There are ideas, sure. There are wants, because a human never truly stops wanting, and Mydei has never been one to deny

himself. There’s inspiration, but it is accompanied by the uncanny abstinence of the burning urge to paint that usually latches onto him like a second skin. Months upon months of the same blank canvas staring back at him.

He peers back at the plaza, eyes trailing on different people. A woman pushes an ice cream’s cart around, a child runs after the pigeons another is throwing seeds at and scares them all off, the kid that was feeding them proceeds to hit the other, a girl kisses a flower before braiding it into another girl’s hair, a bunch of construction workers with different princess backpacks at their feet laugh loudly as they eat while on break, and one cafe worker chases a haggard old man throwing tomatoes at the cathedral with claims of blasphemy with a broom. He could paint any of it. It wouldn’t take much effort.

Another drop falls to the floor.

Mydei looks down at it again, then to the sky, now bleeding with reds and oranges as the purple hues of night start creeping in, and then to the canvas. Blank. An expanse of white. The brush dipped in blue, tip weighted under the wet paint, merely a breath away from it, but the quiet mundanities of the city fail to close that gap.

Another drop falls.

Mydei sighs and sets the brush aside.

In practiced motions, he picks all the tubes of paint and brushes placed on the wooden table and puts them back into his paint case; a smooth, black box that would look professional were it not to have a bunch of ugly-looking chimeras in the sides that all his friends in Castrum Kremnos had painted before he moved out the country.

The thought of ever cleaning them off has never once crossed his mind, but the blue paint on the palette has long dried.

He hauls the case by the handle, takes the blank canvas and leaves the balcony right before the old bell perched in one of the towers of the

cathedral tolls, signaling the pass of another hour with ear-deafening clarity. It’s the third time it has happened.

The old woman behind the counter looks at him sympathetically at the sight of the white canvas under his arm and throws an extra piece of sweet bread into the plastic bag as he buys a loaf. It’s still warm. He thanks her and starts eating it on the way out.

The last bits of light still cling to the sky, but the streetlights have already been turned on by the time Mydei makes it out the plaza. Feet trailing on well-worn cobblestone and a maze of paths and streets as he makes his way to the public parking lot. A stray dog raises its head towards him from where it is lazing on the floor and Mydei throws it the last bite of bread in his hand. Its tail wags against the floor as it eats it.

He keeps walking.

On the fifth avenue, two streets before the parking lot, lies The Irontomb, a military base turned art gallery[1], still open despite the hour. Mydei blinks at it, checks the time on his phone and, after a second of consideration, turns in its direction.

The man at the reception doesn’t look up from his cheap gossip magazine as Mydei walks inside. His body casts long shadows on the porcelain floors with intricate designs thanks to the light of the chandelier up in the ceiling —lavish, as the rest of the Irontomb is, a hard attempt to scrub out the remnants of the military off its metal walls, but nothing can’t quite erase the structural industrialization of its corridors. A nitpick only architects and the like would go on about, most only come to gaze at the art.

Mydei doesn’t come often to this place. He finds the art on display, frankly, too miserable; wannabe edgy. It’s not to discredit the art, all the works are all masterpieces in their own way, all too visceral and all too real, but the contents portrayed all tether on hopelessness of some kind, thriving on destruction. Perhaps that is to be expected for a place named The Irontomb.

For a while, Mydei simply walks through the corridors in quiet contemplation, eyes trailing on the different pieces, not particularly thinking

of anything, but not particularly thinking of nothing either. Maybe hoping for the urge to paint to strike him down. Art lives of art, as his mother used to say.

He walks through the east wing, past the board propped on an easel promoting an upcoming art competition and through artworks named on some variations of *Black Tide, Okhema's Final Days, A Cat's Lie,* and the like. He skims past *Calculation 03*[2]at the center of the gallery, disinterest born from having enough of a lifetime having to write artistic analysis on it, in favor of turning into the west wing.

And the painting of a crumbling statue at the end of the hall stops Mydei dead in his tracks.

A somber mix of blues, blacks and whites broken by bright golds sweeping out the statue like blood. Marble skin breaking apart, piece by piece, revealing nothing but a deep hollowness inside. It is falling, submerging in a deep abyss of blacks as a crumbling hand reaches up to the last vestiges of blue above.

A dying, lonely thing.

His eyes linger on the statue's face; strangely familiar, like a stranger met in a dream, a person only seen from the corner of the eye. It's undoubtedly beautiful, sharp features, otherworldly etherealness, but it is all overshadowed by the molting gold of his eyes, melting in terrible sadness.

Thus Burns the Dawn, the name reads.

Mydei stares at it until the echo of the bell toll resonates through the Irontomb's walls like a death knell and its doors come to close and when he steps outside the sky outside is black like liquid obsidian. No moon that night.

The turned lights of hotels, houses, restaurants, shops and the like mix with the bright, yellow old shine of the streetlights along the attention grabbing neons of ads and illuminated signs. It pollutes the night, erases the natural

light of the stars, but the few, stubborn little dots of white that refuse to be outshined remind Mydei of crumbling marble.

His fingers twitch.

The bright shine of the sun reminds him of burning, grief-stricken eyes.

His eyes trail over the smooth walls of the gym as he works out, replacing oranges and teals with blues, whites and golds, even if his pace doesn't falter once as he continues his morning's regime.

The articulations in his hand tense and relax, tendons and veins moving, skin stretching, and it is easy to picture the places where cracks would form first.

He saves references of statues and sculptures, most marble, on his phone; anything he can find, from famous things like Veiled Virgin, Aphrodite of Milos, David and Belvedere Torso, to the metal or plaster sculptures hidden in some unsuspecting turn of the city, and the unnamed things found on some corner of the web.

His dreams, ambiguous things, lost in the sea of conscience, all feature the last vestiges of a marmoreal heart sinking in the puddles he walks past.

It clings to him. The painting. Intimately.

Mydei is not obsessive by nature. Dedicated, yes. Stubborn, passionate and, at worst, terribly intense, that, he can admit. He knows himself well and isn't afraid to do so. He recognizes the fixation, the fascination, the twitching of his fingers and the reasons the canvas stays blank despite it—He doesn't want to recreate it. He could, rather easily. But he has never been the type of person to settle—but he fails to understand where said fascination comes from. He's never been Pygmalion, not to say that the analogy falls flat when *Thus Burns the Dawn* is another's Galatea; and he does not indulge in either naiveness nor romanticism as to believe in

proclamations of love at first sight, much less with a statue, nor the transcendence of a pure heart.

The first piece clicks eight weeks after, amidst the smell of paper, wood and paint of an art store that is most definitely a mafia front close to Mydei's home. Paintings hung on cloth hangers on the ceiling like dead men. A vase with spider lilies dripping blood[3], a study of birds, a boat on the side of the coast and a statue stepping out a room.

The last one catches his attention. Gently, like a tap on the shoulder. Mydei's eyes skim past that painting to the one next to it just to come back a second after. It's a simple thing—left unfinished, giving the sensation it was made in haste. The room isn't finished, crude strokes of brown melting to white, like it was falling apart while the blacks and reds of the night peeking outside the door overlapped with the door's frame. The statue, back turned, has a foot already set outside, a hand on the handle as it closes it behind it. Picture caught mid-action.

"Thirty-three million, five hundred fifty thousand, three hundred thirty-six." Says a man with far too polished of a suit, a cigarette and a fedora as puts a set of brushes and tubes of different shades of blue paint in a plastic bag. Mydei makes a sound in the back of his throat and, "The painting." He clarifies.

"Weird name."

"It's the number in the barcode on the sticker on the back. It doesn't actually have a name, but I need it to call it something."

"Where did you find it?"

"Why, does it interest you?"

"I'm not buying it."

"Heh, then I guess we won't know."

Mydei doesn’t say anything and neither does a single muscle on his face so much as twitch. He simply shifts his eyes down to stare at the man and he cracks immediately. “On the trash.”

“Mm.”

“It’s not that strange.” He says, suddenly feeling a whole lot chattier. “Most of his paintings do—The model’s, I mean. No worth to an incomplete thing.”

His? A part of Mydei thinks, looking up at the painting once again, eyes trailing to the figure in the center. Clothes made crudely of three strokes of blue and white, a bright yellow circle shines on the neck, overshadowing white hair, hiding grief-stricken eyes, crumbling marble.

Painting left discarded.

Ah.

“Khaslana.”

“Know him?” Mydei huffs, making a motion to the general direction of the art supplies he’s buying, almost offended. There’s no artist in this city worth their name that hasn’t heard about Khaslana. “Personally, I mean.”

“No.”

“Gonna try your hand at it?”

Mydei arches an eyebrow. “Do I look that desperate?" He asks. It comes out condescending.

“No, you look captivated.”

His fingers twitch.

“You aren’t the only one.” The man continues, not as a consolation, and shrugs. “Can’t say I understand the appeal, frankly.”

“You dug his painting out the trash.” Mydei replies.

He taps the end of the cigarette against the end of the table, gray ash falling down to the floor as he replies, “Madness sells well.”

Every place has its stories. Every place has its blood. Every place has its whispers. This city is no different, held between the corners, the soil and the eyes, tales of golden butterflies kissing trees, black dogs that lick the mouths of the drunk, Bartholos’ tricks and the like abound.

And between brushes and paint, the stroke against a canvas whispers that whoever attempts to make a muse out of Khaslana goes mad.

Mydei isn’t one for gossip, but he is observant; not to mention one would have to be both blind and deaf not to notice the lonesome figure with a sun on his neck and snow for hair portrayed on thousands of works left discarded. Found in the trash, found in an alley, found at garage sales, found in unsuspecting art stores, found in random shops, restaurants and cafes—but never in galleries, exhibitions nor museums.

Works all incomplete. Featureless.

With the exception of two. *Thus Burns the Dawn,* made by the Irontomb’s curator, an Antikytheran named Lygus, and an unnamed piece made by the Ruin Author, Nanook[4], that never saw the light of day.

It’s like watching a corpse in the ocean at night, an old man with trembling hands told Mydei once, an untold story hidden between crinkled, warm eyes, *the wish to paint him before he sinks hooks you by the throat like a vice and you don’t realize you are sinking too.*[5]

Yesterday, tall tales, Mydei used to think, Zagreus likes to mingle with the people. Today, he looks down and watches the water reach his calves.

A lesser man would be consumed. A coward would fear it. Mydei is neither.

He still thinks of crumbling marble, burning suns, the vestiges of a ghost, the canvas remains empty, but he doesn't obsess over it. He does not search up and high for Khaslana, he does not go to gaze upon *Thus Burns the Dawn* for hours at a time, he does not search and buy every painting of Khaslana he can find and, likewise, he does not shy away from them. Even when they seem to cling to him insistently.

Hauntingly.

A painting on the bakery he goes to every week, another next to the bin of his neighbour's trash. Here, on the feed of some app on his phone. There, through the window of some shop he walks past. The cathedral-turned-cafe in the center of the plaza has one hung next to the door; featureless, as always, the shape of a head up to the neck. Mydei can't remember for the life of him if it was there before.

I could paint you, he thinks, more than a little pridefully, refusing to bend as he watches shapes across paper, *but you can't sink me.*

Mydei meets Khaslana three weeks after, outside the entrance of some old mall without one wall at the side that the owner insists is an aesthetic choice and not the result of poor planning that had resulted in said wall crumbling down after a tame earthquake some years ago.

It's completely by chance. A thing almost lost under the hustle of his day-to-day if not for the loud *'splash!'* that catches his attention as he walks past and makes him turn his head around—just to see a man waist-deep in a man-made pond.

He doesn't recognize him, at first, more used to the unfinished things made of crude strokes of paint, before he catches sight of snow hair and a burning sun on a neck, hidden under a leather choker but undoubtedly *there.* All-consuming, all-alluring.

Mydei's breath does not hitch when he sees him. His body doesn't look in and on itself, and neither does his heart skip a beat. Instead, there's a single

thought that comes to him with stark clarity and bone-deep certainty.

Found you.

Even though he wasn't looking for him in the first place.

Khaslana makes his way further into the pond. His movements disrupt the stillness of the waters, looking as if he might dissolve and disappear into them any minute now, like an apparition, like a ghost.

A pink plastic ball floats in the middle and a few kids stand anxiously at the edges. Khaslana grabs it, turns, and throws it back to the kids. One of them catches it, and they all yell some variation of *'Thank you, Mister!'* before scramming off as Khaslana gives them a little wave of hand.

How surprisingly kind.

Or, perhaps, not so surprisingly.

Mydei finds himself strangely curious about what other things whispers and rumours fail to say.

A pair of well-worn white sneakers with black socks rest right on the edge of the pond. They dangle precariously, and Mydei drags them further into the concrete as he waits for Khaslana, who is making his way back in strides, head turned down, seemingly careful not to step nor kick onto any of the koi fish swimming lo and about.

Khaslana comes to a stop just a few steps away from the edge, just below the shadow Mydei's body casts onto the waters, and he turns his head up to see him.

His eyes aren't gold.

It startles him, for some reason.

Molten gold of bleeding eyes and scorching suns fade out of his mind like seafoam onto a lightless blue. Khaslana's eyes aren't bright. Not one bit. They are deep, murky things, swallowing all light. The surface of a lake, an

ocean, hiding an unfathomable abyss below. Glossy, almost doll-like. Nothing but Mydei's own reflection staring back at him.

His skin, too, is much like a doll's. White, porcelain-like, stretching over sharp features with seemingly no imperfections if not for the way pale lips are chapped and bitten. Mydei could probably go into more detail, if not for the way his eyes keep going over to set on his eyes.

Empty, enticing things, like the bottom of a well without water.

One you could fall into at any moment.

Maybe that wouldn't be so bad.

The thought is stark, like a bolt of lighting. Mydei bites the inside of his cheek hard enough to taste blood and the pain—The pain is grounding. A push against the pull. He blinks, and finds that he has to take a step back to avoid falling into the water, feet dangling precariously over the edge.

Dangerous.

The thought shouldn't thrill him so.

Khaslana is still watching him, silently. Somehow, looking as if he's seeing past him at the same time he's boring into his very soul. His face an emotionless, cold thing.

He's still on the pond.

Wordlessly, Mydei extends a hand.

Khaslana blinks; empty-well eyes shifting down from his face, to the extended hand, again to his face before settling back onto his hand one last time. There's a long beat before his right hand raises and an even longer beat before his hand stops simply hovering over Mydei's palm and grabs it. His skin is both too far hot and far too cold.

Khaslana's feet make a loud *splat* as he steps back onto land along a faint *drip, drip, drip.* The water darkens the concrete under him. He's drenched

up to the end of his white, loose shirt and his black pants cling onto his legs. On his left hand, Mydei notes, a long, dark purple glove with butterflies reaches all the way to his shoulder. It seems out of place.

Mydei doesn't let go of his hand.

His fingers twitch.

"Thank you."

And the second piece falls into place. An idea sparks in his mind. Competitive, greedy, and more than a little bold. *Dangerous.*

"I want to paint you."

"Eh?"

Not one to be ashamed of his desires, Mydei repeats, shamelessly. "I want to paint you."

There's a long, long pause and, slowly, almost deliberately, Khaslana lets go of Mydei's hand and lets it fall limply to his side.

"...And you are?"

Chapter End Notes

FOOTNOTES

1. Lots of places have been repurposed in this town, truth be told, to the point that it's kind of ridiculous. It cuts costs, for sure, but Mydei thinks whoever is making these decisions should take a long look at themselves when they decided to have children running around in a playground that once was an execution ground. Not even Castrum Kremnos is that careless with their dead.Back

2. Calculation 03, drawn on a chalkboard that covers a whole wall with a cheap piece of red chalk, it's less an artwork than it is a long equation, written in a way that shows a hyperrealistic bird eye's plane of the whole country of Amphoreus being swallowed by code. It's the last and most famous piece of the series Calculations made by the all elusive mathematician Nous on a single evening. Artists praise the talent, but mathematicians and the like have gone mad trying to solve it. There's exactly one person that has achieved it, the genius turned serial killer, Polka Kakamond, though she didn't share the result—Madam Herta has gone on record saying she also did it but the result was so boring you might as well have asked her what two plus two was.Back

3. That one will be bought and burnt soon after.Back

4. Known for their portrayals of destruction in its most visceral form. It is said that gazing upon the Ruin Author's works is enough to instill the idea that existence itself is a mistake. Ash to ash, dust to dust. Indifferent to most works, upon walking into The Irontomb, the Ruin Author had stopped to gaze upon Thus Burns the Dawn for a whole minute before asking about the model. They went on to paint Khaslana after that—an experience that, reportedly, ended up with someone being stabbed with a palette knife, a bucket of paint being swung to a head and a burnt mansion. All parties involved refuse to comment on the matter, though, it is said that the Ruin Author's eyes noticeably soften upon reminded of the experience.Back

5. It had been hailing, that day, the tiny specks of ice threatened to break the glass ceiling of the tiny ice cream shop everyone had crammed into. The old man had come to sit on the same table as him and started talking once he saw the paint stuck under Mydei's nails with the same abandon old people always have—Mydei doesn't remember what he answered, but he remembers the laugh he got in return. "Boy, you don't reach my age without learning how to swim. Besides, I only draw pigeons."Back

Do you guys know Tomie? This was going to go in that sort of direction, with Mydei stumbling upon a painting of Khas' mutilated corpse instead of Thus Burns the Dawn and becoming morbidly awed at it but 3.4 was far too antsy and all the visions I had turned like a lot, lot fluffier because I need that man comforted, besides I got E2S1 Phaiphai (without losing the 50/50 once!!! My wife loves me fr fr) so he deserved a reward. Still, I really like the idea of him as Tomie so the supernatural-ish undertones are here to stay.

Chapter 2: Pull of the waters

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Drops of water fall onto the floor, one after another and yet another one after, darkening the pavement below from ash to black like a burnt down wasteland before they dry. Unable to leave its mark the way paint does, forming shapes that don’t last.

Here one moment, gone the next.

A sun forms, or perhaps it is a flower, maybe both, maybe neither. Maybe it doesn’t matter.

Mydei’s eyes flick away from it to see Khaslana instead.

Paint and shapes reflect in lightless blue eyes, works and arts Mydei has done over the years. He takes his time. Lingers long on each and every one. Sun-ringed pupils shifting from one side to the other as he observes all the different details that create a picture like a puzzle instead of simply scrolling through Mydei’s phone and catching a glimpse or two.

—And yet, despite the amount of care he has, it somehow still feels as if he’s looking right past them.

Mydei’s mouth twists, just barely. The world spins, time flows and the wind that pushes white locks of hair back doesn’t do much to stab off the quiet stillness that surrounds Khaslana. His breathing is slow, blinks sporadically, and his face doesn’t change. Expressionless features carved out of marble. Unmoving, unchanging, eternally.

A statue, a picture caught in time.

He should be able to paint the slope of his nose in one single stroke of the brush, he believes; dust the tip with a little pink, maybe, to give some color

to his complexion—though, that could make him look as if he’s cold. It could work, paint him in the snow. Add some vibrant colors to avoid him blending into the background, maybe paint in gold the sun on his neck.

For the lips, a faint pink will suffice, with small red tears close to the cupid’s bow to portray the places where he has picked at them. The general texture of broken skin may be hard to recreate, but Mydei can already think of a few ways to do so.

For his eyes, those—those shift up to him.

And Khaslana stares.

Mydei doesn’t look away.

There’s no particular embarrassment or startle at being caught watching so blatantly. Of course he’s going to do so, he wants to paint him. He has already made this desire well-known, and, even if he hadn’t, it wouldn’t stop him from watching Khaslana, either way. Mydei is not a self-conscious person and neither is he a coward as to hide when he finds the abyss staring back at him, threatening to sink him down, down, down.

Khaslana doesn’t comment on it. He doesn’t say anything, in fact, and neither does Mydei. Silence growing and drowning the rustle of the leaves, the rumble of cars, the steps, and conversations as empty eyes trail onto every nook and cranny of Mydei’s face with the same attention he watched the paintings on his phone. Careful, but distant, still.

Mydei wonders what he sees, what he’s searching for, whichever realm he finds himself in and threatens to disappear into at any moment now like mist in the night.

They still don’t say anything, maybe words have simply stopped existing.

Time stretches, twists and turns. A minute might have passed, or maybe two. The eternity of a second and the fleetingness of year. All in one, before Khaslana's head tilts. The movement much like a doll’s whose neck’s

articulations couldn’t hold on the weight of its porcelain head. White hair follows the motion, a few strands going over his eyes.

Khaslana looks away first.

In careful movements, he looks through a few more images of his paintings before he shuts down the phone and gives it back to Mydei, fingers shy of touching.

Then, wordlessly, silently, he bends down and plucks the socks out of the white shoes resting on the floor. The sun on the concrete has faded between one blink to the other and the drops falling from Khaslana’s drenched clothes like quiet rain don’t form any other shape.

He still doesn’t say anything.

The silence should be unnerving, perhaps even nerve-wracking. It’s hard to know whether to interpret the lack of answer as judgement, condescension, or simply lack of care, but Mydei isn’t concerned.

He knows his paintings are good.

It’s not vanity—*ha,* Nikador forbid the thought—but simply self-assurance. A fact. Skill crafted out of years of practice and passion. A warrior who doesn’t recognize their own strengths isn’t better than the one who overestimates them.[1] So, he lets such silence stretch. Mydei has spoken his words and it is turn for Khaslana to respond. He’s patient.

In lieu, Mydei watches in silence as he turns around his black socks with ugly yellow-green patterns sewn at the sides. Fabric covering soles tinged in faint red from where the heated stone had started to burn Khaslana’s feet before they moved onto one of the wooden benches placed under the trees.

A beat passes.

And Khaslana sighs. A quiet thing. Bursting silence like a bubble. Breath stolen by the wind, which pushed along the branches of the big, big trees

with their big, big leaves, shifting shadows through space, looming like nooses to be hung.

He says, “There are easier ways to learn how to paint people.”

“Excuse me?”

“I said, there are easier ways to learn how to paint people.” Khaslana repeats with the exact same tone and inflection. There’s no particular sneer to it, but the monotonous timbre of his voice makes it sound awfully pretentious.

A flicker of a flame licks against his ribcage. “I know how to paint people.”

“I never said you couldn’t.”

“Didn’t you?”

“Maybe.” Khaslana shrugs, makes a general direction to the phone in Mydei’s hand. “You just don’t seem to paint people often.”

“Hmph. I’m not the kind of person to paint just anyone.”

“But you want to paint me.”

Khaslana is hardly the type one would describe as ‘just anyone’, let alone a ‘person’. They both know it. None of them mention it.

“I have already said that I do.” Mydei replies instead.

“Why?”

“I want to.”

Khaslana’s eyes lower. “That’s not a real answer.”

“It is.”

“Is it?”

“Yes.” He repeats, firmly.

Another sigh. This is one stolen, too, as if the wind itself wanted to take him. Marble turned to dust.

“What a rather simplistic view of life.”

“I’m a simple man.” Mydei shrugs. “And I don’t think it necessary to justify the whys of our wishes and wants.”

“So, you agree.” Khaslana says. The shadows of the trees shift around him. “That it’s not as simple as just wanting to paint me.”

“No, I think it is.”

Khaslana hums. “Mm, could it be that you don’t know why?”

No. Mydei knows. The fact that he’s simple—or, at least, thinks of himself that way—doesn’t mean he’s oblivious. Repression is a vice and ignorance a weakness. He knows his wants and he knows his whys. It’s hard for him to put them into words, action always speaks far more honestly, and neither is it necessary, so he settles on an unceremonial, “I like a challenge.”

And Khaslana—

—Stops.

It’s not the quiet stillness from earlier, though it is ever present, but something else. He blinks, blinks and blinks again. His mouth opens with the beginnings of an answer before closing and pressing into a line. The movement stretches and shrinks one of the red tears in the commissure of his lips.

The thought of tearing it further comes unbidden. Dig a nail into it or rip the wound further with his teeth and lap the blood with his tongue and paint torn reds over a white linen.

Mydei lets out a low, deliberate breath.

Dangerous, how easy it is to sink.

“...A challenge.”

“Mm.”

“A challenge.” He repeats, as if it was the first time he has ever been told that, before he shakes his head and, a little pointed, he adds, “You do know that none has been able to paint me.”

“None of them are me.”

“You speak as if you don’t have a brain.” Khaslana replies. He doesn’t scoff, but the sound he makes comes close to one. “Haven’t you thought there’s a reason why that is? Next you will say you are going to win that stupid art competition on The Irontomb with me as your model.”

Mydei raises his chin. “Is that a challenge?”

“Well, you sure like those, don’t you?” Khaslana crosses his legs, places his elbow on his knee and rests his cheek on his palm. He’s all sharp edges and jagged ends, a flicker peeking under a cold exterior. “Even when they are far beyond your level.”

“Far beyond my level. Ha, what’s that supposed to mean?”

He shrugs and, almost disinterestedly, he says, “You just don’t paint people often,” and the words are light but the bite sure isn’t.

“Doesn’t mean I can’t.” Mydei repeats.

Khaslana’s eyes narrow at the edges, just so, and the sound he lets out is a condescending thing, perhaps even a little mean. Meant to bruise. “That you can do it doesn't mean you are any good at it. I have seen a whole lot better.”

A part of him, ever observant, ever sharp, ever piercing, recognizes the jab, the lie, a performative dig to get at him, but another part can’t help but fall for it either way. He has never taken kindly to being looked down upon in

any way shape or form. He clicks his tongue and says, just as pointed, “At least they aren’t in the trash.”

Khaslana’s expression doesn’t fall.

It doesn’t shatter, nor does it twist, nor does it stutter, nor does it freeze. It doesn’t change. It remains in that impassive, porcelain expressionless from earlier. Unmoving, unchanging, eternally—But the hand on his cheek tenses, fingers curling, before he goes to pick at a scab on his lips, chipping marble.

“That’s exactly where yours will finish too.”

He’s very adamant about that, if Mydei didn’t know better, he would think he was, “Scared?”

Khaslana’s eyes shift sharply, looking as if he would have Mydei dead more than a million times over. An array of cold, blue colors won’t suffice to paint them. It wouldn’t be enough. Fire encased in ice, Mydei thinks, maybe a dot of orange hidden and dissolved between the blues, like a flame—not because there’s any light on those empty blue eyes, but because Khaslana seems to be burning inside out. It’s hidden, carefully, but it’s there.

Silence stretches, melts and crashes. Somewhere, a child laughs. Somewhere, a car honks. Somewhere, people talk. The hot embers of, well, maybe not anger, but annoyance, still sizzle in his gut, but he swallows whatever scalding retort and prod bubbling on his tongue. He knows, with the sharpness of a predator, when to strike and when to wait.

He reclines against the bench, head thrown back, and looks up into the sky through the little crooks of the green leaves rustled by the wind. Above, the clouds twist into one dream or the other as they continue their slow travel to some corner of the world to cry onto.

From the corner of his eye, he catches the general impression of a motion. Khaslana still picks at his lips, and, despite the fact that the embers haven’t quite cooled yet, he says, “You are going to draw blood.”

A beat passes.

Khaslana’s hand falls.

Mydei waits.

The silence that befalls afterwards isn’t particularly comfortable. There’s still tensions, words heard yet left unsaid, the beginnings of a crack, yet the rustle of the winds and the quiet mundanities of the city soften it. A laugh, a step, a hum, a yawn, a life. The quiet drip of water drops falling to the floor much like paint on an empty balcony.

A lifetime or two may have passed before Mydei lets his head roll to the side, leaving behind ambiguous forms in the clouds to the drifting form of Khaslana. Empty eyes fixed on some spot on the ash concrete, trailing onto the drops of water that don’t make any shapes without really seeing them.

A few more lifetimes pass before he starts to put his shoes on. The sound of scraping stone rising where he’s digging and wiggling his feet into them, crushing the heel tabs. For a moment, Mydei thinks he will simply go with shoelaces left undone, but it seems he’s not without his pride.

The shadows shift and,

“Three sessions.” Khaslana says at least, with his empty doll eyes under the shadow of the trees, he looks more like a ghost than ever. “I give you three sessions. If you don’t get to paint something I like, I leave.”

“Hm, you really think I can’t.”

“I *know* you can’t.”

How terribly arrogant. Mydei grins, wild and prideful, heart thumping with what might be either adrenaline or leftover anger. “Three sessions.” He agrees.

“I forgot to mention,” Khaslana says in lieu of a greeting at half past three o’clock sharp of a gray Sunday afternoon. “I don’t do nude. Will that be a problem?”

He’s one hour and half late.

The three little knock-knock-knocks cling into the gaps of terracotta bricks; not like echoes, but like a cavity in a tooth. Unnoticed, unseen, but all-present as it digs and digs in. Mydei looks at Khaslana, standing at the edge of the second stone step that gives way to his house with his messenger bag, sharp tongue and doll eyes, and, instead of mentioning his lateness, answers with a deadpan, “Good afternoon to you too.”

“Good afternoon, Mydeimos.” He replies just as deadpan. The bastard. Mydei shouldn’t be so charmed by that. “I don’t do nude.”

“Yes, I heard you the first time.”

“And you didn’t answer the first time.”

This guy. “No, Khaslana.” Mydei says through a breath, making a motion as he steps aside in silent invitation for him to enter. He doesn’t budge, and so, “It’s not a problem.” He adds.

Khaslana hums, takes a step forwards, and stumbles when the last stone step wobbles under his weight. Mydei should fix it, he thinks as the other’s arms jerk upwards to maintain balance, it’s been loose for a while now, rock slowly grinding out the floor with the passage of the years.

His soles collide against the stone of the second step with a harsh *‘bam!’* that is far, far too loud for someone as quiet as Khaslana. He doesn’t fall. Mydei gets the impression his body would shatter like glass if he did. Little pieces scattering across the street. Never to be found again.

Mydei extends a hand towards him. Khaslana doesn’t grab it. Instead he takes a long stride with long legs and skips the wobbly step and just like that—He’s in his house.

He shuts the door.

It closes like a casket’s lid.

“Do you want anything to drink?”

Khaslana’s eyes wrack through the expanse of his house; through the terracotta bricks, through the kitchen’s door, through one of the paintings his mother made for him hung on the wall[2], through the long brown couch, through the book with a story about bugs left on the coffee table next to a glass with red drops of pomegranate juice sliding down. He lingers a tad longer on the vase in the center but the glassy sheen never truly leaves his eyes, as if the world always reflected on them instead of sinking in.

As such, it takes a couple more seconds for his question to reach him, and his answer is a simple shake of head.

Mydei nods, tells the other to follow him, and starts leading him in the direction of his art studio. Khaslana walks after him, steps silent against the wooden floor to the point that Mydei has to fight the urge to look back to check if he’s still there.

A couple of more steps pass in place of the clock hands until Khaslana says, “I was late.”

There.

It’s just a matter of patience, really. Don’t mention it and, eventually, they will bring it up themselves—if they care, and it seems Khaslana is not as inconsiderate as he tried to make himself out to be.

Mydei already knew, of course, otherwise the other would have simply put his shoes back on and disappeared into the wind with soggy socks and wet feet the other day.

“You were.” Mydei replies simply. “Had me thinking you weren’t going to come for a second.”

“There was a—Cat.”

The sentence ends abruptly. Mydei turns around to see Khaslana standing still, eyes turned upwards as he stares at the cat perched proudly from his position on top of the stairs leading up to his room, looking haughtily down at him.

“That’s Kopopo the Third.”

“Kopopo?”

“The Third. Address him correctly.”

Khaslana’s eyes shift from Kopopo The Third to Mydei. Expressionless, but once he realizes Mydei is serious, he says, flatly, “The Third.”

Mydei nods.

“You were saying?”

“Cat.” He repeats.

“Brilliant observation. Kopopo The Third *is* a cat.”

“There was a cat. *Another* cat.” He says. Adamantly. A little annoyed, maybe. “It was hurt. I took it to someone who will take care of it.”

What a terribly sweet reason. It’s unexpected, but not particularly surprising for a person who dipped into a pond to retrieve a ball for a bunch of kids he probably didn’t know. Still, Mydei can’t help but ask, “And that took you hour and a half?”

“Cats don’t really like me.”

“What?”

As if on cue, Kopopo The Third, who at some point had decided to walk down the stairs and dignify them with his presence, hisses and swipes a clawed paw against Khaslana’s ankle before darting away like a bullet—

which is strange, to say the least, because Kopopo The Third might be terribly haughty in the way all cats seem to be, kind of rude and overall unwilling to let new people close, but he has never been particularly aggressive.

Khaslana doesn't bat an eye at his cat's actions, though, and the delayed little *ouch* he lets out is possibly the most blandest thing Mydei has ever heard.

It's almost funny.

A beat passes before Mydei starts going into the corridor next to the stairs, Khaslana trailing close behind. "A head's up would have been nice." He tells him.

"I don't have your number."

"Whose fault is that?"

"Who gives their phone number to a stranger?"

"You won't give your number to a stranger," Mydei pauses, baffled by the logic. "But you will agree to go into their house?"

"You were the one who gave me your direction." He says. It feels judgemental, which is irritating, because *Khaslana* had been the one that suggested they do it in Mydei's house, not him.[3]

Mydei opens his mouth, thinks better of it, and sighs. No use starting an argument, frankly. He continues.

Now, situated on the left, in front of the door under the stairs that leads to Mydei's library, lies his art studio. It's nothing big, much less impressive, a little room nestled within his life like a heart in a ribcage, because ostentatiousness and vanity are not needed to create, just a soul and a will.

It's a little messy, maybe, the warm rich reds of the terracotta bricks splattered with stains and little dots of paint here and there, not enough to

cover them, but just enough to make constellations on the walls. It smells of dried paint and strong coffee. He likes to paint with that, sometimes.
Mydei turns on the lights and walks into it with familiar steps. There's four tubes of paint placed on the floor next to the easel in the center of the room. White, blue, black and gold. Remnants of a haunting that made Mydei invite a ghost into his house.

He goes to one of the cabinets to take out some more. Orange, most definitely. Purple, for the silk glove in his hand. Blue, because Khaslana's soft-looking sweater edges on it like a washed-out thing. Red, for some reason—and a couple dozen more.

Khaslana hasn't entered the room.

He places the tubes of paint on the black table next to the easel, where an empty canvas is already propped onto. The same one he has been carrying like a second skin around with him from months on end, from the studio to the cathedral's balcony to the edge of a lake to an errant food stand to the top of a car and into this room once again. It has a few stains of mud and mustard on the back.

He bends to pick the paint on the floor with one hand before placing them onto the table next to the others. Plastic against wood with a harmonized tap. Khaslana still doesn't enter; glassed gaze fixed on the line that separates the art studio from the corridor. Maybe he will crumble into salt the moment that he enters, sea foam in the night.

Mydei walks to another cabinet, picks out some brushes and a palette from the shelf.

Khaslana doesn't enter. Mydei doesn't say anything.

His fingers twitch.

The light in the art studio is a low, yellow thing. It warms Khaslana, but the darkness of the corridor cools him, claws into him like desperate hands. It's a pretty nice contrast, if a little ominous. Not a bad thing to portray. Mydei thinks of riverfalls falling from his eyes, filling the room, drowning it,

sinking it, like an ocean tipped down, but his bottom well eyes have long, long emptied of any water.

There's a breath, like the last exhalation of a dying man, and Khaslana steps into the room.

Mydei still doesn't say anything, watches him walk through the art studio like smoke from a cigarette that might vanish soon enough; watches him look at the paint clinging to his floors, to the dozens of canvas laid across the room like bones holding a body. Some empty, some half-finished, some finished. Gloved fingers graze gently the beginnings of the aftermath of a battleground reclined on the wall before tilting it forward and catching a glimpse of an empty piano in a bar behind it.[4]

He stares at that one for a long time.

How, is the question, does an entity like Khaslana, made out of white linen, wet paint and incomplete brushstrokes, regard art?

"Do you even like art?" Mydei asks.

"Why wouldn't I?" Khaslana mutters, fingers leaving the painting. It's a terribly melancholic sight.

He lets the messenger bag fall onto the floor with a loud *'thud'* immediately after before walking to Mydei. One of his hands rolls a brushstroke absentmindedly through the table as he asks, "How do you want me?"

"Whichever way is fine."

Khaslana nods and goes to sit on the stool in front of the easel. He crosses his legs, gloved hand around his calf and places his elbow on his knee; resting his cheek on his palm, the bandages around his hand[5] looking coarse against porcelain skin. He positions himself in a way where he isn't looking directly at Mydei as he paints.

Mydei takes a seat too, right in front of the empty canvas as he picks up the palette and the brush the other was rolling on the table. He dips the end of it

in a bit of orange, mixes it with white and raises the combination to the center of the canvas. Merely a breath away from it. The weight of the paint lowers the strands and the beginnings of a drop start to form, but before it can fall, Mydei takes a look at the Khaslana.

And the gap closes.

The first stroke against the canvas feels like the first beating of a heart that had been dead for months.

…Just for it to die again a few hours later.

A paintbrush hovers in the air, close to the canvas. White paint shining under the yellow light of the studio as a couple of drops fall onto the floor. *Drip, drip, drip.* Mydei ignores it all, eyes staring intently at the shapes and colors that conform Khaslana on the canvas.

“Can’t finish?” He says, voice quiet. The first sound uttered in the room ever since they started.

Mydei blinks, feeling his eyes burn with dryness as he does so, before his gaze shifts from the painting to Khaslana. “What makes you say that?”

“Don’t they all?” Khaslana mutters, as if answering a question of his own before he says, louder, “You have been still for a while now—and I thought the one that wasn’t supposed to move here was me.”

Mydei huffs, “It’s not that. It’s just…” He falters and the action is so terribly uncharacteristic of him that he finds himself frowning—and yet, he finds himself repeating, “It’s just…”

…What is it?

He can’t put a finger on it.

His eyes trail to the painting, then to Khaslana, and back to the painting. By all intents and purposes, it is finished. A lonely figure sat in the middle of

an art studio, with empty doll eyes and a marble expression. White hair that falls like snow. One hand with a purple glove with butterflies and the other with coarse bandages. Long legs with thick thighs crossed. White shoes with shoelaces undone that hover above the floor. Bitten lips. A burning sun in a neck tucked under black, tight leather that bulges out the skin at the edges in temptation.

It’s done.

But the canvas feels no less empty for it.

Maybe, “There’s something missing.”

“It’s not the painting.” Khaslana replies, closing his eyes. “Not really.”

“What?”

The hand around his calf falls. It reveals the beginnings of three thin scars and a stain of red smudged onto porcelain skin. Mydei’s eyes zero on it. The brush in his hand dips into red paint, covering the white.

“You will see.”

Chapter End Notes

FOOTNOTES

1. Long has the era of warriors, heroes and odysseys come pass, but, at their core, Castrum Kremnos will always be a nation built on Strife, and so they shall continue teaching their blood as such. What is life if not a battlefield, after all? Back

2. It’s of a lion cub sleeping on top of its mother’s back, basking in the sun. Despite the blood sticking to her paws and the meat between her teeth, the look in her eyes as she watches her son is a terribly gentle thing. It’s unnamed, of course, because that sort of love doesn’t need words to be understood. Back

3. More accurately, he had interrupted with a dry ‘yours is fine’ that left no room for argument when Mydei was giving him a few more public options because he understands the cautions a person should have to a stranger asking them to paint them on the street. A part of him wonders if he should worry about Khaslana’s sense of self-preservation. Back

4. It had been raining, that night, but the bar had been warm with his friends’ dumb laugh and Hephaestion’s arm around his shoulder. It had been the day before he moved out of Castrum Kremnos and the sight of the empty piano had stuck him, for some reason. The imprint of someone who should be there but wasn’t. He sketched it onto a napkin with a yellow crayon made out of clay and forgotten about it until it fell from the pocket of a jacket on the floor of a house that wasn't home yet. Back

5. Cats really, really don’t like Khaslana. It’s fine. He was always more of a dog person anyways—Except that dogs don’t really like Khaslana much either. Not anymore. Now, birds, though, different story, they absolutely love the guy. Also lizards, for some reason, which is great, frankly, because lizards are awesome. Back

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There's not a single moment in this chapter where Khas isn't disassociating lol.

Chapter 3: Try and swim

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Blacks and blues and whites and golds cling onto the decolored plastic palette in Mydei's hand, slowly drying like cloths of coagulated blood. The paint on the yellowing strands of the old, rooting wooden brushes falls and dissolves through the once clear waters held in a white ceramic cup without a handle, slowly dyeing them into a dirty murky, gray that tethers and edges to turn onto the all-consuming black held in the middle of Khaslana's empty, empty eyes.

The time on his phone marks four thirty-four in the morning of a date with no relevance to the story at hand in the Month of Freedom in big, bold white numbers. It changes to four thirty-five before the screen turns off on its own.

The painting is nowhere near done.

Khaslana had left once the clock marked eight. Time come notice by the astringent sound of his alarm phone. It had gone off like a gunshot through the dead silence that had befallen onto the art studio. Mydei had startled, a spasm of his hand around the brush, but he hadn't flinched. Neither did Khaslana, who only blinked hard, as if awakened from a long, long slumber —though he did not look any less distant than he did before.

He had settled the painting brush onto the table at his side with a strangely harsh *'clack'* whose echo had drowned over the sound of the still-going alarm that Khaslana had yet to turn off, leaving it to rang and rang, rang and rang, rang and rang.

A whole minute rang and rang before it died on its own.

The silence that followed was sharp.

“I can stay a little longer.” Khaslana had said, quietly, though not kindly. Words only heard, maybe, because there was no wind to steal them away. *“If you want.”*

Mydei had wanted. Instead, recognizing shifting waters, he answered, *“It’s late.”*

“I don’t have anywhere to go.”

The blood stained and swept over the delicate fabric of the purple glove in his hand, darkening it, and the bleeding in his calf had stopped, but the dry reds still smeared white porcelain skin[1]. Kopopo the Third, from where he had come settle on the edge of the room, had hissed and hair arisen as Khaslana walked past him, messenger back slung on his side and a curt, *“Saturday. Same time.”*

Mydei had stayed.

Now, he yawns and his eyes burn.

He scrubs them until voids eating constellations form under his eyelids and melt onto his vision, swallowing bits and pieces of the painting sitting coldly in front of him as the tip of the brush nestled on his index and middle finger taps onto his knee. It doesn’t stain the fabric of the clothes there. The red on it has long dried and hardened each and every single strand.

There isn’t any paint dripping onto the floor.

He gazes at the expanse of the empty canvas in front of him yet again, as he has done countless of times already, like an alarm that rings and rangs and rungs over and over.

It hasn’t changed throughout all this time.

The lonely figure is still sitting in the middle of an art studio instead of standing up and disappearing into the darkness of the night. White hair falling like snow. One hand with a purple glove with butterflies and the other with coarse bandages. Bitten lips. A burning sun that threatens to

scorch it all into ash in a neck tucked under black, tight leather that bulges out the skin at the edges in temptation. White shoes with shoelaces undone that hover above the floor. Long legs and a calf with wounds painted with way too much care that bleeds and bleeds and threatens to flood and drown the low of the art studio in red, red, red.

But it’s not done.

It feels—dull, almost. Incomplete. *Wrong.*

Mydei’s eyes fix on empty doll eyes and marble expression. Devoid of any emotion, distant, fleeting, a perfect replica of its own but also not because something is missing, intrinsically, intimately, viscerally.

Something misses.

It’s the face, maybe. The expression. Mydei’s eyes sure can’t stop going back to it when he isn’t adding more red onto the floor.

The time on his phone reads six thirty-eight.

He twirls the brush on his fingers, once; presses it over the drying lump of white paint on the palette until the stiff strands crack and bend under the force, little specks of red dust scattering around. Kopopo the Third lets out a terribly loud yowl as Mydei lifts it over to the canvas once again.

And then, in one quick stroke, Mydei covers Khaslana's face—turns him into a stranger, a vessel with no eyes to see, no mouth to speak, a blank slate, and it is easy to realize then, the fact he didn’t draw a person to begin with, but merely a crumbling statue bleeding in the middle of an art studio.

He breathes and resists the urge to throw the painting in the trash.

Through the mist, through the fog, through the incompleteness and through the sudden itch, not to create in brushes and paint, but to destroy in reds and

linen, twitching and biting into the tips of his fingers, Mydei goes running the next evening.

It's not running *away*, but merely, running. Jogging. A moment of solicitude from the paint sticking under his nails and the figure of a statue undoing sat on a room taken in rhythmic steps, burning joints, and cold air hitting against his face; through pavement and cobblestone, through paths that twist like mazes, stores, little's *'uh, I didn't know that was there'* and through the dog in the fifth intersection that always jumps out the window when it sees him and chases him for ten streets straight ever since Mydei beat up his owner once[2].

It's grounding. Exerting. Maybe even cathartic. Thoughts and emotions checked, sharpened and put away in the same way a hunter would put away his arrows. Swimming against the current that laps and shifts around the oddity that is Khaslana.

In the distance, the red light on top of The Irontomb flashes once, against the oranges and yellows that paint the sky as the moon comes up, it looks like a second sun—A man-made one, that is, surrounded by the shiny blacks and grays of metal and wires. The sarcophagus of technology and logic defiled by arts and emotions.

There's a second of pause, a second of contemplation edging on hesitation, strange, maybe, for someone like him, but, present, nevertheless. Though, is to be expected, he thinks, when haunted by a ghost. Still, a man does not choose what he feels, but he can sure choose how to face it, whether to be controlled, heart dictated; whether to escape them, soul trembling.

Mydei chooses neither, of course. He squares up shoulders, raises his chin, and turns in its direction.

It takes a while, maybe, maybe not. It doesn't matter much. His feet still going on that rhythmic *plam, plam, plam* against cobblestone and rock as he jogs over.

He finds an old bending machine nestled like a mirror in between streets and when he tries to get a can of apple juice, what falls is the one next to it.

It doesn’t have a label, just a pink liquid that looks radioactive but tastes surprisingly good. It’s the last one, and the machine looks abandoned, so it is probably both the first and last time Mydei ever gets to taste it. A romanticist would sing for the fleeting joys lost, Mydei simply tips it back, throws it in a trashcan and licks his teeth with the aftertaste as he reaches The Irontomb.

The man at the reception doesn’t look up from the newspaper on his desk as Mydei walks inside, one hand tapping incessantly at the table. To his left, a couple of pamphlets with bright blues and greens read in bold red letters and the most egregious font he has ever laid eyes upon, ‘*Join the competition!’*

Oh, right.

“Next,” Khaslana had said, *“You will say you are going to win that stupid art competition on The Irontomb with me as your model.”*

Oh,

Right.

Mydei grabs one of the egregious colored pamphlets.

“Six letters,” The man at the reception says, without looking up at him, *“Maestro.”*

Mydei blinks, egregious colored pamphlet in his hand, and peers down onto the paper. Ah, a crossword. “Teacher.”

The man at the reception writes it down before his face scrunches. “Those are seven.” He twirls the pencil and starts erasing as he asks, “Gonna join?” But doesn’t wait for an answer before he pads around on the table for a clipboard, not looking from the crossword. He lets it fall onto the reception desk with a loud *‘blam!’*, “Five letters. Subsided.”

“Maybe.”

“What does that have to do with subsided?”

“Just lend me the pencil.”

“No.”

Mydei lets out a bland, “Mm.”

A sigh and, reluctantly, the man at the reception gives him the one he has. It’s all chewed up. His fingers drum against the table as he mutters words to himself, and Mydei peers down onto the names written on it. He knows some, others don’t, faintly, he registers the *Polyxia* in elegant calligraphy. Hm, good to know she’s giving it a try again.

He writes his name underneath.

“Remember to have fun or whatever. Don’t feel obliged to participate. There’s always next year. You know the rest. Subside. Abate?” He mutters to himself once he gets back his pencil. Mydei gets a glimpse of him sighing and abating as he takes his phone to look it up while he turns onto the corner.

His steps are firm as he walks towards the end hall on the west wing, through old brushstrokes and images of destruction, past people chatting and pointing to a piece or another, past a girl sitting in front of *Goldweaver’s Last Bath* with an empty document that merely reads *‘Art Analysis’* in a laptop scrolling through her phone, and an Antikytheran looking at *Calculation 03*[3]. It's surprisingly full for it to be a Tuesday evening, but it isn’t crowded either. Mydei, drenched in sweat, with his black shorts and loose, red sleeveless shirt, sticks out like a sore thumb—it’s a good thing, then, the fact he has never cared about stupid inanities like that.

Thus Burns the Dawn is just the same as he remembers from all those months ago. The breathtaking picture of a crumbling statue weeping gold in a somber mix of blues.

It’s strange, but firm, the sudden sensation that strikes him when his eyes set onto golden ones, the knowledge that the being in the linen is as much as it is Khaslana as it isn’t. The traces, the factions, the face, the eyes, the

emptiness. Empty, empty, empty. It’s all him. Undoubtedly so—But, whatever seems to be burning Khaslana up hasn’t extinguished just yet, no.

Because the hand Mydei held the day had met, faint, as it had been, had had a pulse[4].

He taps the egregious colored pamphlet in his other palm a couple of times, contemplating. *The end goal of the competition*, it writes, *is to create a collection of different pieces featuring the same model in some form.* And, so, it would be easy, he thinks, to create a collection of statues, a collection of dolls, a collection of corpses, with empty eyes and snow hair, but he’s no sculptor, neither is he a toy maker, and much less a mortician.

He’s a painter. A human that merely wants to paint another.

He didn't ask Khaslana to model for him just to bury him.

Time tick-tock-ticks and Saturday comes in the eternity it takes a person to blink. All too slow and all too sudden. Seconds slipping by like grains of sand scattered through the wind along the smell of drying paint, white linen and an unmoving figure left undone burning into the back of his eyelids—until time freezes once again when a knock-knock-knocking arises like bubbles popping underwater at one o’clock sharp.

Khaslana is much the same as last time, standing at the edge of the same wobbly stone step that gives way to his house with the same messenger bag, same sharp tongue, same deceptive doll eyes, same all-consuming allurement—except, he’s not terribly late today.

“No cats this time?” Mydei asks, skipping formalities he does not care about as he steps aside to let him pass.

Khaslana stares at him for a pause too long, searching, Mydei’s form reflecting on stagnated water instead of sinking in, before he replies, simply, “No cats this time.” And, without further preamble, walks inside his house.

Mydei lets out a sharp *‘cht’* clicked between closed teeth before Kopopo the Third lunges at Khaslana with bared fangs from where he is hidden under the couch as he closes the door. His cat lets out a loud cry but stays put, because he may be spoiled rotten but that certainly doesn’t mean Mydei raised him badly.

Khaslana hums. “Except that one.”

“Don’t be dramatic.”

“It’s easy for you to say,” Khaslana says, plainly, already walking to the art studio as if he owned the place. Jackass. “You are not the one at risk of getting your tendons sliced.”

It’s a cat, Mydei thinks of replying, but, frankly, Kopopo the Third can be a force to be reckoned with. The kind of creature rhapsodes of old would sing lo and about myths of strife about. Mydei wouldn’t have it any other way.

Instead, he asks, as he follows, “How’s your calf?”

Khaslana falters, for some reason.

“…Fine.”

There’s something weird in the way he says it. Kind of quiet, kind of hesitant, kind of small. Mydei’s brow furrows and his eyes trail down to Khaslana’s ankle. It is covered by the long legs of his white pants—Their length is not quite right, ends of cloth frayed and dirty where the back of his shoes step onto it with every single stride he takes[5].

His shoelaces are undone today too.

“It was a cat’s scratch,” Khaslana continues, reincorporating rather quickly. “Not a battle wound.” He says, lifting one end to let Mydei see the tree thin white lines, almost lost against his pale skin. The hand that lifts it, now without the coarse bandages, is also donned in similar little scars.

“Hm.”

“Mm.”

Khaslana doesn’t hesitate this time when crossing the threshold of the art studio, making a beeline directly to the canvas with his image propped on the easel. Mydei follows, again, coming to stand merely a breath away from him, scanning his face rather than the painting he knows is incomplete.

Khaslana's expression doesn’t even twitch. Instead, he lets out another little, “Mm.”

“I know.”

“Mm.”

“If you want to say something, say it.”

“No, I think you know.” Khaslana replies. Mydei feels the beginnings of a headache pulsing in the space between his eyes. It only grows when Khaslana adds, plainly, “I don’t like it one bit.”

“Neither do I.”

Khaslana’s eyes shift to him before his face does. The look in them is distant, as ever. “At least you are honest.” He mutters, before he catches onto the egregious colored pamphlet placed on the black table next to the easel. “What’s this?”

“A pamphlet.” Mydei says, dryly, unable to help himself.

“And you know what it reads?” He shoots back, brow furrowed, just barely, before his face falls onto the same blank muteness of always. The words don’t. “Or did the pretty colors on the cover merely caught your attention?”

Khaslana, it seems, is allergic to *not* having the last word. Mydei scoffs, and replies, not fully raising to the bait, “The composition on the cover is awful.”

“Ah, so it *was* the colors.”

“I’m an artist, in case you have forgotten.”

He mumbles something that sounds suspiciously like ‘*unfortunately*’ while he opens the egregious colored pamphlet[6]. Mydei leaves him at it, rounding the table to come sit on the stool. There’s already some water, a few brushes and tubes of paint propped on the surface. He uncaps the white one and places some of it on the palette.

“The end goal of the competition,” Khaslana reads out loud, words that Mydei already knows, at the same time he uncaps the orange paint. “Is for each intrepid artist to create a collection of different pieces featuring the same model in some form over a few months.”

The silence that follows is pointed. A little incredulous, perhaps even accusatory. Mydei can’t offer anything else, truly, nothing that the pamphlet has already said, and when it is made obvious he won’t elaborate, Khaslana says, “A collection.”

Mydei hums an affirmative.

“You want to make a collection.” Khaslana repeats, slowly, as if talking to someone stupid. Mydei’s eyebrow twitches. “With paintings of me. Do you need it spelled out?”

“Do you?”

“Do *I?”*

“You were the one that brought it up.” Mydei reminds him, reclining his elbow on the table as he turns to look up at him. “And I did say I like a challenge.”

Khaslana opens his mouth, closes it, and his eyes narrow. “I can’t tell if you are stupid, arrogant, or merely a very good liar.”

“None.”

“Stupid, then.” Khaslana huffs. Mydei contemplates, in complete seriousness, throwing the water in the porcelain cup at him. “The competition starts next Sunday, you know?” He says before Mydei can decide whether to do it or not. Dull eyes go to the egregious colored pamphlet to confirm the date before going back to him. “And you only have that.”

There are a couple of things Mydei could answer. All excuses. He’s not that type of man and, as such, he answers, “I still have two sessions.”

“And that’s enough?”

“That’s enough.”

The silence that follows is charged. Heavy. The beginnings of a sizzle as piercing gold eyes met deep blue ones—Broken abruptly by the loud *‘thud’* of Khaslana letting the messenger bag fall crudely onto the floor, right next to the table. The force makes the tubes of paint shake and brushstroke roll and fall onto the floor.

“How do you want me?”

Mydei thinks about it. “Same as last time.”

Khaslana’s head tilts, movement reminiscent of a haunted doll. Mydei tries to cut the comparison short to no avail.

“You are going to try finish?”

“Why wouldn’t I?”

Khaslana doesn’t answer that, instead, he turns to the painting and asks, “Have you ever heard of Icarus?”

“Are you the sun, now?”

The look that crosses Khaslana’s face is weird and, before he speaks, a small sound escapes him. It sounds like a crow’s cry, like someone who doesn’t remember how quite to laugh.

“Maybe.”

“I don’t have any wings.”

Neither does he need them.

“Yes,” Khaslana replies. “I can see that.”

He goes to the stool in front of the easel without further word. Mydei bends down to pick up the brush that fell. Once he straightens, is to see Khaslana already sitting down, crossed legs and elbow on his knee as he rests his cheek on his palm, positioned as to not look directly at Mydei as he paints. It’s a perfect copy of his position on the canvas.

Except, that he swapped both the leg he crossed and the arm propped on his elbow.

“Are you doing it on purpose?”

His tone is monotone when he answers, “Doing what on purpose?”

He absolutely is.

“The vase in your living room is fake, by the way.” It’s what Khaslana says in lieu of a farewell when the clock hits eight once again, already disappearing past the corner of the art studio.

His head feels as if it is underwater, fuzzy and groggy, and so it takes a second for the words to reach Mydei, another before their meaning dawns on him, and yet another before he musters the force to settle the palette with whites that, at some point, have started to resemble more porcelain instead of skin, aside.

It’s hard, surprisingly so, to set foot outside the room, away from the painting—It’s better, than last time, much better, but still nowhere near *done*—But he still manages to catch up to Khaslana just as a pale hand closes around knob of the door that gives way to the exit with a bland, “What?”

Khaslana turns to him, “That vase,” He repeats, pointing at the red vase with golden accents picturing an image of the last King of Castrum Kremnos placed on the coffee table. Kopopo the Third immediately goes to sit next to it, ears lowered. “Is fake.”

One of Mydei’s eyebrows raises and says, dryly, “Really.”

“Really.” Khaslana replies, just as dryly. “It’s a good imitation, though.”

Mydei would be more inclined to believe him were his low, monotonous tone not suggest that he believes Mydei is being stupid, *again*, and were it not to have been one of his mother’s past belongings. She had spent a small fortune for it in an auction, and she had never been one to be given cat for hare.

“And what would you know?”

Khaslana opens his mouth, before a spark of *something* crosses his face, fleeting, but terribly, unmistakably alive, and he closes his mouth. Mydei wants to see more, but it’s gone before he can even think of the ways he could portray it, replaced by an almost disinterested, “Just a hunch.”

“And you expect me to believe you based on a hunch?”

“Want to bet on it?”

Distantly, an alarm bell starts ringing on the back of Mydei’s mind, but he can’t bring himself to listen to it over the fire licking at the back of his throat. He can be terribly, terribly competitive, push come to shove. “If I win?”

“I give you one more session.”

Tempting, but, “Do I look stupid?” He asks and immediately continues before Khaslana can answer, “I’m not falling for your poorly laid trap. I am not betting the last session.”

“I wasn’t asking you to.”

Mydei scoffs. “What do you get if I lose then?”

Khaslana’s head tilts.

“What do I get?”

Incomplete brushstrokes and rotting linen can’t even possibly begin to fathom how infuriating this man can be.

“I will cook you something.”

“Why in the hell would I want something you cooked?”

Mydei clicks his tongue and raises his chin, “I’m a very good cook.”

“You also said you could draw people pretty well.”

“Tomorrow,” Mydei bites instead of delving into that discussion again. Words and proclamations of could’s and can’s fall flat if he can’t prove them. It seems Khaslana knows this fact as well as he does, seems he’s keen to dig and dig deeper into it until a bruise forms, breaks and bleeds. “Nine in the morning, I will be waiting with the vase. Don’t be late.”

“Great,” Khaslana says. He turns the knob and pushes the door open. A wave of cold air rushes into the house as he does so, pushing unruly locks of white hair back. The dark, uncaring blacks of the night threaten to swallow him without a trace, leaving behind only soon fading memories. “It’s a date then.”

His exit would be a perfect recreation of an unfinished piece of a statue stepping out a room found amidst the smell of paper, wood and paint of an art store hanging on a cloth hanger like a dead man—were Mydei not see him place his feet on the wobbly stone step, stumble, and almost fall face first on the ground.

Oh, yeah, Mydei thinks with some amusement, he should fix it. It’s been loose for a while now.

Chapter End Notes

FOOTNOTES

1. There has been a moment of clarity before a brush dripping red raised where Mydei had set it aside to get the dusty old first kit-aid shoved away in some corner of his bathroom. Khaslana's low "leave it" had been harsh and when Mydei had turned, it was to be met with the abyss looking up at him on derisive challenge. Mydei, not one to lose, had stayed—but, looking back, though, Mydei doubts there even was a way to win and he wonders if Khaslana knew. He doubts it, for some reason.Back

2. Sometimes, you just try to mug the wrong people, you know? Happens to the best of us—But was it his fault? No! How was Head Crusher 3000's owner supposed to know that Mydei was the type of guy to bring his fists to a gunfight and win?Back

3. He thinks about it, sometimes. A board duster in this pocket. But Nous, shameful blood of his, wouldn't care about lost knowledge—because they already know it.Back

4. It's a terribly simple fact, terribly easy to forget.Back

5. He could get it fixed, quite easily, but Aglaea is a busy, busy woman, and Khaslana is of the opinion she shouldn't waste the little free time she has on something as worthless as this. Not for him.Back

6. Once the session comes to an end and Khaslana leaves like smoke in the wind, Mydei will find the egregious colored pamphlet crumpled and thrown into the little plastic trashcan shoved in one corner of the art studio, hidden under empty tubes of paint.Back

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Psst, hey guys, psst, guys, over here, I don't think this is going to be only five chapters at all. The first three sessions were supposed to be one very long chapter and the rest of sessions another before the final chapter but, guys, that's not gonna happen. I calculate about seven or eight.

In other news, though, I had a fucking blast writting session two. Their bickering is so fun to write fr, and, to anyone who might concern, Head Crusher 3000 is a tiny little poodle that bites like hell, named in honor for the little dog that chased me and my dog (who was about thrice his size! like, girl, stop hiding between my legs and fight back! bark back!) for one steet when I was taking her out on a stroll.

Chapter 4: Calm before the storm

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Question, where does humanity lie?

On the middle of the seventh street of the tenth avenue of a place you don't need to know the name of, in between the house of a man who only ever does cups without handles and teapots without spouts and the residence of kind old woman who bakes really nice cookies and most definitely killed her last three husbands; unassumingly enough, in warm terracotta reds and a wobbly step, Mydei's home rests.

It can't be described as a cozy little thing for the sake of flowery descriptions, for it is not exactly little. It's certainly no palace, for he is no prince, and he has never had any intention nor wish to be someone else other than simply Mydeimos, Son of Gorgo. But it is big enough that he knows she would have undoubtedly asked if it wasn't too big for only him and Kopopo the Third.

Solitude is no thing he struggles with. Yet, far away from the strife filled soil that had watched him be born, bleed and grow, far from the sharp vowels of his native tongue, far from all the people who he would go to war for, to her, and only to her, he would have admitted that those first months were—rough.

Lonely.

Mydei had endured, of course, a battle well won. He had stood with the temper of a warrior and the patience of a lion and, like water eroding rock, little by little, he quenched and conquered his unrest. He had come to know all the strange, strange idiosyncrasies this town has to offer, the nook and crannies, the streets and stories and, little by little, he had come to make this house a home.

It was built on top of a graveyard—or, at least, that's what the kids playing along in the street like to tell everybody they might come across between laughter, scrapped knees, plastic balls, rope and chalk.

The day Mydei moved in, he remembers, they all had trailed after him like little ducks in a pond as he carried box after box from the back of his car to his new house. They told him that everyone around here walked on top of the dead, that the bricks of the houses were made out of tablets, and the soil at the bottom of the ravine at the other side of the block was filled with the bones of people that nobody loved and people that didn't eat their veggies[1].

It's the sort of tale that abounds and arises whenever you are, wherever you go. Mydei doesn't believe it, but the three *knock-knock-knocks* rattling at his bathroom door as he brushes his teeth make childish myths and boyish mirth come forth to the center of his mind.

People say you shouldn't let a ghost in even if it knocks. Mydei has already invited one into his house twice.

He opens the door.

There's nobody on the other side.

Because of course there wouldn't be.

The clock on his night table reads eight thirty-six in red numbers, about half an hour earlier, and another *knock, knock, knock* resonates in his room, like the *ba-thump-thump-thump's* of a bleeding heart heard from inside the organ. Mydei walks past his neatly made bed to the window that gives view into the street and slides the metal grid with a *clack, clack, clack* to the side before sticking his head out, mint foam still in his mouth.

He looks down. Khaslana looks up, his gloved hand raised to knock, knock, knock again on his door.

He bites onto the orange toothbrush and raises three of his fingers at him, indicating he will be down in three. Khaslana lifts his index back at him. Mydei's eyebrow ticks and then lifts all of his fingers, *now I will make it in five.*

Khaslana stares at him, completely unimpressed, which is ridiculous considering he was the one that started it.

Mydei grabs the toothbrush again and waits a second before pulling his head back inside; lingering long enough to watch as the kids, let loose from school thanks to the Month of Freedom, slowly get close to Khaslana, spinning tops and chalk in their tiny little hands, before jumping at him like cats reaching for a canary.

He then continues to get ready, slower than usual—*way* slower. Khaslana is not the only one who gets to be petty.

He finishes brushing his teeth, passes dental floss through the gaps between. His hair is still a little damp from the shower after the gym. It's not something he cares about, but he still takes the hair dryer from where it is buried way, way back in his closet and makes sure that it won't spit a bunch of dust at him before thoroughly drying his hair. It puffs up like a lion's mane before he fixes it. Then, very meticulously, and with very slow hands, he braids one long lock of hair and, very carefully, puts the golden aglet his mother gave him around it.

Once he's done and the clock in his night desk reads eight fifty, Mydei puts on his shoes, grabs the vase, tells Kopopo the Third very firmly not to destroy the house while he's out and steps outside, absentmindedly skipping the wobbly step[2].

"The ravine is here, see? Right here." One of the kids says, pointing at a blue line inside a square made with red chalk on the floor. Another two compete whose spinning tops can spin the longest at his back. "That's where you will end up if you don't eat your veggies."

“Mm.” Khaslana, crouched at his side, in that ever-present distant muteness of his, replies, “Even if I really don’t like them?”

“Even if you really don’t like them!”

“I will make sure to always finish them, then, just like you.”

The kid lets out a nervous, “Um, uh, yeah! Like me, ha, yes. I really like broccoli.” At the same time, a little girl pokes Khaslana in the shoulder with a, “Mister, mister, look, it’s you.”

And the wind holds its breath, and the world stills, for there, on the street floor, made in crude strikes of yellow and blue chalk and traces of innocence, a little doodle of Khaslana smiling came to be.

Khaslana goes so, so very quiet.

“My little brother ate the white one, so you are blond now.” The little girl continues as if she hadn’t made life out of a corpse with mere chalk.

She starts another drawing, this time of a bird.

And then a bee.

And then what it looks like Godzilla.

And, after the time it takes a bridge to burn, Khaslana asks, “...Is it done?”

“Eh?” The little girl turns away from her drawing to him. She looks down at her little doodle on the floor, to Khaslana, and back to the doodle. She places the little piece of yellow chalk under her chin and hums. “Mm, I guess I could add a dinosaur.” She nods. “What’s your favorite dinosaur?”

“Uh.” Khaslana lets out, looking so very fickle as one of his hands goes up to pick at his lips, “...Triceratops?”

The girl nods. “That’s a good one.” Before she starts drawing it next to him.

A second tricks by, or maybe two, maybe three; tears slipped through the cracks of the hands of the Veil of Night.

Khaslana turns to see Mydei, then, who had been lingering on the edges of the conversation with sharp eyes and vase in hand. His face is set in marble, empty well eyes swirling by, but Mydei still gets the impression he looks unsure all of a sudden. Aware, perhaps, of this, Khaslana says, a little harshly, a little hastily, “About time.”

Mydei lets out a simple *‘hmph’* instead of dignifying him with an answer. He walks up to him with firm steps, coming to stand next to his crouched form. He does greet back the kids when they all let out small *‘hi’s’* and *‘hello’s’* and *‘what’s that in your hand?’* and *‘what’s your favorite dinosaur, Mister Painter?’* at him.

To that last one, he replies, “Velociraptor.”

“No, it’s not.” The little girl shuts down immediately, making a little triangle on the dinosaur’s nose. She sounds as fed up as one of Mydei’s math teachers back in school. “You only say that because of the movie, but those were more Utahraptors rather than Velociraptors, though they really weren’t Utahraptors either. *Real* Velociraptors aren’t that big, nu-uh, they were more the size of chickens, and had feathers, too!” She shakes her head, takes a long look at Mydei and adds, “You look more like an Ankylosaurus type of guy.”

She doesn’t wait for Mydei to answer before she nods, satisfied with herself, and starts drawing what he assumes is the dinosaur she just said, right next to the other one.

“Sure.” He says nevertheless and turns to Khaslana. “Let’s go.”

Khaslana does a little shrug of shoulder. “I don’t think I want to go out with someone who doesn’t know what real velociraptors look like.”

All four kids’ heads snap up at his words.

“Go out?” The one who doesn’t eat their veggies asks.

“You two are friends?” A girl with a purple spinning top asks.

“They are.” A boy with a green spinning top pipes. “I heard my grandmother tell my mom that she has seen him,” He points at Khaslana, who merely blinks. “Come into Mydei’s house. *Twice.”*

“Twice?”

“Twice!”

“Why have you gone into his house *twice?”* The kid who doesn’t eat their veggies demands of Khaslana. “You don’t look like one of Mydei’s friends. I saw you *knock.”*

“So what if he knocks?”

“Mydei’s friends don’t knock. They just break into his home.”

“They don’t break in.” Mydei corrects. “They just have spare keys.”

All the kids ignore him.

“Aren’t those just *thiefs?”*

“It’s thieves.”

“They can’t be *thiefs.”* The boy with the green spinning top says, ignoring him again. “The kind old woman would have already stripped them down in the middle of the street and drenched them in gasoline.”

“Oh!” The little girl with chalks brightens. “You must be his muse!”

“What’s a muse?” The girl with the purple spinning top asks.

“A person you draw because they are very pretty.”

“I’m not.” Khaslana cuts in, still picking at his lips; whether he means he’s not a person or a muse, Mydei doesn’t know. Maybe both, maybe neither, maybe it doesn’t matter, because all the kids ignore him too.

“Does that mean Mydei likes him?”

The boy with the green spinning top spins in his direction and asks, “Does that mean you *like* him?” At the same time, the kid who doesn’t eat their veggies questions, point blank, “Does that mean you *kiss* him?”

“I don’t—”

The girl with the purple spinning top gasps. “Are you going out on a date?”

This time, they wait for him to speak with waited breath.

Mydei opens his mouth to answer.

And pauses.

The thing is, Khaslana had called it a date, yesterday night, in that monotonously deadpan way of his. Does that make it one? Ha, no, probably not, he concludes in the exact same breath, feeling absurd to even have contemplated the thought. There isn’t anything particularly romantic about how all this came to be. If anything, all this seems more of an errand.

It’s a small pause, barely second and a half, but it’s more than enough for all the kids to latch on like sharks smelling blood.

“It *is?”* The boy with the green spinning top asks.

“It is!” The girl with the purple spinning top sings.

“So you *do* kiss him.” The kid who doesn’t eat their veggies accuses him.

“Mom!” The little girl with chalks yells, picking up all her colors before running towards her house. All rest of her friends following suit. “Mom! The painter you like is going out on a date!”

And just like that, with a *‘slam!’* and a loud *‘he’s what!?’*, they are both left on their own in the middle of the street.

Mydei sighs, long-suffering, aware of the fact that, for the next few weeks, he will fall victim to prodding aunts, peeking grandmothers, nosy neighbors and invasive questions.

“Kids are so simple, uh.”

Mydei turns to Khaslana, just to find him staring at the image of his made on the street’s floor. One of his hands still *picks, picks, picks* at the edge of his thin rosy lips hard enough to draw blood. The vibrant reds would look nice smeared on them like lipstick, give them some shine, make him look more alive as much as it would make him look more dead.

His other hand hovers uncertainly over the little chalk doodle.

Mydei wonders, then, and “Khaslana.” He calls, for he is not one to disregard his wants.

The other blinks, long and paused. It takes a second for the words to dawn on him and another for him to make an inquisitive sound at the back of his throat, and even that is faint, as if he’s tethering on the edge of nonexistence. He doesn’t turn to see Mydei, eyes glued to the floor, and so he waits yet another second to make sure he’s here—as here as possible, either way. He doesn’t think Khaslana is ever fully present.

“Why did you start modeling?”

Khaslana doesn’t skip a beat. “To trick rich people into painting me and then robbing them blind.”

“Funny.”

“I know I am.”

The meaning is clear, albeit hidden, the glint of a fang peeking under closed lips.

None of your business.

Mydei is not the kind of man to disregard his wants, as he just said, but he's also the kind of man that knows when to strike and when to wait. The hunter who lets go too early of the arrow only scares off the prey. So, he plays along, this time, taps the vase and the soft clink of his nail against the clay resonates like the crack of a mirror in a world come to pause. "Is that why you fixated on this?"

"As if that thing were worth a dime."

"As far as you think."

"Mm."

He places his index finger on the face of the little chalk doodle and drags it to the side with such speed that the gravel must have sure burnt the pad of his finger. The strikes of yellow and blue chalk mix into green at the sides and the traces of innocence get lost. A man turned into a ghost, a blank slate, a haunting specter, a stranger met in dreams whose face you can never remember once you wake. Unreachable, unknowable, ephemeral.

The wind lets out a relieved breath when Khaslana ruins himself, rocking the leaves of the trees and the potted plants left on windows without glass as the world starts spinning once again.

As if a wrong had been rectified. Talanton's scale in equilibrium once again.

He stands up. There's a new tear on his lower lip, irregular and wobbly, burning red. It doesn't bleed and Mydei half wishes it did in a desire he recognizes as not entirely his.

"Shall we?" He asks with that little tilt of his, the one that makes him look like a haunted doll, and he doesn't wait for Mydei to answer before he starts to walk away. There's chalk sticking to the pads of his fingers.

Mydei watches him go, takes one last look at the little chalk doodle without a face, then to the two dinosaurs drawn next to it[3], and follows.

It’s always a little bit strange, a little bit jarring, and, maybe, a little bit wonderful, the sudden realization a part of the life of someone you know edges and tethers ever so closely with yours. A tiny gap, merely a breath away, that goes unnoticed like a shell washed ashore, burrowed under the sands and the clear waters until you go looking for them.

The place Khaslana takes him with all so silent, unsynchronized steps, is a small little building at the side of the road that Mydei always passes by without spearing a glance when going from the gym to his home and from his home to the gym, barely thirty minutes away from the street where he lives.

It’s a small little thing, as it has been said, one of those things that look like they were built two or three decades ago and went forgotten by the modernization of times. The little spots of greenery in front have gone unkempt. Green, rich vines with tiny little white flowers extend through the quaint yellow walls and twist all the way inside through the edges of the windows and the door in the entrance, which an old man with wrinkled hands and a newsboy cap opens for them. He greets Khaslana with surprisingly warm eyes before telling Mydei to make time and go into the dinner on the last floor because the food his wife cooks is to die for and it’s not like none of them are getting any younger.

It’s quiet inside. A little bit empty in the way these sorts of places always seem to be, but not deserted. There's a small jewelry shop with a girl clutching her mother’s hand in a death grip as a woman with a dozen piercings brings a needle up to her ear; a bank with a few children running outside while they wait for their parents to be done with their boring adult stuff; and a movie shop with hundreds of old VHS and DVD’S in plastic sheets lining the walls, the owner inside watches a movie in blacks and whites, in one of those televisions that look like a box, as a group of friends argue which movies to take.

The stairs he is led to are placed right next to an elevator and Khaslana off-handedly mentions that it always gets stuck between floors as he starts climbing upwards.

“You come here often?” Mydei asks, though it is less than a question as it is an observation.

“You could say that.” Khaslana replies. His steps aren’t nearly as silent, this time, a little *plap, plap* arising as the ends of his untied shoes slip out of his heels every time he lifts his feet to climb another step—until one of them slips out of completely as they reach the second floor, rolling a few stairs down. “Ah.”

It lands right next to Mydei, who was walking a couple of steps after him.

He shifts to hold the vase with only one hand before grabbing it. He cuts the rest of the distance with long strides and places the shoe in front of Khaslana without a word, careful not to crush any of the little white flowers growing on the white tiles there.

Khaslana blinks at him but, nevertheless, accepts the little action with ease. He crushes the heel tab as he wiggles and slips his foot inside, not bothering to tie his shoelaces—stiff, gray things, full of dust and mud whose aglets have broken with how many times he has stepped on them.

At the sight, Mydei says, simply, “Tie your shoe.”

“When we are there.”

Mydei doubts he will, for some reason.

Not really knowing why but not really worrying why, Mydei hands the vase to Khaslana with an unceremonial *‘here’* before bending down. He grabs the shoelaces, scraps the pointed bits and sharp pieces of plastic still clinging to one before pulling them.

“That’s too tight.” Khaslana complains.

“It’s not.”

“It is. You are going to cut the circulation of my foot.”

Mydei pulls them tighter, ignoring Khaslana dry *ouch*, and ties it in neat, quick motions, making a double knot to make sure they won't come loose. Once he's done, he taps the foot and says, "Give me the other one."

"I'm not a child." Khaslana replies, flatly, but still gives him his other foot, and Mydei repeats the process. When he finishes, he stands up, wipes the dust off his knees and takes the vase from Khaslana's hands, who lets out a quiet, "...Thanks."

"Hm."

They continue up one more floor, into a little shop with a sign at the top that reads in bold blacks against a brown background *'Ancient Knick-Knacks'* and a piece of paper taped to the glass door that reads, in all caps, *'NOT A CYBERCAFE ANYMORE. WE BEG OF YOU, STOP ASKING.'*[4]

A little golden bell at the top of the door chimes with a melodious little *'ding, ding'* as Khaslana pushes the door open into a place impregnated with the smell of paper and old coins. A bunch of wooden bookshelves filled with fragile-looking vases, elaborate clocks, wooden and metal statues, faded tapestry, obsidian knives, crystal eyes, jade jewelry and, true to its name, other knick-knacks, fill the space like pages of an old forgotten book.

At the far end, right in front of the door, like a book separator peeking under the paper, there lay a counter with a man inspecting pieces of chess carved out of marble and glass. His head lifts at the sound of the bell, and, upon settling eyes on Khaslana, he says, "I thought you weren't going to come today."

"Someone didn't hurry-up," Khaslana replies, walking up to him. "So, I ran late."

The sheer audacity of his. It is baffling, truly.

"Be nice, Khas." The man chastises, though, the words are more fond than anything. He throws Mydei an apologetic look. "What can I do for you

today? We got a few amenities of Ancient Kremnos that might interest you."

Mydei shakes his head, "I would like you to inspect a vase." He says, settling it on the counter in front of him, careful of the other knick-knacks laying about.

He perks up. "A vase?"

"It's fake." Khaslana deadpans.

"He *says* it is fake," Mydei explains, glaring at Khaslana through the corner of his eye. "But I am not inclined to believe a supposition based on a mere hunch."

The man pauses.

"...A *hunch?"*

"We were hoping you could shed some light on this debacle," Khaslana adds, and it is a little strange, a little uncanny, to hear him talk without any scalding insults nor derisive glances—but not particularly bad. "Considering you are the only one who knows about treasure appraisal here, Theodoros."

A look of confusion passes through the man, Theodoros, that is quickly, almost immediately, replaced by one of realization, and he narrows his eyes up to Khaslana so hard his eyelids are practically closed.

Khaslana merely tilts his head.

"...Say, uh, sir?"

"Mydeimos—but just call me Mydei."

"Mydei." Theodoros nods, without taking his eyes for a single second out of Khaslana's expressionless face. "You didn't happen to bet anything over this, didn't you?"

“What.”

“Nothing. Nothing, don’t worry about it.” He coughs, sighs, a little long-suffering. He settles with deep, deep care the glass tower in his hand on the table, next to the queen, and turns to the vase. “Let’s check this little thing of yours.”

First things first, Theodoros starts by going over the details. He asks for the time period the vase is supposed to belong to, he asks what image it is supposed to be depicting, he asks what it was used for and a hundred dozen things more.

Then, after Mydei has had to text Ptolemy with a dozen questions because half of the things he got asked are stuff only he remembers, Theodoros finally starts to check the vase. He looks at the material it is made, the thickness of it, the cracks spreading along the surface, the image of the last King of Castrum Kremnos in the middle, the art style it was painted on, the paint it was used—and a bunch of yet another hundred dozen things Mydei doesn’t quite care to catch nor worry about, because Theodoros goes over with the motions of a man that is as good as his job as he is passionate.

Slow, meticulous, thorough and careful.

And also boring to watch.

Very boring to watch—As in, watching paint dry ought to be more fun.

A couple minutes pass before Khaslana drifts away, like a small ship that wasn’t anchored properly to the coast, up to a nearby shelf to pick at a little something that has caught his eye.

Mydei watches him, and, after a pause where consideration mixes with curiosity, he unties his own anchor and drifts to his side in a way that feels almost natural.

“What’s that?”

“A doll.” Khaslana answers, tilting it towards him. It’s a little wooden thing, with fiery red hair, blue flowers for eyes and a little wooden sword in her tiny hand. It evokes as much security as it does kindness. Safety. “One of the Holy Maidens. The Protector.”

Hm. Mydei turns to the shelf, only to see mirrors, clocks and a moon. “Weren’t there supposed to be the other two?”

Khaslana hums an affirmative.

“We have them. They just like to play hide-and-seek.” Theodoros pipes in, voice both muffled as it is echo-y as he sticks his head inside the vase. “Check between the knick-knacks, you might find them there.”

They both turn to look down at the Protector’s doll held in Khaslana's hand.

It’s kind of sad to let her remain on her own.

Wordlessly, they walk further into the maze of bookshelves and little knick-knacks, picking at this and shifting through that. A candelabra here, a quill there. They walk through ladles, sails and goblets; through candles, books and tablet stones; through rings, bracelets and hammers; through glimpses of lives gone by, stories witnessed by the stars, scattered through the winds. None of them really mean to fall into step with each other, but it happens either way. Quietly, silently, tethering on comfortably, tethering on mundane.

The second doll, the Oracle, a little doll whose fiery red hair covers her flower eyes and evokes gentleness and calm, but the exact same kindness as the Protector—that one, they find hiding in between rolls of old, yellow parchments describing constellations.

Khaslana takes it with the same hand that holds the Protector, and then grabs a sword with a thin blade and an intricate blue handle lying on the shelf above the shelf of the parchments.

“This shouldn’t be placed with the rest of kremonan weapons.”

No, it shouldn’t. Kremonan swords are robust in nature, made with a thick blade and simple handles. A weapon is made to kill and die by, not parade around. On the battlefield, gems and elegance hold no value over blood. Though, on the rare occasions pretentiousness and decorations were valued, like in ceremonies, the colors used would either be red or orange, not blue. Judging by the looks of it, the sword in Khaslana’s hand “It’s from the Sky People.”

“Oh.”

Mydei's eyes shift to Khaslana's hand around the sword’s handle, and asks, “You know how to use it?”

“What gave it away?”

“The way you hold it.”

Khaslana looks down at the sword, the position he has placed it. “There are some habits you can’t really get rid of, uh.” He muses, more to himself, and twirls it around with a dexterous hand. “I did fencing for a little while.”

“Fencing?”

He nods, lets out a dry, “On guard," as he brings the hand holding the little dolls behind his back and the sword up, before, lightly, fleetingly, poking Mydei’s chest with the end of the blade, right where his heart beats[5].

Mydei’s eyebrow lifts, amused, despite himself.

He grabs one of the other swords laid on the shelf and mirrors Khaslana’s action, but the other takes a step back, and Mydei misses.

“You suck.”

“I wasn’t even trying.” Mydei replies and repeats the action. This time, Khaslana brings the sword up, and a small little *‘clink!’* resonates as the metal of the swords meet.

For a second, something close to mirth swirls in Khaslana’s empty eyes without light.

“Mm. Still not trying?”

“Not one bit.”

A *clink, clink, clink* echoes and twists between the bookshelves of the store like smoke from a candle, surprisingly light, surprisingly gentle, for a clash of blades. But, maybe, that is to be expected. Both of their movements are light, small, and quiet, a little step forwards, a little step back, as Mydei attacks, *clink, clink, clink*, and Khaslana defends, *clink, clink, clink.*

Until a chastising *‘stop playing with the swords’* arises through the wooden bookshelves and both of them hastily place the swords back in place and all but dart to a far, far away shelf, away from the swords—as if they weren’t the only ones in the store.

The last doll, the Teacher, the guiding, soothing presence, with always the same kindness as the others, is inside a black teapot filled with dry, golden flowers shaped like butterflies. Khaslana takes it out with careful hands and places it, along the other two dolls, next to the teapot.

A big picture window rests on the far, far end of the hall, nestled in between the shelves like a secret whispered at night, letting green vines and little white flowers extend through the walls as the gentle rays of the morning sun filter into all the nooks and crannies and little knick-knacks of the store.

Mydei stares.

Khaslana looks impossibly, breathtakingly warm.

The filtering light makes Khaslana come to be shaded with oranges and yellows instead of the usual reds and golds he always thinks about when he sees Khaslana. It makes it easy to see that his hair is the same shade of white as the little flowers scattering about behind him, and his hands are gentle like the strokes of a brush against linen as he brings the little dolls together once again.

It’s all so very mundane, and, so, there’s a moment, a small little tender moment, held between bookshelves lined like pages of a book, where Mydei looks at Khaslana and doesn’t think of marble and porcelain nor statues and dolls, and much less corpses, because Khaslana looks painstakingly alive, if a little bit sad, a little bit lonely.

His fingers twitch and itch like never before. He half thinks the soft skin under his nails breaks and bleeds paint with the sheer, mere need that swells on him like water on a well.

I want, he thinks, *I want, I want, I want.*

“You are staring.” Khaslana mutters, a little quiet, a little weird.

“I can’t look away.” Mydei admits, freely, shamelessly. What’s the use of denying one’s desires, either way?

“Hm? What’s with you?”

“I don’t know.” Mydei exhales out and he wonders why he suddenly feels so out of breath. “It’s just that I found that I really want to paint you.”

Khaslana tilts his head, and turns to him, and there’s a moment, a small little tender moment, held between bookshelves lined like pages of a book, where Mydei looks at Khaslana and he almost looks human.

Almost[6].

His eyes are so terribly empty, still.

“It is fake.”

At his back, Khaslana lets out a cough.

Mydei’s eyebrow twitches.

“...Is that so?”

“Without a doubt.” Theodoros replies and Mydei doesn’t know whether he’s just rubbing salt in the wound at this point. “According to what you told me, this vase is supposed to come from the Golden Era of the Last King, and although the technique used to represent him is definitely of that era. The forging, the material, and shape of the vase are completely different.” He points at a picture of a vase in a book bigger than Mydei’s head settled on the counter. “See, vases of that era…”

Theodoros goes over step by step, pointing inaccuracies and little details, to the grand conclusion that—yes, Khaslana was right.

Infuriatingly right.

It’s a bit jarring, the knowledge that his mother was tricked, once upon a time. Though, looking back, he supposes it is the kind of story she would laugh and share about over lunch—right after beating the scammer half to death and taking back all of her money’s worth.

Maybe Mydei should do it in her stead.

“By the way, Khaslana,” Theodoros says, just, off-handedly, “Miss Demetria came by yesterday, said she found yet another batch of relics while she terrorised the tomatoes in her garden. Could you give it a look?”

“Sure.”

Mydei’s brain comes to a halt.

He turns to Khaslana.

“You work here?”

“I do.”

Mydei lets out a deep, deep breath and looks at the vase.

Theodoros gives him an apologetic look and a comforting, “He doesn’t. He just comes to help sometimes.” That, he realizes, isn’t comforting at all and instead offers him a discount on any knick-knack he might want.

A weight settles on the counter, next to him, and when he looks to Khaslana is to find him already looking back at him.

He tilts his head.

“I will see you on Saturday.”

What a prick.

“He’s painting you. You are letting him paint you.”

“Don’t give me that.”

“I thought you stopped—”

“That *I* stopped?”

“That’s not—I just worry—”

“Don’t.”

“Khas—”

“*Don’t.*”

“Khaslana!”

“...”

“Khaslana, please—”

“It will be fine.”

“...You always say that.”

Sometimes, most times, Theodoros thinks, Khaslana is like cracked glass just begging to be broken once and for all.

Chapter End Notes

FOOTNOTES

1. They had also told him things along the likes of the mother of the cousin of his sister said that the friend of the nephew of his great-great-great grandfather, that wasn't pretty great despite having three great on his name, said that the youngest son of the friend of the woman of the store at the corner of the street was a 'word-that-my-mom-told-me-not-to-say' and Mydei, come aware of all the dirt of people he didn't even know nor care of, had been hammered with questions after. When he told them he was from Castrum Kremnos, they all asked if he had any swords before starting searching for them through his boxes anyway. Back

2. He keeps saying he should fix that, but Mydei has adapted it into habit with a familiarity that suggests he probably won't until he falls and loses a few teeth on the way down. Back

3. The rain will wipe them all out, either way, like sand castles next to the shore. The little girl with chalks is always a little bit sad when that happens, but it also means she never runs out of space to draw, and that's pretty neat. Ah, isn't it wonderful? To create in spite of destruction? Back

4. His pleas go unheard, of course, because people like to think they are just so damn funny. Khaslana says he should just take the paper off, Theodoros replies that it's not him putting it up anymore. Back

5. Oh, and one wonders, one wonders! One simply has to wonder! If Mnestia was sly enough to tell Cupid to strike at that very same moment! Back

6. It's always 'almost' with Khaslana, you see. Back

I wonder if you guys think I paint with the way I write this, I actually don't, lol, last time I tried I was told my palm trees looked like Ferb, from Phineas and Ferb, the worst part is that they were right, jaja. I did, however, take an optative palontology curse last semester in uni with a lic that would deduct points if I didn't know his favorite dinosour (It's the Baryonyx) which was pretty fun. Yes, I also had a dinosour phase when I was little, thank you for noticing. I used to be able to tell you anything about the T-rex. Nowadays, my favorite is the little chicken that could kill you that we call the Velociraptor, because I am basic. It used to be the Dilophosaurus but then I learned it couldn't actually throw venom nor do the little puff! thing it does in Jurassic Park and I was fr heartbroken,,,, just you wait till I get you Steven Spielberg for tricking me that way, just you wait.

I changed the titles of the chapters!! I wasn't fully satisfied with them before, and thank you all for the kind comments!! I don't reply much, mostly because I'm shy, but I read them all! I'm glad you are liking it (and the footnotes too!), and I hope you all keep enjoying :D!

Chapter 5: Sink! Sink! Sink!

Chapter Notes

Trigger warning: Kind of (?) graphic depictions of (imagined) violence, though nothing bad actually happens to Khaslana. I don't go into that much detail, but there's mentions of Mydei wanting (curse influence) to slice Khaslana's chest open and, uh, stick his hands to check if there's something there. Better be safe than sorry, nevertheless, so if you don't want to read it, once you reach the sentence "The metal of the sharp, sharp scissors shines under the yellow light" skip all the way until a chorus of 'I want, I want, I want' in bold.

Also, emetophobia, if you don't want to read that, just skip one paragraph once you read 'Mydei's stomach lurches'

This all sounds very omnious but don't worry guys, the fluff tag isn't there for decoration.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The answer is simple, of course.

The strangest of sensations comes to befall over Mydei's house as his last session with a statue fast approaches. Little by little, day by day, as slowly as eroding marble, decaying linen, as if everything tilted ever so slightly to the **right** to dissimulate the fact the world turned upside down.

Did

you

know?

Time tock-tick-tock-*tock-tock-tock-tocks* like grind-grind-grinding rock, heavy, slow and appallingly grating. The dust gets under his tongue, into his tear ducts and burns all the way into the back of his retinas—and when Saturday comes, ever so slow, and the always punctual three *knock, knock, knocks* dig into the terracotta bricks like cavity in a tooth, this time, they are ever so close to striking nerve.

They say Strife's brats are terribly prone to madness.

The red, red, red of the setting sun mixes at the far away edges with the last vestiges of blue from the day, like watercolors running down a page, like blood dyeing water. Yet the hands of the clock have barely reached three thirty-three. A sunset come to be far too early; as if the ever arrogant Eye of Twilight was willing to yield time of his domain to the Veil of Night just to turn a blind eye to the silhouette of the Hand of Shadow hiding beneath the folds of time's dress as it looms over the horizon.

Khaslana's face is set in marble, but his lips are picked bloody raw.

He's much the same as last time, and the last time before that, standing at the edge of the same wobbly stone step that gives way to his house with the same gloved hand, same empty, empty, empty, doll eyes, same all-consuming, all-destructive allurement.

Unmoving, unchanging, eternally.

He's all so, so still, all so empty, at the edge of Mydei's house. His breathing is slow, his blink nonexistent, and his face doesn't change. Expressionless features carved out of marble.

He doesn't offer anything, this time. No witty remarks, no cat hurting about, not even an explanation as to why he's so terribly late—or maybe there are, all at once, but all the words he said were stolen by the wind, gone before he could be heard.

It's strange.

A second passes, and then a breath, not from Khaslana, and he says, or more like snaps, really.

“Are you going to let me in, or what?”

What?

Mydei shakes his head, confused, willing for the static and the dust to leave the deep crevices of his mind, and he steps aside. Khaslana walks in with steps so silent one might wonder if he’s actually walking instead of floating as he makes his way into the art studio without even waiting for the door to be shut.

His shoelaces are undone today, too.

Mydei says, “I told you to tie them.”

Khaslana doesn’t answer.

His brow furrows.

“...Khaslana.” Mydei calls, firmly. Khaslana halts, just so, tilts his head like a haunted doll without looking back at him, and only when Mydei is certain the words will reach him. He—doubts, for a second, for some reason, but still, he asks, “Are you alright?”

Khaslana doesn’t answer.

“Khaslana.”

He calls again.

Khaslana doesn’t answer.

He simply disappears around the corner of the art studio, into empty linen, stale brushes and dripping paint.

It’s much like talking to a ghost, in that regard—or a moving statue, perhaps.

And don’t you dare forget it.

Mydei sighs, shakes his head, again. His body feels as if submerged in water, eardrums about to burst under pressure, but he still closes the door shut.

It closes like a casket’s lid.

Kopopo the Third gets in between his legs as Mydei follows an apparition into his art studio, making him stumble a couple of steps, stopping him in his tracks for barely a second and a half.

“What’s with you today?” Mydei asks him, softly, comfortingly, soothingly. Kopopo the Third lets out a mewl, long and plaintive, and he bends down to pet him behind his ears. “It’s going to be alright.”

Another mewl. It tethers on desperate.

He has very well of an idea why. Waters lap at his throat and threaten to flood higher and higher, but Mydei has never been one to go down without a fight—and he never once thought painting Khaslana would be easy.

He always knew it was dangerous.

“Don’t worry, I know how to swim.” He tells Kopopo the Third, scratching at the spot under his little fuzzy chin he knows his cat adores, who lets out a purr. A little hesitant, a little dimmed, a little uncertain. “I won’t sink.”

Kopopo the Third follows after him, either way[1].

Khaslana has already come to stand right in front of the easel in the middle with the propped canvas with his image once Mydei enters the room. Silently, quietly, and it is hard to know whether to interpret his silence as disdain or contemplation.

It still doesn’t make Mydei nervous, he’s still ever so confident in his talent, but, for some reason, the silence makes the palms of his hands itch.

“I hate it.”

“What?”

“You heard me.”

Mydei isn’t sure what to answer, truth be told. Khaslana always gets as snippy as he gets snappy the second someone so much as thinks of painting him. But there’s something different, this time, a little bit more pointed, a little bit meaner.

“...Why?”

“I just do.”

Mm.

“It’s not finished yet.” Mydei reminds him.

“And will it ever?” Khaslana fires back, voice monotone.

He clicks his tongue.

“You talk as if I have already failed.”

“And you like failing is something that only happens to other people.”

“Ha! Only a fool would think they are above failure.” Mydei scoffs and raises his chin. Khaslana tilts his head. “But, say, what kind of warrior marches up to battle expecting nothing but defeat?”

Khaslana turns around. His empty eyes swirl and swirl by, like backwater on an empty well at night. Mydei can see his own reflection mirrored right back at him, as if he was seeing him right past him.

“And did the warrior forget to check the time?”

“No, I remember.”

“Three sessions,” it said.

“I am not coming back.”

A pause.

“I know.”

“Ever.” Khaslana bites as he edges and tethers to disappear like smoke from a burned bridge, like smoke from a cigarette, and, yet, in the little art room that nestles within Mydei’s life like a heart in a ribcage, he doesn’t disappear fast enough for him not to start to rot away his lungs. “You won’t ever see me again.”

What?

Mydei coughs.

“Why,” Another cough. The contractions of his chest feels like razor blades slicing through his ribs up to his throat. “Why not?”

Khaslana doesn’t answer. Instead, he asks, “How do you want me?”

Mydei’s jaw tightens. “Khaslana—”

“How?”

“*What’s* with you today?” He snaps. “You are more…” And he halts, not exactly sure how to describe it. His arms hover in the air as if that might be enough to replace the meaning, but, when it doesn’t, he huffs and shakes his head, almost in disbelief. “How do you say stuff like that and expect me not to ask?”

“I expect you to paint.”

“And that’s what I will do.”

“Get it over with already then.”

“I asked you a question,” Mydei says, firmly. “And I expect an answer.”

“I will leave.” Khaslana replies, and there’s something weird in the way he says it, kind of quiet, kind of harsh. Whether he means it as a threat or an answer, he isn’t sure, but it shuts Mydei up immediately. “So, hurry up, Mydeimos, time hangs upon us like a guillotine—How do you want me?”

Mydei thinks about it.

“Same as last time?” The other asks.

“No.”

Khaslana’s fingers jerk, and, very pointedly, he does not look at the painting.

“Finally decided to throw that thing away, uh.”

Mydei’s eyebrow lifts. “And when did I ever say that?” He huffs, and when Khaslana doesn’t answer, he adds, “The pose you choose is clearly not working for me. I think it’s better to tackle this from a different angle.”

“And here I thought you were the kind of person to just bullhead through it.”

I will show you bullheadedness, jackass, a part of Mydei itches to scoff. He clicks his tongue instead, “Don’t change the subject.”

“Ha… How do you want me then?”

“You choose.”

Khaslana doesn’t skip a beat. “And if I choose the same pose?”

“I am painting a person, not a statue.” Mydei answers, even though the words *are* **not** true—

A statue,
a picture caught in time,
a little porcelain doll to display about,
a corpse.

The words taste like a lie in his mouth, rotten candy, drilling cavities.

Don’t

you

forget.

He forces himself to continue, nevertheless, forces himself to breathe.

“I am sure you can think of another position.”

“You say it as if I were stupid.” He sighs, more to himself than to Mydei, and he walks towards his place in the middle of the room. It’s only then he realizes the other did not bring his little messenger bag with him this time.

The way Khaslana positions himself can not possibly be comfortable for him at all—In fact, it almost looks painful in nature. He sits right at the very edge of the stool, legs extended out, making the long edges of his dark blue gabardine fall onto the floor like tumbling cascades. He places both his hands on the leftover space behind, straining his arms to hold his weight and not slide down onto the floor. It makes his hollow chest pop out.

Glassed doll eyes track every move, every shift, and every last breath Mydei takes like a noose about to tighten as he grabs Khaslana’s unfinished painting from the easel with careful hands and places it gently next to a painting of a simple bowl of ripe pomegranates.

Mydei shakes his head—It feels full of nails. The sharp edges ripping and digging at the corners of his mind as they rattle and tremble with every single thought he has.

He continues, nevertheless.

In one of the corners of his art studio lies a wooden bookshelf covered in little dots of different colors. On its different shelves, a dozen little teacups without handles filled with crayons, pencils and pens, a palette knife, used brushes, scissors and paint-filled rags are scattered about. Mydei takes one

of the less dirty rags and one of the few empty canvases placed on top. It doesn’t smell new anymore.

Empty eyes bore into his back all the while.

Mydei doesn’t let it intimidate him. He places the empty canvas on the easel and the rag on the black table next to it with practiced ease before placing blues and whites onto the plastic palette.

He takes one of the brushes and turns to see the statue placed in his house.

Khaslana stops looking at him, then.

He throws his head back in a motion that seems almost crude, locks of snow hair fall below his shoulders as he goes to stare at the cracks across the ceiling that create grotesque shapes here and there.

The movement lowers the high black turtleneck he wears today down a little, exposing the beginnings of his Adam’s apple at the center of his throat along the edges of a bright golden sun[2].

He isn’t wearing a choker today.

Mydei swallows.

He lifts the brush up to the canvas, eyes still fixated on Khaslana’s neck. It stretches in an arc that lets him see a few lines of the faintest of blues extending like the ends of a river here and there. His skin is far too pale, is the thing, like the rest of him is. White, nearly translucent. The gold of the burning sun at the side contrasts nicely, but, hidden, as it is, is still not enough, just—not enough.

Artistically, the absence of the little black band is felt, damning, maddening, and Mydei thinks of adding colors like purple and yellow around his neck with his bare hands to compensate.

A drop of paint falls to the floor.

Time hangs upon them like a guillotine.

And it falls at eight o’clock.

The blade comes to notice by the astringent sound of Khaslana’s phone alarm. It rings and rings and rings like a drill through the cold marble quiet that has befallen the art studio—Yet, muffled, as it is, through the various folds of clothes, the sound seems ever so distant as Khaslana himself, as if the ear-bleeding screech of the ring and rang was nothing but tiny, tiny bubbles popping underwater.

Mydei doesn’t let go of the brush.

He can’t.

The painting on the easel is unfinished. All long shapes, sharp lines, and cold colors. It tethers, edges and flickers on a strange limbo between object and human, tilting slowly, ever so slowly, like a sinking boat, onto the latter.

But—

Time is the last thing he has.

Mydei breathes, breathes, and breathes again—but it doesn’t feel like any air is quite enough to fill his lungs.

He doesn’t understand.

He just doesn’t understand.

Why can’t he paint it?

He shifts his eyes away from the ever unfinished painting of Khaslana to the statue itself in the center of the room, just to find the depths of the black, black abyss boring into him already. Somehow, looking as if he’s seeing past him at the same time he’s boring into his very soul.

The painting brush, with its stiff strands of dried, faded reds[3], slips out of his fingers and clatters to the wooden floor with a deafening ‘clack, clack!’ that raises hauntingly above the ring and ring, ring and ring, ring and ring of

the alarm. It rolls all the way down to Khaslana, colliding and stopping against one of his untied shoes.

Khaslana's eyes flick down to it.

When he moves from his position, a faint crack of multiple vertebrae arises, and Mydei thinks of fissures spreading and chipping through marble. He bends down, like a puppet on strings, to pick it up. He then stands up. His phone rings and rings, rings and rings, and he makes his way towards Mydei.

Step

by

step

The brush is placed on the little black table at his side with a sharp 'clack' as the phone rings and rings, rings and rings, rings and rings, for the eternity it takes a person to die, before it quiets down.

Silence lingers like a cavity about to strike nerve.

In the time it takes a bridge to burn, Khaslana says,

"This is the worst one yet."

"It's not finished." Mydei replies. Repeats.

"I tried to warn you." Khaslana continues, digging and digging fingers into a bruise until it bleeds. "That there were easier ways to learn how to paint people."

"I *know—*"

"And it doesn't mean you are any good at it." He cuts in, cold as ice. The low yellow light of the art studio does nothing to warm his porcelain skin and his doll eyes flicker to the side, not quite looking at Mydei in the eye, as he adds. "Especially in regard to the portraits."

The words land like a rock in a motionless pond, shattering the tranquil surface like glass. It might have hit a fish and dyed the water red. The world stills and time holds its breath as a loud, steady *ba-thump, ba-thump, ba-thump* beats against his ears—for there is exactly only one portrait in Mydei's entire repertoire of work.

It is titled *For Gorgo.*

A portrait made for a late mother.

And, suddenly, Mydei is three again and picking up one of his mother's brushes for the first time; and he's fourteen and throwing all his brushes and canvases to the trash after her death; and he's sixteen and getting gifted a little box of watercolors by his friends; and he's seventeen walking away from home after his father, now mad with grief, tells him to either give up painting or go; and he's twenty-one moving out to Kremnos; and he's standing in the middle of an art room failing and failing to do a statue; and he's both, he's neither. He's everything and he's nothing, and he's sinking, sinking, sinking, deep underwater, not knowing how to swim from one moment to the next.

The wooden easel tumbles down to the floor along with the painting when Mydei slams Khaslana against the wooden bookshelf. Crayons, pencils and pens clatter to the ground as porcelain cups crash and crack and scatter in a million little pieces down to the floor. He's falling, and he's drowning, and he's sinking, and he's sinking, and he's sinking. All the while, Khaslana simply stands there.

Unmoving, unchanging, eternally.

He doesn't even bother looking at him.

Mydei thinks of beating him raw.

The idea is stark, electrifying, far too visceral and far, far too overactive for the situation at hand. It snaps him into realization at the same time it embraces him warmly like a second pair of teeth breaking and growing through his gums and in the space under his tongue.

He breathes.

It’s hard to, but he breathes.

Mydei’s anger—is a sharp thing, truth be told. The sort that doesn’t exactly go quiet but neither the sort that explodes and sweeps away everything in his path like a scorching sun. Controlled. The emotion flows, and he lets it, but he doesn’t let it drive him. Closed fists that leave a bruise or a dozen, maybe even a scar, always towards those who deserve it, but certainly not a corpse.

And he won’t start now.

He will.

He won’t.

The metal of the sharp, sharp scissors shines under the yellow light.

His hand tightens from where it is closed around the neck of Khaslana’s shirt; prickings of pain biting and arising from where his nails dig into his palm like teeth growing underneath his skin and he wonders if Khaslana’s own skin will yield like cloth under the blade or if it will chip like marble.

Both thoughts make his teeth, both sets, grind against each other, and he thinks he wants to drive the scissors into Khaslana’s neck and all the way down, down, down to his stomach. The combination of bloody red and porcelain skin would complement each other nicely, he thinks, or maybe it is gold paint that would extend in the place of red like dying nebulas above the constellations made by the little drops of paint in the floor of the art studio.

Or maybe nothing would come out.

Khaslana’s eyes are so, so empty.

Mydei wants to rip him open in half like a ripe pomegranate and shove his hands deep inside him just to see if there’s something inside him. He wants to slice Khaslana open all the way down to his stomach with rusty scissors

and stick his own head inside the wound just to see if he even has guts and lungs, a liver and a kidney, or if his eyes would only be met with nothing but an empty abyss filled with dust.

And he wants to paint him like that.

I want, Mydei thinks, fingers twitching, metal shining. Khaslana is all so distant still, ***I want, I want, I want.***

I want, I want, I want, I want, I want, I want, I want, I want—

—To see what other things whispers and rumours fail to say about him.

That's what drove him to wait for him on the skirts of a man-made pond in the first place, wasn't it?

Not the all-consuming, all-devouring, all-scorching allurement of a being made out of incomplete strokes and rotting linen. Not the mind and bloodshot eyes gripped with the obsession of a man willing to throw himself to the sea following a siren's song. Not the nail biting fear of a coward wishing to get rid of his obsession. But the simple sight of simple kindness gone unseen by artists that have forgotten they are no toy makers nor morticians.

Mydei lets go of the other's shirt to press his index and middle fingers at the side of Khaslana's neck, right in the center of the sun in his throat.

Ba-thump, goes his heart, *ba-thump*, *ba-thump.*

It didn't even pick up.

"You…" Khaslana breathes out.

His exhalation is warm against Mydei's wrist as his heart beats under his skin.

Mydei's stomach lurches—as if revolted by that fact.

The hand pressing gently above Khaslana's pulse flies to clamp around his mouth as Mydei runs away to avoid throwing up all over the floor. The heavy *thump, thump, thump* of his footsteps echo through the terracotta walls along the sound of the kitchen's door being slammed open, but both things are soon drowned by the gross, loud *splat* of bile mixed with half-digested chicken spreading through the metal sink like thick petroleum falling from his mouth.

He heaves, reaches, swallows, and breathes.

For a second, Mydei simply breathes.

The light of the kitchen flicks on with a quiet *'click.'*

Mydei breathes a couple of times more, sweat sliding down his face. He opens the water faucet and cleans his face, the coldness refreshing against his heated skin, before he rinses his mouth once to get rid of the taste lingering on the spaces where a second row of teeth used to be.

A minute passes.

Then two.

Then three.

Maybe even four.

"What are you?"

"...That which you see," He replies, quietly. "Is me."

He turns around. Khaslana lets his head fall like a man hanging from a noose.

"What I see?"

"Nothing more and nothing less." He says, and something about that answer angers him, for some reason, but before Mydei can answer, he adds, "And it seems what you see is nothing but defeat."

Mydei’s eyes narrow. “Defeat?”

“It means is your loss, Mydeimos.”

“Ha…” Mydei exhales, jaw tightening. There’s still fire licking at the back of his throat and ants biting at the tips of his fingertips—and every single of Khaslana’s words only serve to burn him hotter. “Fine. You win. I can’t paint you. That’s what you wanted to hear?”

“It’s what I knew I would.”

He doesn’t even sound resigned.

“*Would you stop,”* Mydei bites out, turning around and slamming open one of the cabinets to take out a notebook and a pen from in between the forks and the knives. *“Assuming you know how everything is going to be for once?”*

“What,” Khaslana starts, falters. “What are you even doing?”

“I’m drawing your stupid face.”

“...Come again?”

The sound of paper being ripped off is deafening. It even shuts up Kopopo’s the Third low hiss that Mydei hadn’t registered until now. “Here,” He says, sharply, walking up to Khaslana and extending what is probably the worst doodle that Mydei has ever made in his life; all scruffy lines and unflattering lines with a big *‘STUPID’* written and underlined under it. It’s simple, childish, and terribly petty—but he supposes is far better than smashing Khaslana’s head open against the counter. “This is how I see you.”

“...Did you hit your head on the way—?”

“I sure wish I did.”

“What.”

“Just grab it!”

Khaslana stares.

Mydei shakes the paper impatiently.

Khaslana’s head turns to the side, as if debating whether to just go, before it turns back to Mydei. Empty eyes flicker from his face, down to the paper, and to his face once again before a gloved hand, in almost hesitant motions, plucks the paper from Mydei’s fingers without once breaking eye contact with him.

There’s a pause before his eyes flicker down to the little doodle.

Humanity lies in mundanity.

And he laughs.

Khaslana laughs.

It’s not the quiet, refined laughter one might come to expect from someone like Khaslana, but a bright, loud thing, almost childish in its nature. The sort of sound that might very well light-up entire rooms with its presence even if there’s ash sticking to his tongue and cobwebs in his throat. He even does that little snort people always get embarrassed about—and Khaslana does too because one hand goes to cover his mouth once he lets it out.

Mydei’s heart feels as if it is about to burst out of his chest for some inexplicable, strange reason.

“This,” Khaslana says. There’s still remnants of laughter sticking into the corners of his tiny, tiny smile. “Might be your best work yet.”

“Yeah?” Mydei exhales, feeling as if he had just ran a marathon three times over and come out in first place. He clears his throat. “Yeah, well, I might

just present that at tomorrow's exposition, then." He says and attempts to take the little doodle back. Khaslana moves it out of reach. "Give it back."

"No." Khaslana replies, lifting it higher. Mydei comes to the horrifying realization he's a few centimeters shorter than the other. "You gave it to me, that means it's mine."

What a childish response. "Tsk, you are ridiculous."

"I am ridiculous? You are the one that decided to do something like this after…" The smile falls. "Whatever, just draw another one if you like it so much."

"You know what? Maybe I will." Mydei raises his chin.

Khaslana huffs. "Really, now." He says, not sounding as if he really believes him, as he turns around, doodle still in hand. "I suppose I might just drop in on the Irontomb's exhibition on Monday, then[4]."

Mydei watches him go, follows and stands at the edge of his home as Khaslana walks out the door without further word into a car with a green-haired man, who first inspects Khaslana head-to-toe and glowers at Mydei before driving off.

He closes the door. Then, he takes one step back, two, his heart thumps widely in his chest, laughter echoes in his ears and he all but runs back into the art studio. It's a mess of scattered paint, scattered crayons and broken cups but he couldn't care less about that right now.

Khaslana is alive.

Painstakingly, terrifyingly alive, with all the flaws and wonders that entails.

He doesn't bother reassembling the easel back up. He simply grabs a bunch of colors and a bunch of brushes before he kneels down to paint on the canvas right there on the floor, feeling much like a child playing with chalks, as he starts painting the image of Khaslana laughing right over a

statue. White skin blushed pink, white hair falling over his eyes, and his eyes are empty, empty, empty, still.

But,

Maybe that’s alright.

That’s alright.

The details of the image escape him. He doesn’t remember if Khaslana had any dimples or not, if his eyes crinkled at the sides, if his nose scrunched, if his teeth showed, *and if, and if, and if*—and it would be easy, frankly, to curse and hate the time-consuming nature of painting and drawing over the instant instance the snap of a photo provides.

But that’s the last thing on Mydei’s mind.

The things he doesn’t remember he simply fills with sentiments like yellows and oranges and warm, warm colors. It’s amazing, how every brush and every stroke and every pigment makes a picture slowly come together. There are butterflies coming out of his mouth with every breath he exhales and there are galaxies forming on the floor with every drop of paint that falls, and he’s having so, so much fun.

Because he likes painting.

He really, really likes painting.

His loss?

Ha!

Just you wait, Khaslana, just you wait.

Chapter End Notes

FOOTNOTES

1. He has plenty of trust in his owner, of course, but it is the strange entity that bleeds paint that he remains wary of. He is dan-ge-rous, like poisoned cheese he has seen little stupid mice fall for—Still, Kopopo the Third knows not everybody is as smart (and cute) as him; and he knows he's but a little cat, so he can't do much to stave off the water, but if his owner sinks, then down the well he goes too, no matter how much he might dislike bathing. Back

2. "The sun is set to die," Is what the Ruin Author had answered once Khaslana demanded to know why he wanted to paint him, dipping a brush into gold. "Billions of years from now, it will run out of hydrogen and it will collapse in on itself—But it won't go quietly. It will expand, and it will burn, and it will destroy everything close to it." Their eyes settled on his neck, on the tattoo he had got to commemorate the sister he lost. Under their gaze, Khaslana had wanted to dig his nails into it and rip it right off. "Much like your whole existence does, Khaslana. You only exist to burn." Back

3. Which is strange, because Mydei doesn't remember ever putting red on the palette. Back

4. Khaslana knows better than to want, and much less hope, but there's a tiny little part of him that needs to see what Mydei presents in that stupid art competition. Whether it be yet another empty stand, whether it be yet another grotesque rendition of his, he just—he just has to see it. Back

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EXTRA

Sometimes, most times, Khaslana is like cracked glass just pleading to be broken.

Theodoros can't help but worry, yet, knowful of the fact his friend won't listen to him, that day, he writes an e-mail starting with a polite *good morning, Professor Anaxa, I hope this message finds you well—* For he's too intimidated to write to one Miss Aglaea and, he figures, if

there’s someone Khaslana ought to listen to, it must be the professor he so much respects.

It’s a tad bit too formal, a tad bit too nerve wracking, and a tad bit too stupid to write to a professor with far more doctorates than years Theodoros has about an ex-student of his who will go model for a painter, but he does so, anyways, because someone has to reach out when Khaslana won’t—Yet he still all but begs him not to shoot him with his gun. Anaxa replies with a simple *‘thank you for letting me know, also, it’s Anaxagoras’* and no promises about the shooting thing.

That day, Anaxa sends a text to that problematic student of his, uncaring that the last he sent went unanswered, that reads *‘call me if you need anything’* and nothing else. Khaslana ignores him for the whole week. Yet, when the day of the awaited third session arrives, he texts back a deceptively unassuming *‘I should be out by eight’* followed by a direction that, should Mydei been a lesser man, a weaker one, it might well have carried a life.

He regrets it immediately.

He deletes the messages but Anaxa replies with a simple *‘I’ll be there’* and, suddenly, Khaslana is both terribly young and terribly stupid once again—sitting on Hyacine’s kitchen with paint sticking to his hair, blood under his nails and purple bruises on his neck, half-wishing he had gone limp under that artist’s grip. Because, then, Anaxa wouldn’t have had to pick him up at two in the morning from a deserted bus stop. Then, he wouldn’t be bothering Hyacine on the night before her thesis. Then, they both wouldn’t be wasting time on rotten, incomplete work.

Again.

He texts back a *‘sorry’* before putting his phone in his pocket. A couple of years older he may be but he doesn’t love himself even a little bit more than he didn’t used to before and he knocks on Mydei’s door.

Like glass begging to be broken.

Chapter 6: Land in sight

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Khaslana’s painting comes to completion much the same way the change of Saturday to Sunday comes, quiet and unceremonial as the twenty-three fifty-nine in his phone changes to a cero cero cero cero while Mydei gives one last feather-light brush against Khaslana’s lips. All bitten and picked bloody raw. An ugly sight one would rather leave out for the sake of beauty, and yet, painted with a gentleness that would make you think Mydei was trying to soothe the faint ardor that must accompany the little self-inflicted wounds.

There’s no big shift in the world as he does so. No big burst of energy nor light. Time doesn’t start to go backwards before going forwards and then backwards once again. Neither is there a small shift. A mirror doesn’t shatter, a bracelet of pearl beads doesn’t break, a can of sardines doesn’t explode, a thread doesn’t snap.

Mydei simply looks at the painting in that strange space of time after yesterday is done but tomorrow hasn’t come, brush raised high and stares at the strokes of paint that compose a man laughing along the tiny little dots of colors that fell here and there like constellations, and before another drop can fall, he nods and places the wooden brush in the ceramic cup without a handle with a quiet *‘splash’*.

And just like that, it is done.

His spine cracks with a bunch of little pops like plastic bubble wrap being stepped on as he stands up. He picks up the painting, careful not to touch the paint yet to dry, and puts it on the black table at his side. In familiar movements, he resembles back the easel, places Khaslana’s painting on it with care, and, after one last look and a prominent sense of victory, he flicks the light of the art studio off, closes the door and goes to his room.

In well-known motions, Mydei un-tucks the covers of his bed, takes off his shirt, but doesn't bother to change into a set of pajama pants as he lets himself fall onto the soft mattress with a groan of satisfaction.

A little weight settles on his back, and Mydei hisses when tiny little claws dig into him as his skin is kneaded. His muffled reprimand of *'stop that'* is dutifully noted but haughtily ignored until Kopopo the Third is satisfied by the now irritated hue of his skin and gives two circles before settling down. Like a tiny, silent protector.

Mydei sighs, a little fond, "You worry too much."

Kopopo the Third mewls. A little long-suffering. Mydei twists an arm behind his back and pets him once before closing his eyes.

He sleeps[1].

A solid, healthy lifestyle must require a man to know that rest is as important as working and training.

On Sundays, Mydei doesn't go to the gym, so when his internal clock honed through years upon years of routine and self-discipline wakes him up at exactly six in the morning, he lets his eyelids close again. He sleeps until the late, late hour of eight AM, not because he feels as if he particularly deserves it, but simply because he just feels like it—and sometimes that's all the reasoning a person needs.

Once he wakes up, he stretches, goes to the bathroom and down to the kitchen. One of the hinges of the door is busted from where he slammed it open yesterday night, Mydei realizes, and makes a note to fix it later[2]. He serves Kopopo the Third his food and some water, tells him not to sink a paw into it, and sighs when his cat sinks both paws as he cooks breakfast. Something simple, really, some eggs with beans and two fried bananas with cream and sugar. He doesn't drink coffee, so he makes himself a vegetable smoothie.

The strange, almost floaty sensation one gets after walking home after a concert or going to the movies late in the evening and coming out at night, waking through a mall that's coming to a close, fills Mydei as he goes to the motions of his routine, almost uncanny in its mundanity; but he doesn't let it unnerve him. He finishes breakfast, washes the dishes and the pan because if he doesn't do it now, he then gets lazy. Afterwards, he goes back up to the bathroom to take a warm shower.

There are dots of paint scattered through his skin like freckles.

He showers, changes and doesn't bother to dry his hair as he braids it. His mother would be livid. Throughout all this, the clock on his night table changes number by number from eight to nine. He's not in any real hurry. Though, it was said for contestants to be there at nine thirty, so he will have to take the car instead of walking. He will have to pass by an ATM machine too, because the parking lot of the plaza only ever accepts cash for their overpriced space—But it's either that or risking parking outside and having someone stealing your car or the police asking for a bribe if you don't want a fine.

The painting is right where he left it, and just the same as he left it. Mydei grabs it with careful hands and, right before he leaves, he takes one look at the other painting of Khaslana he left leaning on the wall.

The difference is stark, almost sad, the image of a figure sitting on a stool like a lonely doll left sitting on a shelf contrasted to the laughing man in his arms.

Maybe he will fix it, later, or maybe he won't. He certainly won't throw it away because that just seems unnecessarily cruel.

So, he leaves it there, in the art studio nestled in his life like a heart in a ribcage as he closes the door. He tells Kopopo the Third very firmly not to destroy the house while he's out and takes the keys of his car.

The plaza is as crowded as one would expect for a Sunday, families and friends and couples walking and laughing around lo and about, and it takes ten minutes for him to find a spot to park. Similarly, The Irontomb is

crowded and full of people with canvases under their arms, like sardines in a can about to explode. The ambient is loud, voices overlapping one over another. The air is hot, humid and sweaty with way too many elbows digging into sides and shoulders bumping into each other.

Mydei takes one step inside, takes it all in, and immediately steps out.

What a nightmare, he breathes, and promptly decides to wait outside for the line to go down instead. Whether he gives his piece now or later doesn't change much, maybe the chance to get a good spot in whatever place they shall put all the art.

But, that's alright, there's only one person Mydei is really looking forward to seeing his painting—and he isn't even coming in today.

A few more people are of the same idea as him, laying and waiting on the outskirts of The Irontomb, which makes it difficult to find a good spot to sit that isn't directly under the heated rays of the sun.

"Mydei?"

The call is soft, shy, almost lost in the hustle and bustle of the place. He stops walking, intent on maybe going to some cafe with air conditioning and coming back in an hour, and turns his head around in the direction of the voice, just to find a girl in a wheelchair under the shadow of a wall.

"Oh, Polyxia." He greets back, walking up to her. "It's good to see you. How have you been?"

Polyxia makes a motion for him to sit next to her, which Mydei complies with, laying the canvas on his lap. "Far better than last time, enough to—Oh, thank you." She giggles, taking some peanuts with salt and lemon from the little plastic bag Mydei tilts towards her in silent offering. He bought them from the haggard old man who throws tomatoes at the cathedral. "Enough to pick a brush without trembling."

Mydei smiles at her. "I'm glad to hear that. Who did you paint?"

“My sister.” She replies, taking the canvas reclined next to the wheel of her wheelchair and showing it to him. It’s a very pretty thing, gentle and elegant, showing a girl nearly identical to Polyxia tending with care to flowers in a garden in an array of watercolors. “She was the one who suggested that I participate.”

“A good suggestion—It’s beautiful.”

“Thank you.” Polyxia smiles, brimming with both shyness and pride. “What about you?”

Instead of answering, Mydei simply turns his painting over to her. Polyxia blinks, confused, before a look of realization passes through her face and she gapes. “Isn’t—Isn’t that Khaslana?”

“Mm.”

“That’s—That’s. Wasn’t it impossible?” Polyxia says, at a loss of words. She turns from the painting, to Mydei, to the painting and back to Mydei before blurting, “You don’t seem mad.” Before covering her mouth with a hand. “Ah, sorry, I didn’t mean… I just…”

“It’s fine, Polyxia.” He reassures her. Polyxia winces, nevertheless, so, he continues, “He is hard to paint, I won’t lie, and it certainly was,” He halts, searching for a word that might describe all that was and wasn’t with Khaslana, but coming up short, he settles on a rather lackluster, “Challenging.”

“...I think you are the only person who would describe painting Khaslana as merely challenging.”

“Maybe.”

“Are you alright? I have heard some stories…”

“I am, but thank you for worrying.”

Polyxia looks at him for a minute longer, probably weighing just how truthful he’s being, before she nods. Her lavender eyes go back to the

painting, then, in almost childish wonder, she says, “He kind of looks like my sister’s friend.” She frowns. “No, wait, I think he is.”

“What?”

“My sister, Castorice, she has—or had? I am not entirely sure. She gets sad whenever someone mentions him.” She pauses, shakes her head, and continues. “She has this scrapbook with photos of her friends and he, well, I think Khaslana shows up in some of them.”

Mydei blinks, blinks, and blinks again. Not entirely sure what to say nor how to react. He opens his mouth, but the soft *‘clack, clack, clack’* of heels interrupts him, and he turns to see a girl nearly identical to Polyxia, Castorice, walking up to them with two bags of cotton candy, both lavender.

The purple gloves with butterflies in her hands are identical to the one Khaslana uses.

“Oh, hey, Cas, you are back.” Polyxia smiles, making a motion to him. “This is Mydei, from that coffee painting activity I told you about a while ago, remember?”

“I remember.” Castorice nods, extending one of the bags towards her, and turns to him. “Thank you for taking care of her. She can be a little shy, sometimes.” She says, and smiles at Polyxia’s grumbled *‘Don’t pretend you aren’t shy too’*. “I’m Castorice. It’s a pleasure to meet you.”

“Likewise. Polyxia has spoken lots about you.”

“Only good things, I hope?”

“Only good things, yes. You seem like a very kind person.”

Castorice blinks, and flushes a little, “Hehe, is that so? Thank you.” She chuckles. “Polyxia has mentioned you are a very good artist. I would like to see what did you paint, if it’s not a bother.”

Mydei shakes his head and turns the painting towards her.

Castorice’s eyes widen and she lets out a breathless, almost shaky, “Oh.”

Gently, Polyxia asks, “…Isn’t that your friend?”

“My best friend.” Castorice replies, firmly, but her expression shatters like glass when she adds, “Though, I wonder if he even considers me as such anymore.”

“He still wears it.”

Castorice blinks. “What?”

“The glove.” Mydei adds, plucking his lips a little to point with his mouth at the ones in Castorice’s hands. Her eyes widen. “There hasn’t been a time that I haven’t seen him wear it.”

“...Oh.” She lets out, absentmindedly coming to toy with the hem of the purple fabric. She swallows. “Is it finished?” She asks, looking as if she’s dreading the answer.

“It is.”

“It is?”

“It is.”

Castorice stares at him as if she can’t quite believe what she’s hearing. Mydei holds her gaze, unshakeable and certain, leaving no room for doubt, and, after a long stretch where silence stretches, expands and melts, her eyes soften. Tension he hadn’t quite realized sweeping out of her like steam.

“What is it called?”

A name. Mydei hadn’t thought about a name, but the answer comes all too natural as he tells her, “Khaslana.”

“Just Khaslana?”

“Just Khaslana.”

Castorice blinks, and then smiles, relieved. “Fitting.” She says and turns to the painting, eyes trailing through the strokes of paint, the smile on Khaslana’s face and a quiet melancholy, more painful than outright sadness, washes over her eyes[3]. “...How is he?”

Mydei opens his mouth to answer—and hesitates.

Castorice’s eyes soften. “I see.” She doesn’t sound surprised. “I thought so.”

“...Cas.” Polyxia breathes, putting a hand on her sister’s arm, in silent support. Castorice puts a hand over hers, accepting, before shaking her head and turning back to Mydei once again.

“When,” Castorice starts, hesitates, and then amends, “*If* you ever see him again, whenever you think is right… could you please tell him that I’m glad he’s alive?”

It takes about two hours and a half for the line inside The Irontomb to shorten and another half hour before they are able to give their paintings. Time Mydei spends chatting about simple little nothings that create an everything with both of the girls.

Castorice, turns out, is as pleasant company as Polyxia is, and every bit as kind, if not more, as her sister made her out to be. She’s a botanist, though most people first guess she’s an entomologist with her fascination towards butterflies, and she also writes as a side hobby. She’s a little embarrassed to admit that last part, but still promises to send him a copy of her last book *The Princess and The Cat* once she realizes he has already read a book of hers, a story about bugs with a name he can’t quite pronounce.

They go for lunch, afterwards, because none of them have anything to do and spending so much time under the sun is a good way to get an appetite; and, after they say their respective goodbyes, Mydei goes back to The Irontomb, simply out of curiosity towards the other paintings displayed.

He first goes through the children's section, because there's always so terribly charming about the innocence of crooked lines and disproportionate limbs. There are mothers and there are fathers, grandmothers and grandfathers, big sisters and little brothers, friends and superheroes, made in acrylics, pencils, crayons and a notable drawing of a long suffering woman shoved in a dinosaur costume made with chalks in a little black board called *Dinosour Mum!* whose author simply reads *'Me'*. He has a good idea of who the last one belongs to.

The adult section, in comparison, is a little less charming with all too realistic figures, but not less significant because of that, because here, too, are mothers and fathers, grandmothers and grandfathers, big sisters and little brothers, friends and lovers, with titles like *Mother Dearest, Nagging Old Man, Half of My Soul, You Still Owe Me Twenty Dollars* and *For you, up in the clouds.*

One particular sketch on paper, made with organic cycles and organic compounds like glutamine, proline, cysteine, asparagine and the like composing a woman with flowers in her hair and a needle on hand titled *Unwanted Oxytocin*[4], catches his attention for its peculiarity and refuses to let it go for about twenty whole minutes.

Through it all, there's no burning urge nor electrifying need to go see *Thus Burns the Dawn*, but there's no aversion to it either. Mydei half-thinks of going, but it's a decision that never comes to a head, for a piece of it follows him instead.

"Excuse me, Mydeimos, is it?"

For there's an Antikytheran gazing upon *Khaslana.*

Mydei turns his head away from Polyxia's *On the Garden* towards the other, standing a couple of paintings away from him. He debates, for a second, whether to answer him, but, ultimately, he answers, "It is." Before asking, "And you are?"

"Lyugs. The Irontomb's curator." He says, and something about the name rings an ever so distant bell. He places a hand above the hollow space in his

chest and bows. “It is a pleasure to make an acquaintance with you.”

“...Likewise.” Mydei replies, out of mere courtesy, and walks up next to him to not have to half-shout just to answer. “What do you want?”

“How straightforward, but rest assured I just wish to talk.” He chuckles. “After all, there’s only so many people that have managed to portray the impossible—and the Ruin Author is a terrible conversationalist.”

It clicks. “You are the one who painted Thus Burns the Dawn.”

Lygus smiles.

“Beautiful thing, isn’t it? My Magnum Opus. It took many months to finish and I must admit, I was a little preoccupied when I decided to put it on display. After all, how terribly pretentious of a curator to put their own work in their own gallery alongside artists like,” His lips curl. “Nous.” A pause. “But, in the end, I thought it would be a waste to let such masterpiece gather dust in some studio—Ah, but, of course, the credit can’t be all mine.” He continues and Mydei would think he’s fishing for compliments, were his pride not be evident in his voice. “It wouldn’t have come half as good as it did were it not for *my* muse.”

Lygus laughs, then, and doesn’t give a chance for Mydei to answer as he adds, a little fond, a little patronizing. “But, of course, he would throw a fit if he were to hear me call him that—He has always been terribly unpleasant to work with. Don’t you think?” He asks, but doesn’t let Mydei reply as he turns to *Khaslana*. “In fact, I am most surprised he let you paint him at all. I thought he had stopped ever since that fit of his from two years ago.”

Mydei frowns and, pointedly, refuses to use the word *fit.*

“What do you mean?”

“You know,” Lygus says, almost off-handedly, lifting his left hand, the same one Khaslana keeps covered with a glove at all times. “The whole Nanook thing.” He lowers his hand and taps his chin. “But, I suppose he just can’t help himself to go asking for it.”

Something churns in Mydei's stomach at his words. "*Ask* for it? Do you seriously expect me to believe Khaslana sincerely wants to, what, be hurt, killed?"

"Ah, so you felt it, too—Yet, you still go and interpret him with such gentle strokes… It is certainly a choice."

Mydei clicks his tongue. "I could say the same about your interpretation of his."

"It's not an interpretation. It's, objectively, who he is."

Broken, hollow and empty, goes unsaid.

"Objectively, you say." Mydei's eyes narrow. "Ha! How terribly pretentious."

Lygus chuckles and shakes his head.

He doesn't bother to refute Mydei's claim, as if it was obvious why he was wrong.

Instead, he says, almost as if monologuing, "I am sure you have heard people compare Khaslana to a corpse in the ocean, with the wish to paint it sinking and swallowing you whole. I understand the appeal of such morbid descriptions, of course, but I disagree. The allure of Khaslana…" He sighs. "It's like watching a dying star. Burning bright, dying bright—To not capture such beautiful, self-destructive end, it would only be a waste." He turns to *Khaslana*. "Say, will he come?"

Tiny little ants bite and crawl under his skin with the way the curator's tongue curls around the words, and a heavy, thick sensation spreads over him like viscous molasses trickling ever so agonizingly slow down his bare spine.

Cold, jarring and disgusting.

"No." Mydei lies. "He won't."

“Hm, as I expected. He was never one for art.” He nods, and briefly, Mydei remembers a quiet, melancholic *‘why wouldn’t I?’* muttered like a secret not meant to be heard on that far, faraway first session. “Much less for creation.”

Mydei doesn’t reply.

He simply wonders, for the first time ever since he first saw it, if Thus Burns the Dawn is as complete as it presents itself to be.

The Irontomb is quiet, Monday come, almost deserted if not for the few guards standing on the sides and the reception man who asks him for a synonym for warmth as he racks his brain upon yet another crossword. His steps against the porcelain floor bouncing off the metal walls with a *plam, plam, plam.*

The time on his phone reads ten eleven in the morning, a little early, maybe, for the beginning of the week, but when his eyes had opened at exactly six in the morning, a strange fluttering sensation on Mydei’s stomach[5] had all but forced him to start to get ready early. Besides, Khaslana hadn’t said at what time he would drop by, and his reaction is not one Mydei wants to miss.

Plam, plam, plam echo his steps as he makes his way through the children’s section, before quieting down as he reaches the adult’s. Unwilling to disturb the silence of the big salon, unwilling to disturb whoever might be inside.

Unwilling to disturb Khaslana, standing all so very still, all so very motionless, as he stares at his painting placed at the far away end of the room.

Mydei watches him for a minute or two, maybe three, wonders how long he has been standing there, and when his stillness starts to reminisce far too much that of a statue, he walks towards him. Steps soft, but not silent, resounding in the big, empty room save for them too, but not heavy enough

to echo, not heavy enough to disturb, until he is close enough to feel the warmth radiating off his skin.

A second passes.

Or maybe a lifetime.

Until Mydei turns to him and, as a mirror, a victory, a promise and a reassurance, all and neither at the same time, as something that edges on something unmistakable theirs, and only theirs, he simply says, “It’s your loss, Khaslana.”

Khaslana’s head turns to him before his eyes do, and the look on his face is nothing short of incredulous, maybe even awed. His mouth is parted and his blue lightless eyes are wide, wide open, and, for the first time ever since they met, he looks present—*here*, as if he had stepped out of that strange thread of nonexistence he always threatened to vanish like seafoam at night.

And, for the first time, for the very first time ever since they met, as his blue eyes meet golden ones, it doesn’t feel as if his gaze goes so very deep into his soul he misses the bigger picture, and neither does it feel as if he’s seeing right past him, but, instead, it feels as if Khaslana’s eyes settle to simply see *Mydei.*

He breathes out, and it’s a wonder how a million butterflies don’t come out.

“You…” Khaslana starts, halts and swallows. “You are so arrogant.” He tries, but it sounds as if he’s trying not to topple over, to take back lost ground. Mydei grins, and Khaslana’s nose scrunches. “I never once said I liked it, you know.”

“Didn’t you?” Mydei’s grin gets bigger. “Say it, then.”

“Say what?”

“That you don’t like it.”

“Have you ever been told just how arrogant you are?”

By Khaslana? Plenty. Even just now. But it’s not arrogance, not really, just an unshakable self-assurance as far as Mydei is concerned, though, he understands how that could be misinterpreted as any other thing—Not that he cares, and, besides, that’s not what he wants to hear.

“You are still not saying it.”

Khaslana’s eyes narrow.

“I—” He starts, tries, closes his eyes, and sighs. “I am not that unfair of a person.”

“You like it.” Mydei says, still grinning. Khaslana’s mouth presses. “Say it.”

Khaslana breathes, but, “...I like it.” He admits, almost defeated, and then, as if he can’t quite believe himself, “Kephale above, I *like* it. I really do.”

And Mydei can’t help but laugh and laugh and laugh with his whole chest while his heart *ba-thump-thump-thump’s* so widely and so frantically it feels as if it might burst out of him any second now and fall right into Khaslana’s hands.

“It’s not funny.” He mumbles, coming to cover his face with his hand. The tips of his ears are red. Mydei laughs harder. “*Titans*, you are the worst kind of winner.”

“Heh, won’t you allow a man to relinquish the spoils of his victory?”

“You look as if you will relinquish whether I let you or not.”

He’s not wrong, especially because, “You certainly didn’t make it easy.”

A pause.

“No.” Khaslana admits, breathes. “I did not, and, yet,” His hand falls and he turns back to the painting. “I don’t understand.”

“I just painted.”

“You make it sound so simple.”

“It is simple.”

“It’s not. I didn’t even know I could be seen this way anymore[6], and you just… do.” His eyes shift to him. “How?”

How, he asks. How does one answer that? “I don’t know.” Khaslana’s lips press in a thin, thin line. “I just painted what I saw that night.” He repeats.

Khaslana scoffs.

“You looked like you wanted to hit me.”

“I wanted to do a lot worse.” He admits easily, because deflection is for cowards and repression a vice. “How’s your head?”

The other blinks. “My head?”

“I slammed you pretty hard against the bookshelf.”

Khaslana touches the back of it[7] before he replies, “I’m fine.”

“Really?”

“Yes, tsk, I’m not made out of porcelain, you know.” Khaslana bites and immediately winces, as if he hadn’t meant to say that out loud.

Mydei’s eyebrows fly to his hair. So, that’s how it is. “Pisses you off, doesn’t it?”

“No.” He replies a tad too quickly. He’s an awful liar.

“Really.”

“It’s not like I can change how others see me.” He snaps. “What use is there in getting mad about it?”

“Sounds exhausting.”

“I’m used to it.”

Mydei stares at him for a while.

“Skin bleeds, though.”

“Is that your way of saying you worry you hurt me?” Khaslana asks, a little sardonic. But before Mydei can answer yes, he adds, firmly. *“Don’t.* It’s fine. I have had worse.”

“You do realize that’s not comforting in the slightest?”

He shrugs. “Not everybody has your self-restraint.”

“You do realize,” Mydei repeats, slowly. “That’s not comforting in the slightest?”

Khaslana doesn’t reply.

Mydei sighs.

“I’m sorry—for all it’s worth.”

Khaslana opens his mouth, closes it and swallows. “You are so very strange.”

The Irontomb is a building without any windows, so the light that envelops them it’s the wholly artificial yellows of the ostentatious chandelier on the very top of the room. It’s a wonder, then, just how much time passes between the growing silence. Hours, minutes, years, the day might have died and given way to the night over and over as their little bubble remains unperturbed—even when Khaslana speaks again, it doesn’t pop.

Because the words are only meant for Mydei to hear.

“Mydeimos,”

“Mydei.” He interrupts. There haven't been many instances of Khaslana using his name, if ever, he comes to realize. “Just Mydei.”

Khaslana pauses, and, almost hesitantly, he amends. “Mydei.” He turns to him. “...Now what?”

Now what, indeed.

He knows Khaslana never once thought there could even be an after, and Mydei, well, he’s not the type of person one would describe to live in the moment, because he always knows there’s a tomorrow, but he’s also not the sort of person not to forget there is a today, a now. So, he hadn’t come to stop to think what would happen after he painted Khaslana.

But, now, as he stops to dwell on it, the answer comes all too easy, because Mydei only paints what he wants.

“I would like to keep painting you.”

“...Even now?”

“Even now.”

“If I say no?”

“Then I won’t.”

Khaslana breathes, a little shaky—and he doesn’t look breakable, because he’s not made out of glass and he doesn’t look fickle, because he’s not a flame either. He looks vulnerable, just like any person would.

“Just like that?”

“Just like that.”

“I’m sure you could find any other model.”

“I don’t want another model.” Mydei replies, with a firmness that surprises even him. “It’s—Either you, or giving up the rest of the entries of the competition.”

Khaslana looks at him. “You don’t care about this competition, do you?”

“Neither do you.”

But it’s a good excuse as any, for both of them. Khaslana knows this as well as he does, because instead of answering to the accusation, he instead blurts, out of the blue, “Do you want my number?”

He gives it to him, and once Mydei’s phone has a new contact simply saved as *‘Khaslana’*, he texts him a *‘hey’* for him to have his number too. It’s simple, innocuous, but his phone chimes immediately, and his eyes lower to see an equally simple *‘hi’* texted back at him.

Mydei breathes, butterflies don’t come out, but they sure feel stuck in his throat as he turns his eyes to Khaslana, who is watching him already, mouth hidden behind his phone.

“Hey.” Mydei calls.

“Hi.” Khaslana replies.

As if seeing each other for the first time.

Chapter End Notes

FOOTNOTES

1. Kopopo the Third, for his part, waits for about an hour, simply feeling the rise and fall of his owner’s chest, and only once he’s sure there’s no strange entities of paint attempting to sink his owner in his dreams is that he falls asleep—No, it’s not that he worries, he would tell, a little embarrassed, in the off-chance you spoke cat and were to ask him. It’s only that his mother, Kopopo the Second, Gorgo’s cat, would be livid from beyond the grave if he let anything happen to her human ward. Besides, who would give him pets and treats if something happens to him? But you don’t speak cat, so you can’t ask. Back

2. Much like he says he will fix the wobbly step. Back

3. She doesn’t quite remember what his laugh sounded like, she comes to realize. Back

4. Much like the little girl with chalks, the author is simply listed as ‘Me’, and it will be the first and last piece they give in the competition. Seeing that there’s no return address nor any way to contact the artist, the gallery sends the sketch to the residence of the woman depicted in the drawing. Aglaea scoffs at it, says something about ridiculousness and that fool of a man, but she’s all so gentle as she grabs it and keeps it—Tribios sends a text saying, ‘You could have just given it to her, you know’, to which she’s answered with a curt, ‘I don’t know what you are talking about.’ She laughs and asks if he doesn’t want to know if she liked it, he answers, ‘I know she did.’ Back

5. Once, he remembers being told, as one of those facts drawn on air to unnerve someone, that, on average, people eat about eight or six spiders in their sleep per year. He had never believed that, but that morning he couldn’t help but wonder if whoever told him that as a child got it wrong, and they meant to say butterflies, or moths, or bees—or any other winged insect that might explain the strange sensation bubbling in his stomach. Back

6. If you were to ask Khaslana—He wouldn’t answer you, not really, but in the quiet of his room, he would admit to the empty space he didn’t think he was even capable of laughing anymore. Back

7. It's a little tender. Back

I bought Silksong recently, it's been kicking my ass, I love it. But it has also made me think of Phainon/Khaslana as the Hollow Knight. Anyways, Castorice and Phainon bestfrendism for the win.

Edit (15/09/2025): Added Footnote #7

Chapter 7: Reaching shore

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The little grains that constitute the ever eternal and ever ephemeral sands of time fall, or maybe rise, one by one, in the hourglass that, pretentiously, humans call reality. Silent, as always, abstractly and tangibly, yet, inside the four terracotta walls that enclose dripping paint and colored linen, the slow, yet fast, *trick-trick-trickle* of time can almost be felt as Khaslana *picks, picks, picks* at his bottom lip.

For a while, brush in hand, Mydei simply watches.

It's not obvious, at first glance. In fact, he is almost professional in how he tries not to let it show in his posture. But his back is held so upright it feels as if his spine might snap in two at any second now and he just can't seem to stop *pick-pick-picking* at his bottom lip.

It's strange, edging on uncanny, if for the way he always looked so dimmed, *em—pty*, in the earlier sessions.

Mydei thinks about it, for less than a second, and, before the other can dig so deep he tears at his skin, he sets the brush into the black table at his side with a faint *'clack'*.

Khaslana's eyes shift to him.

"Let's take a break."

Khaslana's brow furrows, in confusion, hand still hovering over his lips.

"It hasn't even been thirty minutes."

It hasn't even been twenty.

Mydei shrugs.

“Have you eaten?” He asks. A shake of head is his reply. Mydei stands up. One of his vertebrae lets out a little *‘pop!’* as he stretches before making a motion for Khaslana to come with him. “Good. I still owe you a meal.”

Khaslana blinks, hesitates, a little, blue eyes shifting to the colors drying up in the plastic palette and the clean brush that hadn’t even been dunked in paint left on the table before he follows him out of the art studio.

Once he catches up, he asks, “Owe me?”

“Mm.”

Mydei makes a general motion to the coffee table in his living room, where the vase still sits.

Rather obviously, if you were to ask him, he hadn’t thrown it away once he was told it was fake. It still was his mother’s, at the end of the day, and Mydei finds that the worth people decide to assign to things always far, far exceeds the coin it is appraised for[1].

“…Aren’t you taking this far too seriously?”

“A bet is a bet.”

“Even an unfair one? I essentially tricked you.” Khaslana must find it somewhat funny, because a tiny smidge of amusement arises as he says the last sentence, buried deep, deep under the soft cadence of his voice.

“Good you recognize that.” Mydei mutters. It comes out a little petulant—but not because he’s miffed about it, because he’s not, not one bit. That would only be childish. “But I lost, nevertheless. Trick or not—Do you like honeycakes?”

“For lunch?”

“Why not?” He asks. Khaslana lets out a little sound on the back of his throat, doubtful, maybe hesitant. “Yes or no, Khaslana.”

“...I do, yes.”

“Great,” Mydei hums, pushing the door of his kitchen open. A chewed-up brown rubber stopper is placed next to it, and he drags it with his foot into the space between the floor and the door to avoid it closing even though the busted hinge doesn’t let it move as smoothly as it once did. He will fix it, one day, he thinks and while he does this, he adds, half-joking: “Because I was going to make them, anyways.”

“Why in the world would you ask me, then?”

“Heh. If you answered no, then it would only be because you have never had mine.”

“You know,” Khaslana’s voice is dry when he replies. “This is exactly the kind of attitude that makes you so easy to trick.”

He doesn’t think so, personally, but instead of answering the accusation, Mydei simply lets out a simple *‘hmph’* as he delves deeper into the kitchen.

Like the rest of his house, the walls here are also built with the rich terracotta bricks, but the floor is carpeted with cream-colored ceramic tiles instead of the usual wood, because those are easier to clean. Its size is somewhere in the middle between little and big. The rectangular wooden table in the middle that, although it doesn’t wobble, he’s still pretty sure he built wrong all those years ago[2], gives the impression that the room is more cramped than it actually is.

Reaching up to the ceiling, through the wall in front of the door to the right, a kitchen cabinet with a hundred drawers, doors and shelves is installed. A fridge with a grocery list he fills little by little and a few photos are held in place by little chimera magnets, an oven, a stove and a microwave are fitted throughout the empty spaces like little puzzle pieces painting the mundane evidence of a warm, clearly lived picture.

On the left wall, a door that gives way into a small backyard he mostly only uses to exercise when he can’t go to the gym is open, as always, but the mosquito door net is closed, as always, because the heat accumulates

terribly in this room and those evil bloodsuckers seem to love Mydei's blood. Kopopo the Third's purple plate of food and water is placed next to it, along a fluffy cat bed he uses whenever he is pissed at Mydei. Hung on it, some little decorations he has been gifted over the years by nails, along a clock with a pendulum and a calendar.

He takes out a big red bowl he always uses to mix batter from one of the doors in the cabinet and places it on the counter with a quiet *'tap'* before washing his hands in the sink. He mixes some yeast, sugar, water and flour with methodical, well-known motions and, as he waits for the yeast to activate, he goes to open the oven and rummage around for that one pan he reserves for making honeycakes.

After a second, Khaslana says, "Sorry."

"For?"

A pause.

"Your door."

Mydei blinks, frowns, the *'clank, clank'* of metal against metal stopping for a second as he processes the words before he continues. "Why are you apologizing?" He asks, taking out a big pot with a dent on one side that's getting in the way along some other dishes. Distantly, he wonders why that one pan is placed so far on the back considering how often he uses it. "It wasn't your fault."

"Wasn't it?" Khaslana mutters.

"You weren't the one that slammed it open, no." Mydei replies, finally taking the pan out and placing it on top of the stove. He shifts his head to see Khaslana from the corner of his eye, just to find him looking at the busted hinge in the door while he shoves the other dishes on the floor back into the oven far less carefully. "It's nothing I can't fix, anyways."

"If you say so."

Khaslana hasn’t entered the kitchen.

He hadn’t entered last time either, choosing to linger instead on the very, very edge like an apparition about to dispel. Unsure—or unwilling, maybe, to disturb the quiet coziness that’s ever inherent to a kitchen, especially to one as well-loved as Mydei’s, with the all-consuming, all-devouring, ever-destructive allurement his sink-sink-sinking presence always seems to carry like a noose about to tighten.

“Don’t just stand there.” Mydei says with the same ease one unties a loose knot, adding more flour, vanilla extract and a little bit of salt in the batter now that the yeast has settled. He takes a whisk out of one of the drawers and starts to mix the batter. “Come in.”

Khaslana’s steps are ever silent, but Mydei doesn’t need to turn around to know that he does.

He expects him to take seat at the table in the middle. Instead, Khaslana pushes himself up to sit at an empty space on the kitchen’s counter, between the sink and the stove, right next to Mydei with a *‘bam!’* as the heels of his feet collide against the wooden cabinets. His shoes are untied, as always.

Mydei doesn’t stop in his motions, but he does raise an eyebrow at him, to which Khaslana merely tilts his head and offers no explanation whatsoever as he watches him cook. Mydei has never been fully comfortable with people doing that, for reasons he can’t quite pinpoint, but, nevertheless, he lets him stay there.

“Are you allergic to anything?”

“Cotton.” Khaslana replies, straightfaced. At the look Mydei gives him, he even adds, “Makes my skin itchy.”

“I will make sure not to add it, then.” Mydei replies, also straightfaced. “Do you want anything to drink?”

“Coffee?”

“I only have the instantaneous type.”

“That’s fine, thank you.”

“Alright. Here, mix.” He answers, shoving the bowl and the whisk into Khaslana’s hands without further ceremony. The other scrambles not to let it drop with a sound of surprise as Mydei walks out of the kitchen and back to the art studio.

The only coffee he has is the one he uses to paint, and so he has ended up treating it as merely another art supply, placed in between the tubes of paint. It’s perfectly drinkable despite that, though he does check the expiration date just in case.

When Mydei gets back to the kitchen, he finds Kopopo the Third sitting down on the table staring intently at Khaslana.

“I think,” He starts, speaking as slowly as he’s mixing the batter, not taking his eyes out of Kopopo the Third either. “Your cat is going to murder me.”

Mydei huffs. “He’s like this with everyone.” And he passes a hand through his little fuzzy back, lingering to pet his head. Kopopo the Third presses against it further with a face of satisfaction. Cute. “He will warm up to you, eventually.”

As soon as he stops petting him, his cat’s face immediately snaps back to stare at Khaslana.

“As my corpse *eventually* cools down, maybe.”

“Have you ever been told how dramatic you are?”

“Not as often as I used to.”

“Allow me to make up for it, then.” Mydei says, taking out a pot and filling it with water to boil. He then gives a sideway glance to the motions of Khaslana’s hands. “Faster.”

Khaslana's face is wholly unimpressed as he stares at him, but he does start doing it faster. "When you said you were going to cook me a meal, I didn't expect you to put me to make it."

"I am just asking you to whisk it."

"I am whisking it."

"Badly."

"No, I am not. See?" He tilts the bowl to him as he whisks it—badly, might Mydei add. "I am doing it faster."

"And your technique sucks."

"You do it, then."

Mydei turns one of the knobs of the stove. A loud *'ts! ts! ts!'* arises before the lighter catches with the gas coming out of one of the little black discs and a flame comes to life. He places the pot with water on top before he takes the bowl and the whisk Khaslana is extending back to him.

Then, looking at Khaslana straight in the eye, he whisks the batter with impeccable form. A fast *clink, clink, clink, clink* resonates through the kitchen as the metal collides against the bowl's porcelain with the motions.

"Must you be good at everything you do?"

"Heh." Mydei chuckles, a little smug. "You don't bake much, do you?"

Khaslana shrugs. "Not as much as you do, apparently." He answers, before doing that little tilt of head of his. "It's a bit surprising, come to think of. You strike me more as the type of guy who would only subsist on a base of protein shakes and chicken breast."

"That sounds like an actual nightmare."

"You don't care about calorie intake and all that?"

“I wouldn’t say I don’t care, seeing that I like keeping a good physique.” Mydei replies, eyeing the batter. It looks fine, so he settles the bowl down onto the counter to let it rest as he turns to the pot of water. Not boiling, but already hot. He turns off the stove. “However, I also really like sweets.”

Khaslana blinks.

“Sweets?”

“Sweets, yes.” Mydei nods, filling a blue cup, one of the few that does have a handle, with water before adding a teaspoonful of coffee. “How do you like it?”

“Just one sugar.” Mydei can’t help the expression of disgust that crosses his face even as he puts only a teaspoonful of sugar into the cup and stirs it with a *clink, clink*. “I gather you don’t like coffee, then.”

“Too bitter.”

“Just add more sugar, or milk.”

“It tastes like dirt water one way or another.”

He passes the cup to Khaslana, who stirs it a little bit more. “If you say so.” He replies before taking a sip.

Just to immediately spit it out in the sink.

The laugh Mydei lets out is sharp, near indistinguishable from the sound a choked cat would make. Khaslana glares daggers at him before turning to look down at the dark liquid in his hand. “What in the world did you just give me?”

“Coffee.” He answers, amused beyond belief. “I told you that thing tasted bad.”

“Not if you do it *well*—What brand is it?”

Mydei shrugs, making a general direction to the place he put the coffee in.

Ts! Ts! Ts! The stove lets out as a flame comes to life at the same time a little *‘pam!’* echoes in the kitchen when Khaslana comes down the counter. He comes to open the door he pointed at to check. While he puts some oil in the pan, Mydei watches as Khaslana finds and takes a little glass jar with chocolate chips.

He opens it, puts a handful in his palm before tilting his head back and shoving them into his mouth in one go. He closes it, puts it back, before immediately grabbing it again and grabbing another handful of chocolate chips.

Mydei’s chocolate chips, mind you.

It seems Khaslana remembers this a beat later, because he turns to him, looking wholly unapologetic, and tilts the little jar towards him in a silent offering.

A silent offering of, once again, *Mydei’s* chocolate chips.

The audacity.

Mydei sighs and extends his hand towards him, nevertheless.

A little handful is placed carefully on his palm, and Mydei copies Khaslana’s prior actions and tilts his head back before shoving them all into his mouth in one go. Then, he watches as lightless blue eyes trail away from his face to the red bowl with the batter. It’s not a silent petition, just a little second of want Khaslana doesn’t ask for. Mydei gives it to him, either way.

He grabs the bowl and places it closer to the other, and just like that, another little handful of chocolate chips is put in the batter.

He makes a note to write down that he needs to buy more.

Mydei stirs the batter a couple of times to spread the chocolate chips throughout before tilting the bowl into the pan until a little circle forms. The excess clinging to the edge and trailing down the bowl he swipes with a finger and licks it.

“Why in the world would you buy a brand of coffee named Dirt Water?”

“It’s cheap.”

“It’s a medical hazard, that’s what it is.” Khaslana replies, scanning through the contents of the label on the back.

“It’s not like I drink it.”

“But you will give it to your guests? Hmph. Buy a better one.” Khaslana says. Mydei wonders if he realizes how petulant he sounds. He then adds, “Unless, of course, this was all just a very complicated ploy to poison me ever since the beginning—In such case, I suppose I shall give you your flowers.”

Why would he give him flowers for that? Mydei wonders, absentmindedly[3]. But before he can question him, with all the naturalness in the world, Khaslana grabs the cup, tilts his head back and drinks it in one go.

He gags when he’s done and then goes to wash his cup in the sink.

“Why would you do that?” Mydei asks, a little incredulous, as he flips the honeycake.

“I don’t like wasting food.”

“Hm. There’s lemonade on the fridge.”

“...Thanks.”

A couple minutes later, a neat, fluffy, and delicious-looking stack of honeycakes is placed in the middle of the table, along with a bottle of bee honey, and two plastic containers still cold with condensation. One with blueberries and the other with raspberries.

Kopopo the Third, now displaced from his position in the table, has recurred to chew into the rubber door stopper, though his eyes are still fixed

in-tent-ly on Khaslana. If it bothers him, the aforementioned doesn't let it show at all.

"Eat."

Khaslana still looks sort of doubtful even as he stabs one honeycake with a fork and brings it over onto his own plate. He grabs some blueberries, adds some honey, cuts a little piece and, feeling the weight of Mydei's gaze, looks him in the eye as he brings the little piece into his mouth.

Just to immediately freeze.

Khaslana blinks once, twice, eyes shifting from Mydei to the honeycake sitting innocently in front of him in a look close to wonder as he chews.

"Oh."

He immediately stabs another honeycake from the stack and drags it to his plate.

Heh.

"Heh." Mydei lets out, smiling like a well-satisfied cat as he serves himself two honeycakes from the stack too.

He has never had any doubt whatsoever about his abilities in the kitchen, but there's always so undeniably warm in the sight of someone enjoying something you have made.

Effort, he had been taught, by both his mother and his father, back when he hadn't gone mad with grief, is its own kind of care[4].

Its own kind of devotion.

And, likewise, he knows, there's trust in accepting.

Khaslana takes another bite of a honeycake.

"You are not subtle, you know."

“I’m not trying to be.” Mydei replies.

Khaslana’s eyes lower.

“I’m sorry.”

“If this is about the door, I already told you it’s fine.”

He shakes his head. “I know we stopped the session only because of me.” He says, the edge of the fork catches onto his lower lip, and Khaslana winces as it digs into a space he must have hurt earlier with his picking.

“You needed a break. It’s fine.” Mydei reassures, grabbing the container with the raspberries and letting some fall onto his plate. “I don’t wish to paint you when you are uncomfortable, either way.”

Khaslana opens his mouth, closes it, and pushes the bottle of honey towards him instead.

A long, long beat of silence stretches, little grains of time coming into a halt, just for a moment, just in this room, just for them. A faint breeze comes in through the open door of his kitchen, refreshing and faint, and when it looks like Khaslana might not speak again, Mydei extends the container of raspberries to him.

He hesitates before he grabs one.

And, quietly, he admits, “I don’t know how to act around you now.”

“What a stupid thing to worry about.” Mydei tells him, upfront. Khaslana’s fingers around the raspberry in his hand tighten, a little trickle of juice sweeping between the gaps. “Just act like you always do.”

“If I acted like I *always* do, I wouldn’t have come back in the first place.”

“Then why did you do it?”

A pause.

“I don’t know.”

Mydei looks at him.

“Liar.”

Khaslana’s mouth presses into a thin, thin line, and he places the raspberry on his plate, cleaning his hand on his pants. He then stabs the raspberry with his fork and eats it along with a little piece of honeycake.

He does not answer.

And Mydei does not know what to say.

“It’s fine if you don’t know how to act.” He tries, nevertheless. A part of him knows he still comes up short, though. “You just have to be.”

Khaslana makes a face. “You always make things sound so simple. I don’t…” He halts, pushing with his fork a blueberry on his plate from right to left and left to right. Empty blue eyes shift fleetingly to the broken door before going back to Mydei’s face. “What if I *‘am’* and you don’t like what you see?[5] ”

Mydei tilts his head. “If I do?”

“How could you know that?”

“I don’t, and that’s why I won’t make any empty promises, but both of us will never know the answer if you don’t let me.”

Khaslana stabs the blueberry.

“And how would you go about it, mm?”

Leave it to him not to make things easier from the get-go. But that’s fine, he should have already learned by now Mydei can’t resist a good challenge.

“For starters,” Mydei thinks for a second. “Tell me what’s your favorite color.”

The look Khaslana sends him is nothing short of incredulous. Briefly, Mydei wonders, how did he not notice just how expressive the other could be. “What are you, five?”

“Answer the question.”

“Gold.”

“As in coin?”

“As in wheat.”

“Why?”

“...It reminds me of home.” Khaslana shrugs, but it looks a little bit too mechanical, as if he’s trying not to let whatever emotions accompany his statement show. Maybe, that’s why he asks immediately, “What’s yours?”

In the past, he remembers, back in school when Mydei came with his hundred dozen crayons of different colors in his purple droma’s case, he always struggled with that question. And, even now, even to this day, it is still somewhat hard, because, as an artist, it is hard to place one tone over the other when all of them can be valuable to form this picture or the other.

Still, he finds, today, and maybe from this day on, the answer comes to him with terrible ease.

“Blue.”

“Is there a reason for that?”

Mydei looks at Khaslana’s eyes.

“No, not particularly.” He replies, chewing on a piece of a honeycake, deciding to keep that little secret for himself for no particular reason. “Now, what do you like doing?”

“...How many of these are you going to do?” Khaslana mutters, still looking unconvinced. “Bird watching, I guess.”

“Bird watching?”

“I like birds.”

An idea comes into Mydei’s mind with a little *‘pop!’* like a corn kernel exploding into a little white popcorn and, a little impulsively, a little too much spontaneously in the way he often doesn’t tend to be, he asks, “Would you like to go watch them, then?”

Khaslana blinks at him.

“You mean right now?”

The ravine on the other side of the block is more a little forest than it is a ravine. A little lush of greenery in between houses of brick and concrete colored in an array of artificial tones, that goes down, down, down into a little creek with cold, cold water in which it isn’t strange to see the kids waist deep when the weather is hot or whenever they simply wish to catch fish with their hands.

It’s humid, in the way these sorts of environments always are, with dirt that’s always a little muddy and slippery and trees that reach high, high into the sky. Big green leaves cast shadows that shift as the wind pushes them side to side.

They cling onto Khaslana, dig into the edges of his skin and wrap around him like thorned vines, in the way they always do, and, maybe, will always do, because Mydei’s shift in perspective doesn’t mean the world has stopped seeing Khaslana much more like a ghost or a broken wind-up doll.

It doesn’t mean Khaslana has stopped regarding himself as such either. But, that’s fine, Mydei is a patient, patient man. Tenacious in his perseverance.

Now, close to the edge of the creek, there stands a gray pillbox reclaimed by the greenery that the kids have now turned into a secret base everybody pretends not to know about until it is time for dinner. Mydei places the

white canvas he brought with him in the top of it, along with the black box with the ugly-looking chimeras where his art supplies rest, and hauls himself upwards.

He turns around, intent on helping Khaslana up, just to find him lifting himself upwards with the same ease as Mydei's.

It's not surprising, not really. Khaslana's build isn't as bulky as his own, but it is certainly athletic. Enough that it is easy to see he could certainly carry himself well in a fight and more than enough that it is easy to know he would be able to push back were he to be slammed into a bookshelf.

I suppose, the curator's smile flashes in Mydei's mind, *he just can't help himself.*

Mydei scrunches his nose and shakes his head, trying to dispel the image—which comes to be all too easy when Khaslana lets out a dry *'ah'* that is followed by a loud *'splash!'*

His shoe came off[6].

"I did tell you to tie them."

"Yeah, yeah." Khaslana waves off, sitting at the edge of the pillbox. He pulls his leg up and ties the remaining shoe. "There, happy?"

"That thing is so loose you might as well leave them undone."

"It's not loose. You—*Why* are you untying my shoe?"

"Because it's loose." Mydei replies, sitting down in a more comfortable position next to Khaslana as he tightens the knot. He's about to say something else, when a glimpse of brown mixed with neon yellows and greens catches his eye and he blurts out, "What in the hell is that thing on your foot?"

"...My shoe?"

"No, not that."

Mydei lifts the leg of his pants, enough for the abomination the other is wearing as socks to be put on full, shameful display.

Khaslana pins him with the sort of dead look that only someone who has been told the exact same thing many times over could have.

“I like them.” He defends, flatly.

“You do?”

“I think they are fun.”

“To laugh at.”

Khaslana scoffs. “You are just jealous.”

“Jealous of the person I was before seeing them, yes.” Mydei replies as he finishes tying Khaslana’s shoe.

“I’m going to shove you into the creek.” Khaslana threatens, looking as if he means each and every word he’s saying, as he points at the water—until a little bird comes to rest on his extended finger with a joyful chirp.

Mydei blinks at it. Khaslana doesn’t look the least bit surprised.

“They like to do that.”

“Every time?”

“Since I was a child, yes.” Khaslana replies, looking down at the little bird on his finger. “I used to think it was only because they liked the music, but they continued to come even after I stopped playing.”

In quiet movements, as to not scare off the bird, Mydei drags the white canvas into his lap and starts to put greens and browns in the plastic palette.

“What did you play?”

“The ocarina.”

Mydei hums. “I used to play the piano.”

Khaslana tilts his head. The little bird in his finger also tilts its little head.

“Really?”

“Is it so surprising?”

“Maybe.” He shrugs. “If anything, I would have expected you to play the lyre.”

“Why is that?”

“You just have very kind hands, that's all.”

“Kind?” Mydei blinks, caught more than a little off-guard at Khaslana’s words.

He turns his eyes down to see the array of calluses littering his fingertips and the ever-perpetual bruise on his middle finger, in the skin under his nail where the wood of his painting brushes always digs, digs and digs in.

His hands aren’t the type one would usually associate with kindness, not really. They aren’t small, nor smooth, and much less delicate. They are big, and gruff, and more than a little rough. The type of hands far, far more fitting to that of a fighter than that of a painter, he knows, and, he thinks, would always know even if he hadn’t been told time and time again.

And yet.

“...I see.”

Khaslana seems them as kind.

How strange.

Mydei can’t quite help the smile that blooms and spreads over his face.

He doesn't finish the painting that day, for there is no threat of that moment in between the creek and the trees to slip away through the gaps of his fingers like grains of sand as there was with the image of Khaslana laughing.

So, they come back, again and again, to talk of little important nothings as Mydei paints, and, at the end of the month, when the second round of the art competition arrives, a painting titled *Of Conversations and Birds* comes to hang on the Irontomb's walls like a little star.

Chapter End Notes

FOOTNOTES

1. Even then, first and foremost, Mydei is his mother's son. So, he still had made the time to take a little impetus trip to Castrum Kremnos to meet with old friends, and even though none of them will delve into the details of their fun little escapade, especially without a lawyer in the room, they will say that the scammer will think thrice the next time they decide to pull off something like that. Back

2. There's no word for 'reading the instruction manual' in the Kremonan Language. Back

3. Sometimes, Mydei has a hard time understanding little turns of phrase. It's fine, but it makes it so that, later in this story, much, much later, hidden somewhere somewhen in between the lines, he asks Khaslana when will he give him the flowers he said. Khaslana looks at him weirdly before explaining it wasn't literal. Still, he asks, "Did you want some?" To which, Mydei replies, "I was expecting some, that's all." He believes that's the end of that, but, a month later, he is given a little bouquet of pink and blue hydrangeas tied with a ribbon from where a little bag of silk with a hundred pressed forget-me-nots hangs. "So that they last longer," Khaslana says. The hydrangeas wither after some time, for such is the cycle of life, and a new painting comes to appear in Mydei's art studio the day after it happens—as for the forget-me-nots, those, he keeps on a glass box in his night desk. Back

4. This, Mydei won’t ever know, for grief withered Eurypon into a coward, but, even now, even though it pains him terribly to see his wife’s strokes in his son’s paintings, he still makes an effort to go into each exposition he knows one of Mydei’s works shall be presented. It’s not enough, it will never be, especially after his actions forced Mydei out of his house, but, it sure makes you wonder. Back

5. Once, in a book Khaslana really liked but could never come up with the energy to finish reading, it said than an overexposure to mirrors could chip away bits and pieces of a person, for the fragment of a mirror could contain both a piece of the universe and a piece of soul. Khaslana has never really liked mirrors, and he has come to not like being painted either, and a part of him wonders if the statement the book said about mirrors applies the same to paintings. If, maybe, he has been chip-chip-chipped so much by brushes instead of chisels, that there’s nothing left for him to be. Back

6. They never manage to find it. So, that day, Khaslana walks back to his apartment with a pair of Mydei’s shoes. Back

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A couple of notes on the footnotes, lol. The book Khaslana is referring to actually exists, is 'Witches Abroad' by Terry Pratchett, which I love and has irreparably changed my writing style. It's pretty good, I do recommend it.

On the flowers, hydrangeas can have lots of meanings depending who you ask. The pink ones, I have found, tend to mean things along the lines of love and sincere emotions, while the blue ones tend to mean apology, forgiveness, gratitude and understanding. If you wonder, Khaslana focused on the ‘sincere emotions’ and ‘gratitude’ meaning, and so, he’s practically telling Mydei, ‘Thank you (for understanding/seeing me)’

The forget-me-nots are self-explanatory.

Chapter 8: Stable ground

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“And where are we going today?”

Khaslana asks that day.

Mydei blinks once, twice, and then thrice at the question.

Khaslana blinks back at him with the sort of quiet, almost gentle, tranquility he always seems to carry with him, standing expectantly at the edge of the ever-wobbly stone step that Mydei will definitely fix later. He’s much the same as ever, the same three *knock-knock-knocks*, the same messenger bag, same glove, same sharp tongue, same blue, deep ocean eyes, and even his inquiry is much the same as it has been for the past weeks, maybe even months.

Still, he finds himself surprised, like coming aware of the fact you are in a dream, maybe, or like coming to notice the dirt path in the middle of the grass that slowly, gradually, formed unnoticed under the weight of your steps.

When, Mydei wonders, suddenly overly aware of the way Khaslana tucks a lock of his hair behind his ear, *did things change?*

He thinks about it, for a second. Time coming to a halt.

It would be a complete, utter lie, not to say terribly unfair, to say that things started to change once the last brush of *Of Conversations and Birds* was given and Khaslana, ever so disbelieving, asked a faint *‘is it done?’* at the side of the creek with about five canaries in his lap and his ugly socks, as if still unsure Mydei had actually finished painting him, not once, but twice, because, the truth is, things had started to change long, long ago.

Change, it’s the thing, it’s just the nature of things, as melancholic as it might be.

The oceans turn to sand and the sands to ocean. Day turns to night and day to night. Metal rusts, rock erodes, dust settles, and vines grow. The blanket you used to sleep with unravels thread by thread, the plastic toys gain a hundred little white scratches, and that shirt you liked doesn’t quite fit you anymore. One day, you look at your mother’s face and come to notice the wrinkles and creases on her old face and can't quite remember if she always looked like that, and you realize flowers bloom just to die; and maybe there’s some sort of tragic beauty in that, such is life, alas[1].

Things had already started to change long, long ago, ever since the moment Mydei ever laid eyes on *Thus Burns the Dawn*, maybe. Khaslana had changed from an urban legend, a whisper in between the linen and the paint, a mere concept, to an apparition, and from an apparition to something in-between a challenge and a muse, and then to a proper muse with how he had fulled and ignited Mydei’s passion for art before it could die a slow, painful death.

But, now, as the question changed from an empty, monotone *‘how do you want me?’* to a light, almost expectant *‘and where are we going today?* [2]*’* he isn’t exactly sure what exactly Khaslana changed into, much less what exactly he became to Mydei.

But that’s alright, maybe, he thinks. Some things in this world don’t need a name.

They just need to be.

“I don’t know,” Mydei replies, easily. He passes the blank canvas to Khaslana to carry, and the action comes with a strange sort of naturalness, a little mundanity between them. “Where are we going?”

Khaslana blinks again, this time surprised. The winds of change can be felt.

He brings his phone out of his back pocket in his white pants and taps it once to check the hour. It’s two o’clock of a day that will probably be

forgotten in history because the events and affairs that happen that day aren't particularly worthwhile. If that makes it matter less or more, Mydei doesn't particularly care, he's no romanticist.

He just knows he will remember, nevertheless—even if sometime in the future he won't be sure if it happened either on a Monday or a Wednesday, maybe even a Thursday.

"Have you eaten?" Khaslana asks. "Lunch, I mean."

"No."

"Do you want to go to the diner?"

"You mean the one on the last floor of where you work?"

"Mm-hm."

"Hm."

Khaslana shuts down his phone and shoves it carelessly into his messenger bag through a little gap left by the flap, and says, "They have really good desserts, you know."

Mydei arches an eyebrow.

"Bribery doesn't work on me."

Khaslana tilts his head. "Pomegranates ones."

Ah, maybe it does work, just a little bit—but it's not like he was ever actually going to say no to Khaslana's choice of place. He didn't give much warning that he was going to be the one choosing their destination today, anyway.

Mydei turns his head around. "Don't destroy the house while I am out." He tells Kopopo The Third, firmly, who is laying on the floor tummy-up, with that little smile dogs and cats always seem to have when they are very, very

comfy. He meows non-comitally at him. Hmph, little fuzzy bastard. He's lucky Mydei loves him.

"You always say that to him." Khaslana points out as Mydei steps outside, skipping absentmindedly the wobbly step, and closing the door behind him.

He lets the keys of his house fall unceremoniously into the messenger bag through the little gap left by the flap as he answers, "He's a menace," and they start to walk towards the diner. "As you must be aware."

"I think he's cute."

He is, but, also, "He has attempted to kill you at least three times now."

"Four."

"Mm? When was the fourth one?"

Khaslana hums, also non-comitally.

A part of Mydei wonders if he should be glad Kopopo The Third doesn't get along with him.

They reach the building a little after, as untouched by the modernization of times as it ever is. The green, rich vines have extended further and further up to the top, and the tiny little white flowers have grown in numbers and bloomed beautifully, covering completely the quaint yellow walls. It's the season, he believes, somewhere in between the Month of Reaping and the Month of Weaving. Soon they will dye red in the Month of Strife before they wither and fall in the Month of Mourning, and who knows what will happen in the Month of Fortune. *Maybe Zagreus will make strawberries grow*, Mydei says. *Better than potatoes again*, Khaslana replies.

The same old man with wrinkled hands and a newsboy cap from last time opens the door for them once again. He's delighted to hear they are going to his wife's diner. Upon hearing he likes sweets, he laughs and recommends the carrot cake she makes before patting him hard on the back hard enough

to knock the air out of Mydei's lungs. Apparently, he used to be a very good wrestler.

It's as quiet and a little bit empty as last time, in the sort of way places like this always seem to be. In a little corner of the first floor, colorful linens on wooden easels held together with adhesive tape stand in place of people. A small art exhibition of the works belonging to the art class given up in the diner on the weekends. Charming things, as always, some better than the others, little pieces of dreams put into reality with watercolors and oils, though, the painting of a drowned man with hair dipped in gore and spider lilies for blood is a stark, gruesome contrast to the rest. Khaslana's eyes flicker in something like melancholic recognition at the image before they continue towards the stairs next to the elevator that always gets stuck between floors [3].

Khaslana walks a couple of steps ahead of him, climbing upwards in fast strides that echo with a little *plap, plap, plap*, as the ends of his ever untied shoes slip out of his heels every time he lifts his feet.

"You would think that after losing one shoe more than once you would have learned to tie them by now."

"Don't speak to me as if I were five." Khaslana replies, giving a little wave of hand to Theodoros, who is ripping yet another sheet of paper taped to the glass door of his store. "I know how to—Ah."

His shoe slips off.

It lands a couple of steps behind Mydei.

He goes to fetch with an *'I told you so'* or some other witty comment already at the tip of his tongue that he doesn't get to utter as Khaslana says, monotonously, "Race you." And before Mydei knows it, he has already disappeared onto the next floor.

"That's cheating!" Mydei yells at him, voice bouncing in the walls. He picks up Khaslana's shoe and scrambles to reach the diner first, skipping

steps four at a time with fast, long strides. The painting utensils in his box clatter around loudly with the movements.

Still, “You lost.” Khaslana not so kindly tells him once he reaches the diner merely seconds later after he arrived. His face is impassive. “That means you are paying.”

Mydei, unimpressed, lets the shoe fall to the ground with a *‘plap!’*

Khaslana doesn’t look the least bit surprised at the fact Mydei still got it for him. He half wonders if he’s that predictable as he watches him wiggle his foot into it. “Thank you,” He says, holding onto Mydei’s shoulder to maintain balance before he lifts his leg to straighten the heel tab he crushed against his feet. “You are still paying, though.”

“For my own food, yes.”

“Penny pincher.”

“Says the freeloader.”

Khaslana lets out a little *‘hmph’* sound in the back of his throat, pushing open the diner’s wooden door. The hinges, old rusted things, grinds and creaks as if they were getting murdered.

He lets Mydei pass first.

“Shouldn’t the winner get something?”

“You never once said the loser had to pay.”

“It was implied.”

“No, it wasn’t.”

“Mm, I knew you were a bad winner, but I didn’t expect you to be a bad loser, too.”

“I’m the bad winner? You are the one always starting competitions where I am at a disadvantage.”

“What you are saying it’s that you are slow.”

Mydei steps on the back of his shoe, just to be petty. It comes off Khaslana’s feet swiftly and, before he can put it back, he kicks it to the side.

A beat.

“...And a bully.” He adds, dryly, walking to it.

“Hm-hm.” Mydei lets out. The sound edges on the side of indulgent.

His shoe landed under a table with two grannies on a little date. One of them pushes it towards him with her long walking stick that has a skull on the top, looking amused as Khaslana thanks her. The other says something to him as he bends down to tie it. He shakes his head and replies with another thing that makes both grannies laugh. One of them even pinches his cheek.

“What did they tell you?” Mydei asks, a little curious, after Khaslana comes back.

“That you are being very mean.”

“Hm-hm.”

The face Khaslana makes is close to a pout, but not quite. Were he to be more childish, or younger, maybe, Mydei suspects he would have stuck his tongue out at him.

He sighs.

“Fine,” He concedes, for some strange reason, yet, not one to yield, he adds, “But you are paying next time.”

Khaslana’s face doesn’t twitch nor change one bit, no quick turn of lips, no crinkled eyes, but he still manages to look unbearably smug, somehow.

Mydei clicks his tongue and attempts to step on the back of his shoe again. Khaslana kicks him in the shin.

The diner is a quaint little thing, shoved into a corner thanks to a big saloon occupying the majority of the last floor that's used for this activity or the other, like Zumba classes on Fridays or haunted houses where the most terrifying thing is the price to enter. A bunch of metal tables and metal chairs that you have to get on your tiptoes to get onto stand across the checkered floors. The end wall is covered with childish paper drawings hung with red tacks.

It is quiet, although not silent, with the clinks of cutlery and the clatter of the kitchen resonating like distant notes in the back of a song. Lyrics made out of fragments and pieces of conversations floating around. Tiny glimpses of a million lives that seem so far away and, at the same time, so close. *'She told me not to tell anybody, so you better not tell this!', '...I texted him again.', 'Oh, come on. It's five o'clock somewhere.', 'So, what if it has more than a thousand episodes? I swear you are going to like it!', 'No, no, I can still pass the class. I need fifteen points and there's still six from activities and ten from the test. He's also giving extra points if you come dressed as a fruit on the examination day. I will go as a carrot—What do you mean that's a vegetable?'* Unfamiliar in their familiarity, familiar in their unfamiliarity. The distinction might not matter.

They sit at a table next to a window filled with faded stickers of princesses and transformers, placing both the canvas and his box with the ugly-looking chimeras on the sides below the table. And, after they order and the waiter takes away the cheap, laminated menus that Mydei has always hated the sensation of with him, he opens the blue cardboard box of clay crayons in the middle.

It only has four colors.

He takes out the blue one as he says, "Whoever makes the better drawing pays."

"You are already paying."

“Not if I win.”

“This is unfair.” Khaslana replies, looking unamused. It’s almost funny. “You are the painter here.”

“What I am hearing is that you can’t.”

He points a finger at him. “Don’t use my own tactics against me.”

“Why, is it working?”

“No.”

“So, you lose then.”

Khaslana’s finger twitches.

It’s a little bit curious, Mydei thinks, how terribly, almost pettily, prideful he can be in the most inconsequential of things. Then again, it’s not like Mydei has much room to talk. He has come to realize he’s much the same ever since he met Khaslana.

“Art is subjective.” He replies.

“Hmph.” Mydei lets out. “Don’t you think I know that?”

“I wouldn’t be surprised if you didn’t.”

Mydei’s eyebrow twitches. Instead of replying and giving Khaslana more ammunition to shoot back, he sends a pointed look at the blank sheet of paper the diner uses as placemats in front of him before starting to make a sketch on his.

Khaslana clicks his tongue.

From the corner of his eye, Mydei watches with a sense of victory as a gloved hand takes out the green crayon from the box.

“Heh.” Mydei chuckles, smug.

Khaslana throws the crayon at his head. Mydei throws the one in his hand right back at him.

Now they only have two crayons.

The food arrives soon after, and they eat it between meaningless chatter and little banter. The old man with the wrinkled hands and a newsboy cap hadn't been lying when he said his wife's cooking was to die for, because saying that it tastes amazing is an understatement. A part of him can't help but compare the explosion of flavor on his tongue to the feeling of placing cold hands around a warm cup despite him being no romanticist. He even ends up asking if he can have the carrot cake recipe[4].

Once they are done, Mydei makes a motion of writing in air in the direction of the waiter, who nods and disappears into the kitchen to get the tab before he turns to face the other, expectantly.

Khaslana covers his mouth with the paper with the drawing.

"...Why do I have to go first?"

"You have seen my art plenty of times already." Mydei replies, easily. "I want to see yours."

Khaslana brings the sheet of paper a little higher, now covering his nose along with his mouth, leaving only his deep blue eyes uncovered, staring accusingly at him.

It's a little endearing, for reasons he can't quite put a finger on.

"Ha! Don't tell me you are getting shy."

"I'm not shy." He replies immediately. "It's just not very good."

Mydei extends his hand in a silent request. "I will be the judge of that."

"You are going to laugh."

“I will try my best not to.”

Blue eyes narrow. “Try?”

“I don’t make promises I can’t keep.” He replies, earnestly, and perhaps a little too solemn for the situation at hand. But Mydei has always been a rather solemn person, a sincere one, in all aspects of his life, and he has never seen the point in either pretending or hiding who he is. “It can’t be that bad.”

Khaslana’s gaze flickers across his face before he lowers the drawing from his face. He looks at it once, mouth pressing before it goes back to his usual lack of expression. “I don’t really like it, but,” He sucks in his upper lip, scraping his teeth against it as if he wanted to draw blood before he lets it go. He extends the paper to him. “I tried.”

Mydei’s eyes flicker down.

A hundred thousand little butterflies catch in his throat.

Despite the fact the world does not change nor care, not one bit, it still feels as if the winds have changed from south to north. Time, ever present, ever important, ever going, tick-tock-tick, fading far, far away, as if eternity took grace and allowed him to stay watching the little drawing made with pinks and reds as long as Mydei desired.

Still, eternity would get lonely, he thinks, and Mydei would rather live the moment he’s in, so, he says, a little redundantly, for the butterflies seem eager to steal all words and all air, “You drew me.” And the gears of time start grinding forward again, or maybe backwards. It doesn’t matter.

“Why do you sound so surprised?” Khaslana mumbles, letting go of the drawing once Mydei grabs it. “You paint me all the time.”

He’s not wrong, but, also, somehow, someway, this, “Is different.”

Khaslana rests his chin on his hand. “Maybe.” He replies, and then hums, looking contemplative. “Maybe not. I do think you would do far better as a

muse than I do, though.”

“Really now?”

The words come out like little butterflies.

“Hm? You have never been painted before?”

Mydei huffs. “Of course I have.” By his mother, when she lived, and then by a bunch of people back when he started getting into art again after her death and when he went into art school.

He’s no fool either, much less blind. Mydei knows he’s attractive with certainty, not vanity, enough that he knows he is appealing to capture in art.

And yet,

Nobody has drawn him the way Khaslana did.

Arguably, it’s also the worst, lacking the finesse and technique a skilled artist has. Khaslana has a good sense of perception, he will give that, but he does not know how to calculate proportions. He drew his head a little too big, his upper body a little too small. Arms a little wonky, and both his tattoos and his braid look like wavelengths. The traces aren’t firm, but he absolutely nails his face, golden eyes made with pink that look both piercing, ferocious and kind.

It’s strange.

There’s a certain innocence to it, almost. The him in the sketch gives off a firm sense of tranquility, or safety, maybe, despite the roughness of the lines —but that’s fine. Mydei wouldn’t be who he is if he weren’t more than a little rough, if he lacked the sharp lines Khaslana used.

Is this, a part of Mydei wants to ask, *how you see me?*

He doesn’t ask.

The drawing is enough of an answer.

“You are smiling.” Khaslana says, quietly. Mydei hadn’t realized. “You can laugh if you want. It’s fine.”

He shakes his head. “I like it.”

“Uh.”

“It’s nice.” He says, and it’s true. It may be the worst way he has been painted, but there’s still a certain skill peeking through the wobbly pinks and the shaky red. Not quite talent, but technique that went uncared, unnurtured, like vines in a garden that overtook the flowers. He wonders, shifts his eyes to him, and asks, “Did you used to draw?”

Khaslana’s eyes flicker down. “I never liked it.”

“Why did you start, then?”

A pause.

“...I like taking photos.” He admits, so quietly that Mydei has to lean on the table to hear him. “I had a camera, back when I was a kid, but I dropped it into the river. I didn’t want to bother my parents to buy me another one, so,” He shrugs, making a motion to the drawing. “People told me I was good—for my age, that is, so I kept doing it. I even tried to get into art school, you know.”

Mydei’s eyebrows fly to his hair.

“Did you get in?”

“No, thank Kephale. Being in a place full of artists sounds like a living nightmare.” He says, and a shudder climbs up his spine that he tries hard to dissimulate. Mydei has enough grace not to mention it. “My portfolio got accepted, though. But there was a test where you had to go into the school and draw what the examiner tells you that I didn’t pass.”

“What were you supposed to draw?”

Khaslana’s eyes drift to the side. “I don’t remember[5].”

Another pause.

“I would like to keep it, though.” Mydei speaks after it comes to be obvious Khaslana won’t say anything else on the subject.

“Why?”

“As I said, I like it.” He answers without a trace of doubt. “It’s as simple as that.”

He huffs, a little incredulous, but says, “Do what you want.” Before he asks, “What did you draw, anyways?”

With care, Mydei settles the sketch of him down on the table before he takes his own drawing and lifts it.

“Chimeras?”

“Us as chimeras, yes.”

“...Uh.”

“This” He points at one of the chimeras, the one made in pink. “Is Beagle Coconut,” He points at Khaslana, who looks very confused, “That’s you. Now this,” He points at the other chimera, the one made in red. “Is Fig Stew—”

“Why do I look like the incarnation of the devil?” Khaslana interrupts.

Mydei shifts the paper and cranes his neck to see his drawing. “You don’t look like the incarnation of the devil.” He picks up the red crayon and makes two horns on Beagle Coconut’s little fuzzy head. “Now you do.”

Khaslana looks terribly unimpressed.

“This is defamation.”

“No, it’s not.”

“Yes, it is. You made me look bad in comparison to you—And why in the world did you draw Fig Stew so cute?”

Mydei sets his drawing on the table and, in what is probably the blandest tone ever, replies, “I’m adorable.”

Khaslana blinks, slowly, eyes flickering up and down, gauging just how serious Mydei is before he hums. “I don’t see it.” He says, tilting his head in the way Mydei is quickly coming to associate with trouble. “Maybe if you made a cute face, I would.”

A what.

“A what.”

“A cute face.” He repeats. “You know,” Khaslana tilts his head again and winks at him.

It’s ridiculous, frankly, his face doesn’t even change one bit while he does so, remaining in its quiet, gentle impassiveness of always, not even a turn of lips. Ridiculous, he tells you, utterly, terribly, ridiculous—

“You are blushing, Mydei.”

“No, I am not.”

“Yes, you are.”

“There’s no word for ‘blushing’ in the Kremnoan language.”

Khaslana lets out a little ‘oh’.

“Well, your face is very red, Mydei.”

“Out of anger.”

“Because I am cute and you are not?” He asks, mirroring Mydei’s bland tone from earlier. He can’t tell if he’s being serious or not, either. “Or is it because you can’t do it?”

“Who says I can’t?” He snaps.

He can make a cute face—cuter than whatever Khaslana’s very poor attempt that definitely didn’t make him blush could be.

Distantly, a part of him wonders why he is getting so riled up by all this, before Khaslana makes a motion for him to prove it and the thought dissipates like sea-foam.

Tsk.

Mydei thinks for a second, takes a breath to shove the surge of embarrassment that threatens to overcome him, and plucks out his lips while closing his eyes.

Click!

Makes the phone camera.

Mydei goes very, very serious. “Delete that.”

“No.”

“Khaslana.”

“No.”

“Khaslana, I’m warning you.”

He locks his phone and presses it against his chest. “No.”

When the waiter finally comes back with their tab, it’s only to find Mydei trying to forcefully lift Khaslana from where he has pressed his upper body flat into the table, phone and hands tightly kept and secured under his chest like a turtle.

Mydei doesn’t ever get to delete the photo, but he does manage to lock the phone for more than an hour trying to guess the password.

This, he won’t know, but Theodoros catches Khaslana looking at it more than once.

Chapter End Notes

FOOTNOTES

1. Much more of a tragedy is to not be witness to such sight, though. Gorgo died young, very young, to the point that a wave of bittersweet sadness will hit Mydei the day, far, far away into the future, in which he starts to catch grays in his own hair and wrinkles around his eyes. Back

2. It wasn’t on purpose, not really. It’s just that Khaslana always seems to shut down the second he steps inside the art studio, like a wind-up doll running out of cord, dim and em—pty. Too many bad memories, Mydei thought, and he had adapted easily to such revelation. It is not much of a bother. Mydei has come to find he much prefers to paint Khaslana doing inane things, like stealing his fries next to a random food stand, than sitting still. Back

3. Once, Khaslana met a corpse. A ghost from the Xianzhou. He had ink for hair, rubies for eyes, linen for skin, and paint for blood. He smelled of flowers and death. He saw him some night staring at a painting of a vase with spider lilies dripping blood, hung like a dead man in an art store that was most definitely a mafia front. Khaslana had bought it for him, not exactly sure why, and watched him burn it right after. Apparently, long, long ago, the ghost had fallen in love, and the man he loved cursed him in return. “My Yingxing?” He had said his lover once said with a smile, right before his head fell, “No. As long as my art lives, he will live too.” He has been searching death ever since, but new paintings of him keep appearing. His lover reincarnates. Khaslana had told him his own story, then, in that self-destructive way that makes you want to bleed in front of someone knowing they won’t do anything to save you. In the end, the ghost had asked, “What do you want, then?” and Khaslana replied, “Nothing.” The corpse said, “Only dead men don’t want for anything, and even I

wish for death.” Struck, Khaslana admitted something, that night, next to a burning painting, but his confession isn’t meant for you. Back

4. The old woman proceeds to drag Mydei into the kitchen nearly by the hair and doesn’t let him leave until he gets it right, because she will be damned first before she lets anybody botch her recipes. Mydei gets it right on the second try. The old woman starts calling him ‘grandson’ from that day on. He’s strangely touched. Back

5. That’s a lie. It was a self-portrait. The second the word left the examiner’s lips, Khaslana set down the pencil, stood up, and left, because he only ever drew things he loved. Back

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Do you guys remember this was originally listed as only four chapters? I was insane. The chapter count is almost near fixed by now, with the possibility of it going up to 14 depending in what you guys want. See, both chapter 8 and 9 were supposed to be two, I guess you could call it 'dates' each, but I keep writing a lot and so I broke the 8 into two. In regards to the one after the next, would you guys prefer if I also broke the two 'dates' in one chapter each or if I wrote both in one single chapter? Do take into account the second option would make the update come a tad bit later than usual, but it would def be longer.

Chapter 9: Planting seeds

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Kites?”

“You don’t want to?”

“No, it’s not that.” Mydei replies, watching the colorful slips of color paper tissue peeking from the top of the black plastic bag loosely held by Khaslana’s middle finger. There are blues, purples, yellows and greens; pinks, reds, oranges and a little bit of whites and blacks. A faded blue wallet with frayed ends rests atop, thrown carelessly along with the rest of the things. “I just didn’t expect it, that's all.”

Khaslana shrugs. The brown paper bag pressed against his chest crinkles with the movement. “The theme is wind.”

Soon after the first pieces to the art competition had been submitted, an e-mail had been sent to the participants filled with meaningless chatter and hollow congratulations of this and that before having the pleasure of informing that, from now on, to incentive and prod at the limits of creativity and something else Mydei had skimmed past, themes would be introduced, before the word *‘Wind’*, in big curved red letters, declared the concept to more-or-less follow for the next installment.

After reading it, Mydei had sent a screenshot of the e-mail to Khaslana, who had replied at three in the morning with a simple, *‘I think I know what we can do.’* Mydei, when he had woken up, had replied with a simple *‘sure’* and a question of what on earth was he doing awake at that hour.

Khaslana hadn’t answered that and instead sent a photo of a lizard he found in his sink[1].

“Does it get messy?”

“Making them? A little, I guess. Depends.”

Mydei’s eyes shift to the coffee table in his living room, where Kopopo The Third has settled onto, not watching Khaslana for once but the paper bag pressed against his chest.

He hums, “Outside?”

“Sure.”

Mydei drags the chewed-up brown rubber stopper from the kitchen and places it in the space between the floor and the door to stop it from slamming closed.

It’s a little windy outside. It’s always a little windy this time of the year, when the Month of Weaving edges to its end and the winds of love start to shift to the winds of war distinctive of the Month of Strife.

Khaslana has settled onto the last stone step of Mydei’s house. The black plastic bag placed between his legs as he absentmindedly chews a little strawberry pastry. When the *‘tap, tap, tap’* of Mydei’s footsteps he shifts his head upwards before extending the brown paper bag to him.

Mydei peeks inside to find another little pastry there. Chocolate, judging by the smell, and he takes it with a, “Thanks.”

“They were on discount.” Khaslana waves off[2].

“Mm-hm.”

The stone steps aren’t particularly big, so Mydei sits on the floor, crosses his legs and pulls the black plastic bag into the gap between his legs. He takes a bite of the pastry, settles it onto his leg, and cleans his fingertips before starting to rummage inside. Color tissue papers, a spool of black thread, ribbons, a bag of wooden dowel rods, liquid glue and little blue scissors with drawings of stars still on its package.

Out of curiosity, Mydei takes the wallet on the top and opens it. There's ten bucks, little white slips of paper bills and expired coupons that he takes out to throw in the trash. The plastic edge of the identification card peeks out, and Mydei pulls it out. Khaslana looks a little bit funny in the photo of it, in the way everybody always seems to come out in these sorts of things. His signature is rather nice, although simple, and his birthday was two weeks ago.

Mydei doesn't comment on it, although some distant corner of his mind makes note of it. Instead, he looks at the year and says, a little smugly, "I'm older than you." Although not by much. A year or so.

"And I'm taller." Is Khaslana's immediate reply.

"...Tsk."

"Heh."

"I'm stealing your ten bucks." Mydei replies, closing the wallet and throwing it back onto the bag. "Where do we start?"

"The skeleton." Khaslana replies, placing his half-eaten pastry on the discarded paper bag and leaning forward to take out one of the bags of wooden rods and the spool of black thread. He smells of clean laundry and linen painted on. Unfinished work, wet paint.

Mydei wonders how long will it be before Khaslana lets it dry.

Khaslana opens the bag and passes him four rods, explains and shows to him how to tie them with the thread to form an octagon before he cuts the thread off from the spool with his own teeth.

Mydei goes along with the motions, notably a little less smoothly and more haltingly than him, and he points out, "You have done this before."

Khaslana hums an affirmative, bringing a gloved hand to hold one of the wooden rods in place as Mydei ties them. "Not for a long time." He says.

"Why is that?"

“Wasn’t much of a reason.”

“And there was before?”

“I suppose.” He shrugs, taking his hand away when the wooden rod is set tight. There’s a little pause as Mydei goes to tie the last one, almost as if he’s dwelling on continuing, before he adds, “There used to be a festival close to where I lived. Something about the dead, I think. Evil spirits bothered the good ones, and the sound of the paper against the wind drove away the bad ones.” He makes a vague gesture to the skeleton’s kite in Mydei’s hands. “So, they made these big, beautiful kites that would cover the whole expanse of the sky—It always reminded me of a kaleidoscope, you know.”

“You used to go help, I gather.”

“Just with the little ones. I wasn’t that good. I always used too much glue, so they always ended up a bit soggy.” Another pause. “I haven’t gone back[3].”

Mydei’s eyes flicker to him before he returns to his work.

“Why is that?” He asks yet again.

And, “No reason.” He replies. When Mydei turns to him, blue eyes drift away from his gaze. Then, almost casually, “Does Kremnos have anything like that?”

Hm.

“You aren’t particularly subtle.” Not to mention a very bad liar, as always, but Mydei has already told him that before, and he isn’t one to repeat himself if it is not needed, and he suspects Khaslana is very much aware of the fact. “But, no, Kremnos does not have any tradition like that. The dead recognized are the ones deemed strong in life, so the idea we would have to do something to protect them is laughable at best.”

“What of the weak ones?”

“Forgotten.”

Mydei frees the little blue scissors with drawings of stars from the package and cuts the thread from the spool and finishes tying it.

Khaslana’s eyes are low, and he is absentmindedly dragging one of his feet back and forwards, back and forwards, back and forwards, on the ground with a *‘crish, crish’*, dragging dirt and dirtying the tip of his red basketball shoes—The ones that Mydei gave him that time he lost one in the creek[4]. Laces tied up, for once, without Mydei’s prompting, and he can see a peek of purple and yellow under it, no doubt yet another pair of ugly socks.

He seems a little bit distant, almost, as if…

One of Mydei’s eyebrows raises.

“Does the notion sadden you?”

Khaslana scoffs, “It *is* a sad notion.”

“That’s a way to put it.”

“How would you put it, then?”

Mydei blinks, a little taken aback at the question, though, maybe, it is one he should have been expecting.

He has never given it much thought before, truth be told.

“Harsh,” He replies after a beat. “But so is life.”

The wind blows, chilly, gentle, and a little bit wild. The end of love, the beginnings of war. It lifts dead leaves off the ground into a dance, whistling through windows without glass, bags crinkling and shifting with a soft sound, raised dirt. It steals the little breath Khaslana lets out, ever-intent, ever-bent, on taking him with him, like yet another dead leaf, but his presence is warm at his side, undoubtedly alive, undoubtedly present, and so the wind fails to steal his words away.

Maybe, just maybe, that’s the reason why world does not still, and neither does Mydei, when Khaslana says, quietly, certainly, melancholic, “I would remember you,” while he takes a sheet of color paper tissue as orange as Mydei’s hair from the bag, “If you died.”

He lifts an eyebrow, and, dryly, asks, “Are you calling me weak?”

Khaslana lets out a sound that could very well be a chuckle—as if the mere idea was ridiculous.

“No, not at all. If anything, you are the strongest person I know. But,” His eyes shift. The deep, deep depths of the blue, blue sea swirling as he looks directly at him. “You wouldn’t need to be for me to remember you.”

Mydei laughs.

No, the world doesn’t still, and neither does he; if anything, his heart beats. He wouldn’t be alive, otherwise.

“You are so very sentimental,” He answers. It’s even a bit surprising, Mydei thinks, how much Khaslana’s heart bleeds, perhaps even foolish. “I’m not dying anytime soon.”

Khaslana does not reply.

The ‘*snip*’ of the unpacked scissors cuts that trail of conversation as effectively as it starts to cut the sheet of orange paper in his cold, pale hands.

The process of putting the color paper tissue on the skeleton of the kite is rather simple enough, Khaslana explains. It’s basically putting glue on the wooden dowel rods and on the thread and placing the paper there. The hard part is actually making it look good.

Mydei opted for making a lion’s face with reds and yellows, along with a wild mane made out of different colored ribbons because there aren't

enough orange ribbons while Khaslana simply puts different colors in every gap, like a kaleidoscope of sorts, little triangles made with pinks, greens, oranges, reds, purples, yellows and grays.

It’s in the middle of Mydei attempting to make an eye with white and black paper that Kopopo the Third attempts to steal his half-eaten chocolate pastry.

“No.” Mydei says, firmly, raising both the kite and the pastry up into the sky. Kopopo the Third, from his position on his lap where he ended up falling, yowls as if he was being murdered. “Chocolate is bad for you.”

Kopopo the Third yowls again.

Movement from the corner of his eye catches his eye, and he shifts his head to see Khaslana breaking in half the little piece of strawberry pastry he has left before placing it on the floor.

“Don’t indulge him.”

“It’s not for him. It’s for the ants.”

“And what if he takes it?”

“Strawberries aren’t bad for cats in small quantities. Nothing bad would happen to him.” Khaslana replies, pauses, and adds, a little haltingly, “If he were to steal it from the ants, that is.”

“Sure.”

“It’s just a little bit.”

“And he’s already fat.”

Kopopo the Third mewls, indignat.

“Don’t call him fat. He’s cute.”

Kopopo the Third scrunches his little nose, as if being in agreement with Khaslana disgusted him.

Slowly, he pushes himself off Mydei's lap and lands gently on the floor with his ears flattened back, as if ready to pounce and attack, as his little fuzzy face goes from Khaslana's impassive face to the little piece of pastry left for him.

One minute passes, two, maybe even three.

Haltingly, his cat starts to walk up to the piece of food, step by step, fuzzy paws soundless against the floor before his face lowers and he sniffs it a couple of times.

Then, he sits.

Khaslana blinks.

Kopopo the Third mewls at him, sharply[5].

Khaslana tilts his head.

Kopopo the Third also tilts his head.

"...It's for you." Khaslana admits.

Kopopo the Third lets out a sound that resembles a scoff, which is a little bit weird to hear coming from a cat.

And then, as fast as a light, his cat grabs the little piece of strawberry pastry left for him off the ground before darting back into his house. He stops at the door, twists his head to see him, hisses loudly, and disappears into the kitchen[6].

Khaslana lets out a hum. "I didn't think he would actually accept it." He says, and even though his face is still impassive, he sounds strangely pleased.

It's a little bit funny.

A little *‘crack’* of a branch being stepped on comes from behind him, and a chilling, ruthless sense of foreboding crawls up like a hundred thousand spiders in Mydei’s back. When he turns around, it is to find the kids with plastic balls, rope and chalk standing a couple of steps behind him.

The kid who doesn’t eat their veggies narrows his eyes at them while the girl with the purple spinning top tilts her head and asks, “Whatcha doing?”

Ever so slowly, as if movement might get them pouncing on them like a cat towards a mouse, Mydei turns his head around yet again to face Khaslana. Discreetly, he takes the rest of his chocolate pastry and eats it in one go to keep them from stealing it.

Khaslana’s lips twitch, and he coughs to dissimulate a laugh.

“Kites.” He tells them while Mydei tries not to choke on the pastry. A faint rustle of paper arises as he lifts his own to show them.

The kids’ eyes light up.

The little girl with chalks sprints first and plops down next to Mydei, letting all her chalks fall and clatter to the floor, leaving tiny dots of color in the concrete like little stars or distant galaxies. “I want to make kites, too!” She demands. The rest of her friends follow suit.

One of them steals the last bit of Khaslana’s strawberry pastry.

“So,” The little girl with chalks starts, hands full of dried glue as she places a sheet of pink paper above the skeleton of her kite. She’s making Godzilla, but pink. “When is the wedding?”

Mydei, helping the boy with the green spinning top cut purple paper for his own, blinks once, twice and then thrice, not fully registering the words. “What?”

“The wedding.” She repeats. “That’s what people who date do. They marry and then they kill their husband.”

“Uh.”

“I want to be the flower boy.” The boy with the green spinning top pipes at his side.

Mydei opens his mouth, but the girl with the purple spinning top chimes from where Khaslana is helping her tie the wooden rods for her kite, “Not fair! I wanted to be the flower girl!”

Khaslana blinks. “Um.”

“Nu-uh! I already said I would be! You can be the ring girl.”

“But *I* wanted to be the ring boy.” The kid who doesn’t eat their veggies scoffs.

“You can’t be the ring boy.” The little girl with chalks interrupts. “You already were the ring boy for the kind old woman’s wedding last week.[7]”

“But—!”

“We are not getting married.” Mydei cuts in with a sigh.

All the kids go silent, incredulous, almost.

The little girl with chalks settles his pink kite on the floor, turns to him and, with the sort of dead, lifeless tone only a person who has worked a nine to five every day for the last thirty-four years could have, asks, “Do I look stupid to you, Mister Painter?”

Mydei opens his mouth, closes it, but before he can muster a semblance of an answer, the girl with the purple spinning top says, “That’s not very nice to tell the person you are dating.”

“We are not dating.” Khaslana replies.

“But you guys go on dates all the time?”

“They are not dates.”

She stares at Khaslana before turning to her friends.

“They may be stupid.”

“Very stupid.” The boy with the green spinning top agrees.

The kid who doesn’t eat their veggies stands up abruptly, kite left discarded, and walks up to Mydei with the certainty of a war general.

“Does this mean,” He demands, crossing his little arms. “You haven’t kissed him?”

“No.” Mydei replies.

“Wimp.”

“Wimp?”

“Wimp!” Khaslana repeats as he breaks into a fit of laughter, loud and bright, like the chime of a bell, picked, dry lips stretched wide into a smile as his shoulders shake.

It’s as breathtaking as the first time he heard it, perhaps more, because the cobwebs have un-stuck from his throat and his tongue dusted off ash. Mydei’s fingers twitch, half-regretting he didn’t bring out something to paint him, sketch him, empty linen or empty pages to fill with warm, bright colors; although, the emotion is dampened, a little, by the knowledge Khaslana is laughing at him.

It pisses Mydei so much his heart skips a beat or two, maybe even three.

He opens his mouth, but the kid who doesn’t eat their veggies beats him to it, turning his head around like an owl and, rather eerily, saying, “Don’t think I have forgotten about you.”

Khaslana’s mouth shuts with a sharp *‘click!’*.

All the kids, smelling weakness, cats to a canary, sharks smelling blood, turn their little heads towards him and stare with their piercing little eyes.

“That’s—”

“Why haven’t *you* kissed him?”

Khaslana’s eyes flicker to him in a silent plea for help. Mydei ignores it. Ha, that’s what you get for laughing, jackass.

“...Can we go back to making fun of Mydei?”

“No.” The kid who doesn’t eat their veggies replies immediately.

“We are making fun of you now.” The boy with the green spinning top says.

“Now, answer.” The girl with the purple spinning top demands.

“I already said we aren’t dating—”

“Because you haven’t kissed.”

“It’s not like that—”

“But you are his muse!” The little girl with chalks pipes in. “All artists kiss their muses.”

“No, they don’t.”

“Yes, they do.”

“...I think I would know.”

The little girl with chalks scoffs, as if she thought he was being dumb.

Khaslana looks mildly offended at the notion.

Suddenly, “You don’t like him?” The kid who doesn’t eat their veggies, and who also seems terribly invested in their love life, asks, looking scandalized. “Is that it? You don’t like him?”

“Is that why you don’t break into his house?” The boy with the green spinning top continues, and, ignoring Mydei’s *‘For the last time, they don’t break in. They just have spare keys’* the girl with the purple one gasps with a, “Is that why you knock?”

The lips of the little girl with chalks wobbles, as if she were about to cry. Khaslana makes a sound akin to that of a strangled cat at the sight.

“Ah, don’t cry—”

“But you don’t like him!” She hiccups.

“I like him.” Khaslana replies, gently. It’s stupid, but it makes something in Mydei’s chest feel warm. “He’s, ah, a very nice person and—”

“But you haven’t kissed him.”

“And you don’t break into his house.” The boy with the green spinning top interrupts. He seems oddly hell-bent on it, for some weird, weird reason.

Khaslana answers, “Because we are only friends.”

All the kids go silent, quiet, eyes flickering from him to Mydei, who nods in confirmation.

They all turn to each other.

“Adults are so dumb, aren’t they?” The kid who doesn’t eat their veggies asks.

They all nod in unison and, unceremoniously, go back to making kites.

A pause.

“Kids are so strange.” Khaslana sighs.

Mydei makes a faint sound of agreement at his side.

They finish their kites as Aquila up in the sky begins to doze off, the blues high above bleeding into warm oranges and rich reds like watercolors diluting in water. Some of the light posts have turned on as Khaslana ties a long piece of thread in the center of every kite so that they can rise high, high up and not lose.

It’s a little bit cold by now. The frigid exhales of Oronyx sweeping into the world. Some of the kids run into their houses for a sweater to wear before running back outside, leaving trails of mud and dust in the ceramic tiles of their houses as the wind picked up; mischievous gusts of air that rustle the leaves of the tall, tall trees. It makes it so that the kites rise high with little to no prompting, but the kids still run between laugh and laugh to lift them up, either way.

“I’m a little worried they might run them into one of the electric cables, electrocute and then die.” Khaslana says as he moves his hand side to side, making his kaleidoscope kite swish this or that way in the sky.

Mydei lets out a startled chuckle, watching as the wind pushes the colorful ribbons of the mane of his lion kite. It’s fun. “They won’t die.” He tells him. “At most, they will feel a little electric shock—I am more worried they might cause a blackout in the block.”

“Oh, well,” Khaslana shrugs, making his kite bump into Mydei’s. “I don’t live here, so I don’t have to worry about that.”

“Ah!” One of the kids cries at their back. Both of them jump and turn their heads around sharply. “My kite!”

Khaslana lets go of his kite and runs to catch the kid’s.

Mydei scrambles to catch Khaslana’s. His whole arm snapping up towards the thin line of black thread floating in the air, swaying side to side, almost in mockery when the tips of his fingertips graze it before the wind picks up

and pushes the kite far, far up in the sky, out of his reach, like grains of sand slipping past the gaps of his hands.

The kids cheer behind.

He turns his head back to see that Khaslana has caught the kid's kite and bent down to tie the black thread around their wrist, securing it, and the rest of the bunch crowd around him with extended arms so that he can tie their kites to them too.

The kaleidoscope dances above, all on its own, swaying side to side.

Khaslana is a rather lonely person, isn't he?

Mydei stares at the kite, drifting away. He's no romanticist, has never been, will never be, but he can't help but think that, eventually, the wind will die down, and Khaslana's little multicolored thing will fall somewhere. Forgotten and alone, and the color paper will tear and the wooden rods break.

Khaslana won't be sad about it, he thinks, knows, but Mydei is, a little bit, inexplicably so.

Golden eyes shift from the kaleidoscope kite and shift to his lion kite with its wild, multicolored mane and round eyes, and, rather impulsively, Mydei lets it go.

He watches it fly after the other one for a second before turning around and walking up to the rest in quiet steps as the other finishes tying strings of black threads around little wrists.

"Mm?" He lets out as Mydei appears, standing up and turning to him. "Where's your kite?"

Mydei points at the sky.

"Oh."

The lion kite flies high, high up and bumps into the kaleidoscope kite, making them tumble and spin around in the sky. The black threads of each twist and loop around, tangling together until they start to drift side to side.

Click!

Makes the phone camera at his side.

The painting Mydei creates is rather simple, truth be told, a plain orange background with two kites flying together high in the sky, as Khaslana watches them from behind, phone held loosely in his hand.

It's nothing big, just a little memory preserved in paint, titled *Two Kites*.

Chapter End Notes

FOOTNOTES

1. He does that a lot. He also likes taking pictures of Mydei whenever they agree to meet somewhere else and sending them to him along with a simple 'see you' instead of walking up to him and saying 'hi' like a normal person. He seems to get a kick out of seeing him search for him even if he doesn't show it. A part of Mydei thinks he just likes to be found. Back

2. They weren't. Back

3. Not since Cyrene died and his home burned, either way. A little bit contradictory, maybe, seeing the purpose of the festivities, but the only thing Khaslana can think about when he looks at the big, kaleidoscope kites is that Cyrene hadn't had a hand in making them yet again, never again. Back

4. Khaslana had tried to give them back the next day, but Mydei had waved him off and told them to keep it. They were always a bit too big on his feet, anyways. Back

5. He means to say, "Hmph! You think you can bribe my affections, strange entity that bleeds paint?" But, contrary to popular belief,

Khaslana doesn’t speak cat, so he doesn’t understand him. Back

6. “This doesn’t mean anything, you hear me?” He means to say. Khaslana still doesn’t speak cat. Back

7. Her husband disappears mysteriously the following month. Back

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I do love the trope of characters being good with kids, but I love more kids bullying the absolute hell of adults. It's fun.

Anyways, I read through the comments (and you are all so kind ;_;) and, after some consideration, I decided to break the following chapter into two. One of them said that it would make the little dates stand out their own and I agree!! So, 14 chapters it will be, really really this time. Also, I made a twitter account, I don't have many much interesting things to say, truth be told, but you can find me as @lowlowdmg ^^

Chapter 10: Growing plants in burnt soil

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The sound of the slap echoes and resonates through the silent industrialized walls of The Irontomb like the furious rumbling of thunder before lighting that gives way to a forest fire, engulfing, devouring and burning down the trees and the flowers to nothing but cinders and ash; blackened earth, smoke in the air.

A bunch of gasps from the two or three people littering about the halls of an art gallery on a Monday afternoon arise as Lygus' head snaps crudely to the side and the breath Khaslana lets out seems to crackle.

"Your opinion is as misguided as it is unwanted, not to mention repetitive and uninspired." In the quiet that has frozen the space in place, Khaslana's voice thunders, incinerates, and razors, hell on earth, even though it doesn't rise. "We, unfortunately, have had this conversation a thousand times before, and your view of art[1] is still as flawed as the first time I ever had the displeasure of hearing it—It's a complete waste of talent, I dare say."

Melting heat irradiates in the air, burnt earth, but when Mydei exhales, steadily, calmly, sparks don't come out of his breath.

Somewhere along the way, without none of them knowing, silently, intrinsically, intimately, they had fallen into a routine, of sorts. All Mondays without fail, following a new entry to the art competition and The Irontomb is near deserted, Khaslana will come to see the painting he presented, and, all Mondays without fail, Mydei will meet him there. Afterwards, depending on the hour, they either go for breakfast or lunch.

He had run late, today, for no particular reasons worth lingering on about, the sort of innocuous little things from day-to-day life that pile up here and there and made it so that he hadn't even had the chance to change out of his gym clothes.

The faint smell of sweat clings faintly to him.

There were a couple of things Mydei was expecting when he entered The Irontomb. The little mundanities of a routine. The few guards standing on the sides, the reception man asking him for a synonym for some word as he *taps, taps, taps* the chewed pencil on the counter while doing yet another crossword[2], and Khaslana, either lingering on the children's section of the art competition or near the space of the painting Mydei had made; toying with his phone, maybe, and a demand for him to pay that day for making him wait so long.

He was not expecting, however, to turn the corner and be met with the immediate sight of the curator finishing saying something or another to Khaslana with a razor-sharp smile before the man whirled around and slapped him so hard that Lygus nearly collapsed onto the floor.

Mydei's hand closes into a fist.

He can feel the phantom sensation of the sting.

Khaslana lets out another breath, sparks coming out, a lighter lit up, and he burns, burns, burns inside out and inside in as he spits, "Don't ever talk to me again, Lycurgus."

Having said that, he turns around, and walks away towards the door on the other side of the room. He's not running. He is much too valiant for that, a part of Mydei believes, and, perhaps, much too proud, though, that may not be the right word. It's fine. He's a painter, not a writer, and much less a poet. He only knows that Khaslana's steps, firm, but ever silent, seem to scorch the floor beneath him.

Mydei's footsteps aren't silent as he walks after him, but no less firm because of that, although they certainly don't burn.

Two Kites hangs next to *Polyxia's Petals In The Sky*, and Mydei's eyes shift to his own painting, almost absentmindedly, before the *'plam, plam, plam'* of his steps slowly comes to a halt.

For a second, just one second, a brief, fleeting instance of time under Oronyx's melancholic sighs, *Two Kites* seems no different from the rest of the paintings displayed at The Irontomb. Beautiful, in its own way, but thriving on destruction of some kind, rejoicing in it, because the soft oranges of the warmth of the sunset start to resemble more the warmth of the burn—ing fire.

"Unfitting, isn't it?" Lygus says, the beginnings of madness, the end of humanity, "Such gentle strokes don't fit a thing like Khaslana."

His fist tightens, nails digging into the palm of his hand.

What a rotten belief.

Mydei shakes his head and looks at the painting again. Madness is alluring, and sinking is easy, and, yet, "No," He answers, because he remembers the warmth of that day. The taste of a chocolate pastry on his tongue, the child's rambunctious laughter, the sound of the paper tissue fluttering against the wind, warding off bad spirits as a lion kite entangled with a kaleidoscope one. "They fit him just fine."

Lygus chuckles, soft, a little condescending.

Mydei doesn't know how Antikytheran's work, truth be told, so he's not sure what exactly is the dark, dark liquid that slowly starts to trickle down Lygus' mechanical nose. Oil instead of blood, maybe. It falls down onto the porcelain floor with a drip-drip-dripping sound, staining the ornate designs made in gold.

How hard must Khaslana have had to hit for him to hurt a being solely made of metal?

In practiced motions, Lygus retrieves a silk handkerchief out of his pocket. It's white, with an owl embroidered in the corner, and it's covered in washed-out black stains that now look gray.

Mydei's eyes narrow.

“What did you say to him?”

Lygus smiles. “Nothing he doesn’t know already.”

He opens his mouth to reply before he notices Khaslana isn’t in the room anymore. With a click of tongue and a scoff, he moves past Lygus to chase after the other.

He catches up to him as he is exiting The Irontomb, long legs walking along with long strides, making quick work of the few steps outside the entrance.

“Khaslana.”

He does not reply.

“Khaslana.” Mydei calls again, a tad bit louder, a tad bit harsher.

He does not reply.

Mydei scoffs, picking up his pace a little bit. One of his hands goes to catch Khaslana’s wrist to stop him, his name already on the tip of his tongue, but before he can even form the first syllable, Khaslana yanks his arm out of his hold and keeps walking.

A beat.

He grits his teeth and grabs his wrist once again, “Khaslana.” Mydei demands, this time, his hold tightening when the man attempts to yank himself free again. “Where are you going?”

Khaslana stops.

Silence trickles drip by drip into the space like water flooding a ship before it stretches like bubblegum held between teeth. The outskirts of The Irontomb are empty, save for them two, and the world stutters from where it spins, as if unsure whether to halt, for a second, for them, or to continue.

It doesn’t stop, though, for it could not care less about the insignificant occurrences and happenings in their lives, and silence remains as the sun

shines bright, burns bright.

As a mercy, or maybe a cruelty, up above, a long, big cloud slowly comes to cover it, like a ship left adrift, covering the unbearingly hot light of the star, casting long, dark shadows over them as the faint sound of the wind howls like the crackle of firewood burning down.

“Let go.” Khaslana says.

“Where are you going?” Mydei asks again.

“Away.”

“Hmph,” He lets out. “And where is that?”

Khaslana turns his head around to see him, locks of white hair bouncing with the movement like tumbling snow in an avalanche, and a lesser man would have probably cowered at the rage burning like a million stars in his blue, lightless eyes, spreading like a wildfire, consuming, devouring, burning.

Mydei, who grew in between honor and strife, where everyone is adjacent, intimate, well-prepared, to the concept of conquest, war, thinks Khaslana would do well in one.

It would break him, irreparably, he’s much too kind for that, much too sensitive, but he would do well, probably even use the little broken parts of himself as ammunition; and a part of him wonders if, back, back then, he should have been more worried about him burning down to ash instead of the wind chipping marble into dust.

He shakes his head.

Khaslana raises his chin, defiant, angry, and Mydei doesn't cower one bit, meeting the fire burning and crackling head on.

“Don’t make me repeat myself, Mydeimos,” He demands, yanking again. “Let go.”

He tightens his grip around his wrist, not enough to bruise, but certainly not scared to do so if it means that Khaslana won't disappear like mist in the night, sea foam in water, wood in the pyre, ash in the wind.

"Mydei—"

"Have you eaten?" He interrupts, not exactly sure of what to say but very well-knowing he has to say something, anything.

Khaslana's anger doesn't recede, and neither does it soften, but the tension in his shoulders falls slightly, and he stops trying to yank himself free as he lets out a dumbfounded, "...What?" That all but echoes in the empty, empty space.

He hasn't, turns out.

The maze of paths and streets that surround the plaza has no shortage of restaurants and diners, cafes and holes in the wall, food stands and carts moving along the cobblestone with a *'racka, racka, racka'* filled with candy, a cooler with ice cream, or sliced bits of fruit. It means there's much to pick and choose.

Khaslana does not choose, though, and a part of Mydei, a foolish one, maybe, probably, ridiculous in its softness, honest in its care, half-wishes to just take Khaslana to his home and cook him something himself.

Still, he didn't bring his car today, and the walk from the plaza to his house on foot is far, far too long.

There isn't really a place Mydei has in mind to take the other for that very reason. Though, he doesn't worry too much about it, opting to walk around the place, eyeing the different options there are as Khaslana walks silently at his side.

The cathedral, with its colorful stained glass of long-forgotten saints and paint-stained balcony, rises in the distance, not as tall as The Irontomb, but

imposing enough to draw attention. The bell tolls, marking the pass of yet another hour, the sound echoing through the streets.

A stray dog without an ear eating the scraps of rice somebody threw in the trash growls at Khaslana once it sees him while a black dog licking the mouth of a drunkard passed out between a police commissary and a casino whose bets are most surely illegal stares at him with its red eyes before tilting its head.

They take a detour before the stray dog starts chasing them, turning into a street without a number where an old lady with a glass eye and a golden tooth sitting at the feet of a morgue that used to be a school scams a bunch of tourists with plastic trinkets and cheap imitations of this painting or the other. One of them pays for an overpriced wooden butterfly while another looks between copies of *A Chess Master's Last Piece* and *Spectator of Life.* An unfinished imitation of Mydei's *Khaslana*[3] peeks under the edges of *Missing Heart.*

They keep walking. They get lost.

None of them worry, though, in between this maze of paths and streets, it is not strange for one to find themselves lost. Sometimes, people say, it's as if the locations of certain shops, houses and restaurants changed places from one moment to the other.

Eventually, as they turn onto another street with its number upside down, at the very end, a modest hotel without a name rests. Mydei had stayed there, once, when he first came to this city and was searching for a place to move into. The room had been too cramped, the bathroom probably haunted, and the outdoor pool on the last floor so cold that Hephaestion had gotten hypothermia.

The food in the restaurant below had been pretty nice, though.

Mydei doesn't particularly bother asking Khaslana if he wants to eat there, and Khaslana doesn't particularly bother asking where they are going. Mydei walks, and he follows.

If it is out of trust or out of lack of care, he isn't particularly sure. Nevertheless, he tries to be responsible with whatever is that he's been given.

The inside of the place is dim lit. A hard attempt to appear classy that, in reality, only serves for the place to resemble more a stereotypical tavern where pirates of old would sing lo and about. The wooden tables, wooden chairs, wooden floors, wooden ceiling and wooden counter at the back only serve to drive further the point.

Khaslana grimaces at the cramped space. Mydei has to resist the urge to chuckle at it, though the glare sent his way tells him his amusement does not go unnoticed. He asks him what he wants, Khaslana says that whatever is fine, and when Mydei tells him to go pick a table, he immediately makes a beeline to the ones set outside on a little balcony that resembles more of a dock.

The restaurant does not have any waiters, mostly because they all get lost, and so Mydei spends about fifteen minutes in the queue to order something. Once he reaches the counter, he makes quick work to ask for the steak, for him, and a salad with a bowl of fruit, because Khaslana's appetite varies widely between eating thrice his weight in one sitting or taking one or two little bites before he pushes his plate towards Mydei, and he doesn't look much hungry right now.

He also orders two milkshakes, vanilla and pomegranate[4], mostly because he just feels like having one, though, distantly, he remembers his mother once saying everything is better with a little bit of ice cream. He's given both and then shooed away with a disgruntled *'come back in twenty minutes for your food'*.

Outside, the wind is dead. The airs of war, the drums of battle, and the cries for glory proper of the Month of Strife settled down like the death-filled quiet that follows the aftermath of a battle. The cloud engulfing the burning light of the sun has yet to go, and instead of dead bodies littering the ground, the balcony is filled with wooden tables with big black umbrellas in the middle.

It’s empty, today, save for the man in far too polished of a suit with a fedora reading the newspaper as a black case rests at his side, a girl tapping something or another into her phone and Khaslana, seated at the far edge of the balcony with a cigarette on hand, staring down emptily at a piece of paper as a person with graphite smudges on their palms and a sketchbook under their arm fidgets nervously at his side.

Mydei’s eyes narrow.

He walks towards the table with firm steps. The *plam, plam, plam* of his feet against the wood resonates and vibrates, unfaltering, but the person seems so enthralled by Khaslana they hardly even notice, body swaying side to side like a ship left adrift, about to sink, sink, sink.

“—You are not going to convince anybody,” Khaslana’s voice drifts as he gets closer. Monotonous, flat, a little distant. *Em–pty*. His hand taps the paper on the table with his gloved hand. “To model for you if what you present them is an unfinished product.”

The artist flinches at the words, even when the tone isn’t even particularly harsh. The sketchbook under their arm falls to the floor with a fluttering noise. A hundred thousand loose sheets of paper with doodles and sketches scatter through the balcony like dismembered limbs.

More than half of them are of Khaslana.

All incomplete. All unfinished.

The artist scrambles to pick them all up with apologies and shaking hands, shoving them all under the black covers of the sketchbook carelessly, folding, crumpling, shredding and breaking the sketches.

Mydei, who certainly isn’t a bleeding heart but certainly isn’t cruel and much less indifferent, would be much more inclined to help them pick all of their drawings if not for the way Khaslana’s hand, the one holding the cigarette, comes to pick-pick-pick at his bitten lips.

Instead, he sidesteps the loose sheets of paper scattered across the floor and places both milkshakes on the table with a loud *‘tap’*.

“I didn’t know you smoked.”

Khaslana’s head turns to him, swirling eyes blinking once, twice, before he registers the words, and he scoffs, some life returning to him as he bites, “If you are going to tell me it’s bad for my health, then zip it, Mydei. I don’t want to hear it.”

Mydei’s eyebrow raises, and he takes seat in the empty chair between the artist and Khaslana.

“I am not one to tell you the ways in which you should or should not accelerate your own death.” He replies, plainly. “You can make your own decisions.”

The glare sent his way is entirely unimpressed.

“You say it as if I smoked five packs a day.”

“Mm.”

Khaslana sighs, takes a drag, and the smoke filters through the gaps of his teeth like rot as he speaks.

“I only do it when I’m stressed.”

Mydei’s eyes flicker from his face to the piece of paper settled like a sentence on the wooden table. It’s a simple sketch, made in pencil, all long, elegant lines that constitute Khaslana’s rather lonely-looking figure. The face’s area is smudged, almost crumpled, and a hundred dozen lines, the imprint of a hundred thousand empty eyes, that the eraser couldn’t remove remain.

An orange, almost red dot burns in the middle of the page, the edge of a cigarette.

His eyes go further down, then, past the sketch, past the table, to the floor. Two cigarette ends lay extinguished next to two red basketball shoes. One tied, another untied. Another sheet of paper rests there, too, but before Mydei can make out the lines and forms, a graphite-smudged hand snatches it.

With a jump, the artist stands up again. The sketchbook now tightly pressed against their chest, pages peeking from under the hard covers.

They clear their throat, embarrassed. “So, uh,” They shift, not even acknowledging Mydei. “You really won’t let me draw you…?”

“You can do whatever you want. I can’t stop you.” Khaslana replies, flatly. “But, if you are asking whether I will model for you or not. Then, I’m afraid my answer hasn’t changed.”

“Why not?”

“I’m not interested.”

“That’s not an answer.” They reply immediately. Khalsana’s eye twitches, almost irritated, and the hand holding the cigarette flexes and tightens. “I have seen you in The Irontomb—The paintings made of you, I mean, and *Thus Burns the Dawn* is simply…” They sigh, dreamlike, and when they look at Khaslana, it’s as if they were seeing something ethereal, indescribable, unreal. “You are clearly not opposed to being someone’s muse, why can’t you be mine?”

Khaslana takes another drag of his cigarette.

They frown.

“What’s so different between them and me?”

“It’s not about y—”

“Is my art not good enough for you?”

Their fingers are knuckle-white around the sketchbook.

Khaslana lets out a low, deliberate breath and, wordlessly, Mydei shifts in his seat so that his body comes to shield most of him. It's a rather futile endeavour, truth be told, Khaslana is no small man, he's even a little bit taller than Mydei, but it is enough so that the artist's eyes snap towards him instead, fleetingly, almost annoyed before they go back to the other.

"You are not impossible to draw." They continue. The words are pleading, but the tone is demanding. "You have been painted more than once in only a few months by that Mydeimos—"

"You mean me?" Mydei interrupts.

The artist flinches as if they had been slapped, and their eyes are wide as they turn towards him, looking as if his presence hadn't actually fully registered to them before, only Khaslana's, always Khaslana's. "*You?*" They ask, incredulous. "What did you do to make him pose for you?"

Mydei's nose scrunches, disgusted at the implications.

"I asked." He replies.

"I *am* asking." They bite, and turn back to Khaslana. "I could finish drawing you too. He's nothing special."

Khaslana scoffs. "And that's why you gave me an unfinished sketch?"

"That's—!"

"And none of the others seemed completed, either."

"Because I didn't have good enough of a reference!" They snap. "If you just let me—!"

One of their hands shoots forward to grab Khaslana's.

The wooden table scratches and digs against the floor with an ear-grating sound, nails on a board, scissors cut-cut-cutting through skin and bone, and the salt container tumbles down, scattering little white crystals through the

brown surface like falling, dying stars. The milkshakes wobble precariously, like old pillars about to collapse.

Mydei's hand closes around their wrist before they can even so much as graze Khaslana.

The whole balcony seems to freeze at the action.

A low, long inhale comes from behind him, and Mydei's head shifts just enough to watch as Khaslana exhales a cloud of gray, gray smoke. His face is impassive, but the hand that had been resting on the table has come to rest on his lap.

"As I said," Khaslana says, monotone, tight, a little distant. Some ash falls from the cigarette down onto his white, clean pants, and his eyes, glassy blue things, latch onto the gray stain. His eyebrow twitches. "I'm not interested."

The artist's hand jerks, and he tightens his hold around their wrist. He turns towards them, watching as they open their mouth to say something probably more biting than the last. But, there must be something in Mydei's gaze as he stares at the artist, because they shut his mouth with a *'click!'*

Their hand jerks yet again.

Mydei lets it go, this time, and watches pointedly as the artist brings it towards their chest.

They look at Mydei, then to Khaslana, and back to Mydei once again before they swallow, taking one step back, two, three, and halting at four.

Mydei raises an eyebrow at them.

The artist all but scrambles out of the balcony.

The door closes with enough force to rattle the whole wooden structure under their feet. The cloud above them stretches and expands above them, like cotton pulled too far, letting some of the bright rays of sun filter down to earth like little fish in a big net. The girl who was tapping something or

another on her phone looks rattled, eyes flickering anxiously to them and the door while the man in far too polished of a suit with a fedora keeps reading the newspaper.

Mydei, once again, turns to Khaslana, who is still watching the gray ash stain.

“I brought you a milkshake.”

The words are firm, certain, as Mydei always is, but they still come out more gently than he intended.

Khaslana’s eyes flicker towards the milkshakes in the table and instead of taking one, he takes a drag of his cigarette.

Mydei waits, and, after a couple more minutes, Khaslana sighs, “You are ridiculous.” He says, but, nevertheless, grabs the pomegranate one, takes a sip, and makes a face at it.

Despite the situation, Mydei still finds it in himself to be amused at the reaction, “What is it?”

“...I thought it was strawberry.”

“You didn’t like it.”

“No, it’s fine.” He replies, taking another sip. He doesn’t make a face, this time, though he still doesn’t look as if he liked it. Mydei does not grab the vanilla one and Khasana repeats , sounding exhausted, “You truly are ridiculous.”

“For the milkshakes?”

“For this,” He waves a hand in the general direction of the table before picking up the salt container again. “It was unnecessary.”

“Unnecessary.” Mydei repeats, flatly.

Khaslana shrugs, brushing the salt crystals off the table. The little things fall and snake their way into the gaps left by the wood, like sugar drilling cavities.

Mydei looks at him.

“How often does this happen?”

He picks up the sketch, looks at it, eyes drifting through the desperate strokes. “I have told you before, haven’t I? Not everybody has your self-restraint.”

“Khaslana.”

“It’s fine.”

“Fine.” Mydei scoffs. Khaslana’s eye twitches. “You looked like you were about to put out the cigarette on them.”

His head jerks upwards. “I *wasn’t.”*

“I never said you would. I am saying you looked like you wanted to.”

Khaslana’s mouth opens, closes, and takes a long, slow drag of his cigarette instead of answering him.

“It pisses you off, doesn’t it?”

“You already asked me that question before.”

“And you didn’t answer.” Mydei replies, plucking the paper from Khaslana’s hand and settling it down on the table in a way the sketch isn’t seen. “Not concretely, at least.”

“I said there’s no use getting mad about it.”

“So, you do get mad about it.”

“I didn’t say that.”

“Didn’t you?”

“Maybe.” He all but spits, admits. He takes another drag and, as the smoke curls around every syllable he speaks, Mydei imagines him setting fire to his own heart. “But what does it matter? How people see me won’t change.”

“I changed.” Mydei replies easily.

“That doesn’t count.”

“Why not?”

“Because it’s *you.”*

Mydei’s eyes flicker from one place of Khaslana’s face to another, and he watches the drawn eyebrows, the tight jaw, the fire burning, crackling, consuming inside his eyes, and something occurs to him, and he asks, blurts out, almost, “Did it piss you off?” And at Khaslana’s look of confusion, he adds, “When I first asked if I could paint you at the side of the pond. Were you angry?”

For a moment, Khaslana looks so, so terribly lost. It’s almost painful to see.

“I—I don’t—” He starts, tries, and breaks, “It’s not—”

“Yes or no, Khaslana.”

“Yes—No. I mean, no. Maybe.” A pause, a wince and then, in a whisper, “...A little bit, I think.”

“A little bit?”

“I don’t *know*, alright?” He snaps, then sighs, as if the energy physically drained out of him. “I don’t know. It’s—always there, underneath it all, the anger,” He turns to the cigarette in his hand, watches as the flame on top consumes the white slips of paper around the tobacco, leaving only ash and smoke behind. “It’s rather ugly, if you ask me.”

Mydei breathes, but the answer is simple, “Isn’t that just human, though?”

Khaslana’s head whips to him so fast that Mydei can actually hear something in his neck snap.

“Don’t.” He spits, begs. “Don’t say that. Not to me.”

Mydei looks at him.

“Why not?”

Khaslana’s does not reply.

Getting answers out of Khaslana is like pulling teeth. Mydei has no intention of hurting him, but he has no intention of letting him keep burying himself alive either.

“Why not?” Silence. Mydei’s fist clenches. *“Why not, Khaslana?”*

“Because I might believe it!”

The words land like a rock into a frozen lake, crashing and cracking the ice before sinking deep into the cold waters, creating ripples and a hundred million jagged ends. Khaslana’s hand jerks as he says it, slamming onto the table, and the pomegranate milkshake tumbles down onto the table, pink spreading through the table and being absorbed by the paper like blood.

Khaslana’s expression flickers, and he brings his hand onto his lap.

Wordlessly, Mydei plucks a couple of brown napkins from the holder in the middle. He picks up the pomegranate milkshake, cleans the liquid clinging to the side of the plastic glass before moving to clean the table.

A couple minutes pass in muted silence, fallen like a thick blanket on a hot summer day onto the space between them. The girl taping away something or another on her phone went away some time ago, and there’s another man dressed identically to the one with far too polished of a suit and a fedora watching as the other bangs his head repeatedly on the table with a guilty

expression. In his hand, a case that would be identical to the other, save for the fact that one is bright red, shines under the few rays of the sun.

Once it is cleaned, Mydei picks up the soggy napkins, stands up, throws them in a nearby trashcan and comes back to sit right back at Khaslana's side.

"...Sorry."

Mydei sighs. "You are so terribly stupid."

"And you are so terribly cruel."

He blinks, once, twice, eyes going to Khaslana. Silently, he watches as he finishes the cigarette, throws it on the ground and squashes the flame with his shoe. Then, immediately, he picks up the messenger bag he had placed on the floor. He opens it, takes a cigarette box with a dead dove on the front and a red lighter.

He places the end in his mouth.

"Another one?"

"Shut up, Mydeimos." He mumbles. The lighter lits up with a silent *'click!'* and a *'ts!'* and, with stark, sad ease, he lights the cigarette.

For a man like Khaslana, maybe care is just another form of cruelty.

A necessary one, in Mydei's opinion.

Carelessly, Khaslana throws the lighter and the box of cigarettes back into his messenger bag. A black pen rests on top of a copy of *The Princess and the Cat*, and Mydei takes it before the flap closes.

He takes another napkin, places it on the table, and draws a game of tic-tac-toe. He places an 'x' and extends it towards Khaslana.

Haltingly, he grabs it, and, haltingly, he places a 'o' on the top right corner.

He extends it back to Mydei.

Mydei takes it.

“...You are not asking.”

Mydei blinks, draws another ‘x’ on the bottom right corner, and passes the pen back. There are a lot of things he could be asking, truth be told, but, somehow, someway, he knows exactly what Khaslana is referring to.

“You are not talking.”

Khaslana breathes.

A dozen rounds of tic-tac-toe replace the tick-tock-tick of time where none of them win.

It’s anticlimactic, almost.

“Do you know the process of pinning butterflies?” Khaslana asks, drawing another board on the napkin. “To kill them, you put them in a freezer so that the wings won’t be damaged, and then you unfreeze them. Afterwards, you put a pin right in the middle of their body and there’s—this little thing,” He puts two fingers side to side, leaving a gap in the middle. “Where you put them, and then you put some type of paper onto the wings, to keep them down and in place.”

A ‘x’ in the middle right, none of them wins.

Mydei draws another board.

“It’s hard, frankly, more often than not, you end up taking one if not all of the butterfly’s legs in the process, and the wings are so delicate they break as you try to make them look symmetrical and pretty.”

A ‘o’ in the top left, none of them wins.

Khaslana draws another board.

“...I dream about it, sometimes.”

Mydei’s eyes shift to Khaslana.

He doesn’t look at him as he places another ‘o’ in the napkin. “More often than not, Lycurgus is the one pinning me in place.” A pause. “That’s all you need to know.”

A hundred million things said and a billion hundred more left unsaid.

Mydei draws another board. The strength with which he does it tears the little napkin with the same ease butterfly wings are torn.

My Magnum Opus, Lygus had said.

Something hot bubbles up in Mydei’s stomach, and his teeth clench. To lament and sigh at how life has turned out is a fantastic way to drive yourself insane and drown in sorrow, and, as such, Mydei does not. Yet, there’s a small part of him, a small part of his heart, that still wishes he could have met Khaslana earlier.

He does not know how to reply.

“I—” He starts.

“Don’t.”

So, he doesn’t.

Khaslana takes another napkin, places it on the table.

Mydei obliges and draws another board, and a couple of ‘x’s’ and ‘o’s’ pass in place of words.

“I met Castorice,” He replies instead. Khaslana halts. “A couple months ago. She asked me to tell you that she’s glad you are alive.”

The cigarette slips out of Khaslana’s fingers.

The breath he lets out is shaky, though his eyes are dry as ever. His hand hovers in the air, uncertain, for what seems to be a lifetime, before grabbing the pen instead of the cigarette.

Mydei takes the cigarette as Khaslana writes an ‘o’ on the middle right. He throws it to the ground and squashes it under his foot. As he said before, he’s not one to tell Khaslana what or what not to do, but that does not mean he wants to see him indulge in little deaths like this one.

“And, if it matters,” Mydei continues, placing an ‘x’ on the bottom right and drawing a diagonal line. He wins. “I’m glad you are alive, too.”

Khaslana turns to him. Something indescribable, almost incredulous, but all too vulnerable crosses his expression, and Mydei meets his gaze head on. It’s all too easy to do so. He’s not ashamed, much less embarrassed, of his words, not when each and every one is rooted in sincerity.

Mydei cares, is the thing, and he cares deeply, devotedly, ferociously.

Khaslana laughs. It’s a little bit sad. “You are so dramatic.” He breathes. “I don’t want to die[5].”

“I still want you to hear it.” Mydei admits.

Khaslana lays his arms on the table and rests his head on top of them.

“I will leave, though, one day.”

“...Why?”

“I don’t know.” He replies, closing his eyes. “But I always do.”

“I will go with you, then.”

“You don’t even know where we would be going.”

“It doesn’t matter.”

Khaslana cracks one eye open. “And if you can’t find me?”

“Then, I will wait for you.” He replies, unflinchingly. “As long as it takes for you to come back.”

“Sounds exhausting.” Khaslana replies. His voice nothing but a whisper. A part of Mydei wonders if he’s falling asleep as they talk. “You should spend that energy waiting for someone worthy. A savior, a hero, certainly not someone like me.”

“But you are worth it.”

Khaslana opens both eyes.

“Why?”

Ha! What sort of question is that? Hasn’t Mydei made it obvious?

“Because I care about you.”

Khaslana opens his mouth to reply, but nothing comes out. Instead, his eyebrows furrow as Mydei pushes the vanilla milkshake towards him and takes the pomegranate one.

“That’s—”

“I prefer the pomegranate one.” Mydei replies, and takes a sip. “I will ask for the strawberry one for you, next time, but I think you might like this one.”

Khaslana stares, breathes, and, after a beat, takes a sip of the other one.

“...It’s sweet.”

“That a complaint?”

“No.” He says, softly. “I like it.”

A pause.

"Thank you."

Chapter End Notes

FOOTNOTES

1. Ergo, Khaslana. Back

2. Many have told Mister Reception Man to quit the crosswords and instead just stick to the cheap gossip magazines, seeing he sucks so bad at it. He's intent on finishing one for this very reason. Back

3. That Khaslana pretends not to see. Back

4. The restaurant, nicknamed fondly as Not a Tavern, does not usually have pomegranates, much less milkshakes made of it. If you were to ask the owner, he would tell you it's the season. In reality, though, the old man who throws tomatoes at the cathedral had wondered if pomegranates would be harder to clean off. When he found that, no, they weren't, he had already cultivated a ton. In a show of goodwill, he proceeded to dump all of them here and, kindly, threaten them to either keep the fruit or be pelted to death with rocks. Back

5. Make no mistake, this is no lie. Though, it would be a lie to say he hadn't thought about it, in the same way a soldier thinks about his death. All-too close, all-too tangibly, all-too present. Would his body be left to rot at the side of an art studio? Will it be kept like a doll in a glass showcase? What of the mortician preparing his body? Will they, too, obsess over him? No, Khaslana does not want to die, if anything, he always wanted to find a reason to live, but he thinks that if he were to die, he would not want it to leave him pretty, and he certainly would not want to be found. Back

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EXTRA

The last message on the chat is a defeated *'I am here if you ever need anything'* sent by Castorice three and a half years ago.

Khaslana stares at it for what seems to be an eternity, fingers hovering over the keyboard as guilt eats away his guts like termites eat away wood.

He does not know how to reply.

He scrolls far, far up to his chat, and something bitter claws up to his mouth when he sees the ease in which he used to talk, in which he used to be, and a part of him wonders if he should just copy one of those texts, but, no matter how much tries, it all comes a little too stiff.

She's glad you are alive, repeats in his head like a mantra and, in a surge of courage, he sends her a simple *'still alive'*.

'I'm glad', is the immediate response, and Khaslana flings his phone to the other side of the room. Heart beating in his eardrums like a war chant, bile crawling up to his throat and he wants to throw up.

His phone buzzes. Once, twice.

He could not answer.

He picks up the phone. The screen is cracked.

'There's a book fair happening in a week,' reads the first. *'Do you want to come with me?'* reads the second.

A part of him does not want to answer, wants to cut the connection before it even has the chance to re-grow, take the flowers and keep the weeds, because misery is easy, happiness all-too terrifying, and vulnerability feels like ripping the nails out of his hands.

She's glad you are alive.

Khaslana breathes, happiness is hard, but, he thinks, now that he has remembered the beginnings of its taste, he's willing to fight for it. So, he takes out a few nails and, with bleeding fingers, answers *'yes'*.

It’s funny, almost, he didn’t know how much he missed her until he saw her again.

Chapter 11: Budding flowers

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Pitter-patter, goes the world outside, *pitter-patter, pitter-patter,* as rain falls down from the skies. A wide sheet of water pulled over the dark veil of the night like the closing curtains of a theater play, quickly gaining intensity like thundering applause. It's the last day of the Month of Strife, and the clouds have already started to cry as seconds pass and the Month of Mourning approaches.

A little *'clack, clack, clack'*, accompanies the sound of falling rain. Specks of ice bounce on the floor as it hails. One last battle, one last war, one last attack before the last soldier falls to the ground to be buried alive. Under the dim yellow lights of the light posts outside, the little white dots of frozen tears look more like little pieces of broken stars, soon to be pulled into the crude rectangular holes at the side of the road that leads into the sewers by the running water.

There's a certain tranquility to the sound despite the growing violence of the grief, a certain beauty, maybe, and, for a minute or two, both of them simply stare out at the rain. A faint breeze of cold air filters deep into the crevices of the terracotta bricks through the open door as they both linger at the entrance. It's way past eight. Nine ten, maybe, or nine fifteen.

"I didn't bring an umbrella."

Khaslana's voice is soft at his side, calm in the same way staring out into the rain is.

"I have one." Mydei replies, watching the trunks of the faraway trees tilt to the right and the leaves blow out like manes of wild hair. "But I don't think it is going to serve you much with the wind. You are going to get drenched, either way."

“Yeah.” Khaslana breathes out, sounding resigned. “I guess I should make a run for it, then.”

“You are going to get sick.”

“Probably.”

Little specks of ice bounce off his red car parked outside with a dull, metallic *'clang, clang, clang',* nearly lost under the cries of the sky. Mydei stares at it, feeling the way that the raindrops that fall onto the stone steps in front of him break and sprinkle onto the hem of his pants, before he turns his head to the side to see Khaslana. The key of his car, resting next to his mother’s vase on the coffee table in his living room, glints damningly from the corner of his eye.

Mydei stares at it with distant consideration before his eyes shift back to Khaslana.

Selfishly, or foolishly, maybe, though Mydei does not particularly care about the nature of his sudden, almost childish, impulse, instead of offering him a ride, he asks, “Do you want to stay the night?”

Khaslana blinks. Once, twice, before he turns towards him. A stray lock of white hair falls into his face as he tilts his head and, without permission, Mydei’s eyes can’t help but track the way long, pale fingers go to tuck it behind his ear.

Pitter-patter, goes the rain, *pitter-patter, pitter-patter.*

“I don’t exactly have another set of clothes.”

It’s not a no. It’s not a yes, either. Mydei shrugs. “I can lend you some.”

“Will they even fit?”

Mydei sighs, annoyed, this time. Khaslana’s mouth twitches.

“You keep talking as if I barely reached your waist when there’s barely any difference in our height, you know.”

“But there is a difference.”

Mydei clicks his tongue.

“I’m going to kick you out into the street.”

“No, you won’t.” He replies, instantly, with a certainty that surprises even Khaslana, if the way he blinks and falters right after is any indication. The funny part is that he’s not even wrong. Not one bit.

Still, “Don’t try me.” Mydei threatens without any real heat, waving his hand in the general direction of the empty street.

Bottom-deep ocean eyes shift from one side of his face to another. Searching for something held between the planes of his expression that he seems to find after a beat or two, and he goes to watch the rain once again.

Pitter-patter, it cries, *pitter-patter, pitter-patter.*

“Ha.” He sighs, laughs. Only once. “I wouldn’t dare.”

“Mm-hm.” He lets out, not convinced before he, too, goes back to watch the rain. A layer of thick, white fog has started to raise, meandering through the space like a snake in between the grass. It’s getting colder. “Does that mean you will stay?”

“...Maybe.” Khaslana concedes faintly, uncertain. “If it isn’t much of a bother.”

“I wouldn’t be offering if it were.”

There’s a long, long pause.

Movement from the corner of his eye catches his attention, and Mydei’s eyes flicker to the side to find Khaslana’s gloved hand going up and down, up and down, up and down, through the strap of his messenger back, before they flicker back to the rain.

“I will just drive you home if you don’t want to.”

“No, it’s not that. I—” He starts, breaks, and breathes. “I will stay,” Another pause. “For tonight.”

The corner of Mydei’s mouth twitches upwards. “For tonight.” He repeats and closes the door with a soft *‘click’*. The cold from the pit-pat rain still lingers inside the nooks and crannies of his house, but his chest feels warm, for some strange, strange reason.

Mydei’s house does not have a guest room. The expanse of the second floor of his home is occupied by his bedroom, a closet room and a bathroom. Khaslana protests rather vehemently when Mydei says he will take the couch and, effectively, shuts down any protest by threatening to fill his shoes with paint and entering the bathroom to take a shower before Mydei even has the chance to reply[1].

In the meantime, Mydei changes into a set of pajamas, which is a very generous description, considering it consists solely of a pair of loose sweatpants and a rather pronounced lack of shirt. He also leaves a pair of fuzzy red pajama pants, a pair of socks, and well-worn, well-loved black hoodie with the logo of a rock band he used to be really into a couple of years ago[2] outside the bathroom for Khaslana to change into before he goes to rummage around his closet for some blankets.

He is not the kind of person to get cold easily, truth be told, and the second floor is considerably warmer than the first one. So, it takes him some time to pull those from the very top, which is, apparently, enough time for Khaslana to get out of the shower and the low rumble and guttural groan of the washing machine that Mydei is pretty sure will just explode on him one day to filter through the floors.

Ultimately, he manages to take out a heavy, green blanket that faintly smells like dust, and he’s already halfway through the door before he catches sight of the little white label sewn in a corner that reads in thick black letters *‘100% cotton’*.

A distant recollection of a conversation scratches at the back of his mind at the sight. He frowns, places the thing on his bed before going back into the closet. He rummages some more and finds a thick white wool blanket that he had forgotten he owned. He barely uses it, too much of a sensory nightmare, but it had been a gift, so he had never thrown it out.

He picks one of the pillows on his bed and makes his way halfway down the stairs. The low humming of the probably soon to explode washing machine arises is muted, nearly drowned by the ever-distant *pitter-patter* from the rain outside. He cranes his head to the end of the hallway, where the laundry room is placed, just to find it closed.

“Khaslana?” A distant, half-shouted *‘what?’* comes from the direction of the kitchen, and Mydei asks, “Is wool alright?”

"Is what alright?”

“Wool.” Mydei repeats, louder.

“...Uh?”

“Just come here.”

A few seconds pass before Khaslana pops out of the kitchen, idly scrolling through his phone and finishing eating a cookie from the batch the kind old lady next door had given him yesterday[3]. His hair is still wet from the shower, water darkening the fabric of the hoodie around his neck. Mydei’s hoodie. It fits him nicely, Mydei notes with a distant sense of satisfaction, though the fuzzy red pants, on the other hand, do end awkwardly around his shins.

He has also put the purple glove back on.

Mydei stares at it for a second too long. He has long realized its presence is not exactly merely a fashion choice on his part, and he thinks it would be rather naïve to attribute it only to sentimentality. It’s much too deliberate, much too present, to be that.

Still, instead of hounding him with questions he's more than sure will only serve to make Khaslana bite, his eyes go down to the fluffy chimera slippers the man hijacked and asks, "Did you go through my closet?"

Not looking up from his phone, he replies, "Your cat would have snapped my neck if I so much dared to look at your room, Mydei."

"Hm." He lets out, blandly, already accustomed to Khaslana's random surges of dramatism. "With his fuzzy little paws?"

"With his deadly fuzzy little paws, yes."

"Where did you find my slippers, then?"

"Dryer."

"Ah."

"Do you want them back?"

"Will you actually give them back to me if I say yes?"

"No. They are comfy."

"Thought so."

"Be nice to me." He says, dryly.

"I'm being more than nice."

"Hmph." Khaslana lets out. He turns to him, the beginning of an answer forming in his mouth before he cuts himself abruptly and blurts out, "You— Why are you naked?

Mydei blinks, looks down at himself, raises an eyebrow and turns to face Khaslana again, who is staring at the expanse of his naked chest with a blank expression.

“I’m not naked.” Mydei replies, lifting the blanket so that he can see the loose sweatpants he’s using. Khaslana does not look away from his chest. “And my eyes are up here.”

A beat of silence passes as Khaslana registers the words and, once he does, he goes bright red, much to Mydei’s amusement. He coughs once into his hand to dissimulate his embarrassment. “Sorry. It’s just—” His eyes flick down, up. “It’s a little bit distracting.” He mumbles out.

“Distracting.” Mydei repeats, slowly and, out of curiosity, flexes one of his pecs.

Khaslana goes even redder, if possible.

Heh.

“Heh.”

That does snap him out of it. “Show off.” He accuses.

“Jealousy is an ugly sight on you, Khaslana.” Mydei shoots back immediately. Khaslana scoffs. It’s a little funny, truth be told, but he’s still mindful enough to add, “I can put on a shirt if it makes you uncomfortable, though."

Khaslana opens his mouth, closes it, and, ultimately, sighs, “You don’t have to change your habits just because I’m here, you know. It’s still your house…”

“So, you don’t want me to put on a shirt?” Mydei says. Khaslana doesn’t go red this time. Shame. But the look he sends his way is still amusing, nonetheless. He shakes his head and jostles the blanket in his hands. “Nevermind. Is wool alright?”

Khaslana tilts his head to the side, confused.

Mydei raises an eyebrow. “Aren’t you allergic to cotton?”

“...I am, yes.” He frowns. “How did you know?”

“You told me.”

“I did?”

Mydei nods.

“Oh.”

A pause.

“I’m surprised you even remember that.”

“I remember everything you tell me.” Mydei replies easily, naturally, and entirely unaware of the immeasurable weight his words carry, because such fact it’s not a weight to him, neither a deep secret, just a simple, straightforward truth.

The same can’t be said about Khaslana, though, who blinks once, twice, before the words and their implications sink deep into him and his eyes widen.

Pitter patter, goes the rain, *pitter-patter, pitter-patter*. The noise may be washing away all the sound right out of Khaslana’s vocal cords, drowning out the syllables underwater as Mydei watches him mouth an answer without being able to let out a single word.

One of his hands goes to his neck, long fingers going to toy with the straps of the black choker around it before Khaslana realizes he already took it off for the night, and instead he presses his palm against his mouth.

A second passes, then two, three. Tick-tock-tick. Time stolen by the mischievous winds of Zagreus outside, dancing in between strife and death.

“You—” He starts, tries, and breaks, voice muffled. “You really are—” A pause, and his eyes lower, and maybe the light-footed, time-stealing jester snuck in between the crevices of the terracotta bricks uninvited and came to sway and hide Khaslana’s little bleeding, childish heart, for what he says instead is, “...Must be pretty empty up there if that’s the case.”

Mydei blinks, looking up at the ceiling. “Up there?” He repeats just to immediately catch on and sigh. “Must you keep finding clever ways to call me stupid?”

“Why, does it piss you off?”

“Immensely so.”

Khaslana’s smiles are a rather precious thing, truth be told. Mydei does not know if he would admit it if asked, not out of shyness, and much less greediness, selfishness, perhaps; but he does know he would not be able to deny it, not then, not after, not now—Especially not now, not when Khaslana’s hand falls from his mouth to reveal pale, chapped lips curved upwards. Soft, small, a little mischievous, this time. They come easier to him now, the smiles, but they still feel as wondrous as the first rays of light at dawn after a long night.

Though, right now, it does not make it any less infuriating because of that.

Mydei feels the weight of the wool blanket in his hands. Heavy, but not overly so, and asks again, “Is wool fine, then?”

Khaslana nods, still smiling. “Wool is fine.”

“Great.” He says and immediately throws the blanket towards Khaslana’s head, who yelps and, pulled down by its weight, falls down to the floor with a loud *‘blam!’*.

He resurfaces slowly from under it, shaking his head before he turns to glare at him. As soon as he does so, Mydei throws the pillow directly at his face like a seasoned pitcher would throw a baseball.

“Ha.” Mydei chuckles. “Jackass.”

The pillow slides off Khaslana’s face and down to the floor with a dull *‘plaff’*, revealing a very disgruntled expression underneath.

Approximately five seconds pass before Mydei bolts onto the second floor as Khaslana chases him to hit him with the pillow, and, approximately,

another ten pass before it is Khaslana the one darting off onto the first floor as Mydei chases him with two.

Pitter-patter, goes the rain, but Mydei can't hear it over the wild *ba-thump-thump* of his *beat–ing* heart.

Truth be told, truth be said, there isn't any particularly interesting event worth the waste of flowery words and redundant descriptions that happens over the course of the night. The rain pitter-patters, the ice hails, and an admittedly late dinner stretches for hours upon hours as they talk of this and that, here and there, did-you-know's and no-I-did-not's, before Morpheus' arms come to rest upon weary shoulders.

And, then, morning comes, as all mornings often do, rather unceremoniously. Aquila's eyes crack open bit by bit as he, too, struggles to escape the throes of late sleep, the throes of early death, until he shakes himself awake and the skies clear and the stars disappear, for the Eye of Twilight has always been much too proud to resign his half of the day to the Veil of Night.

Mydei follows soon after. The clock on his nightstand shifts from eight cero cero to eight cero six in the time it takes him to muster enough strength to get out of the warm comfort of his bed with lazy movements before he goes down. Some of the steps creak and grind under his weight, up until he sees a little white cloud of hair peeking from the side of his couch and he stops.

Khaslana is still asleep.

Still here.

…

He wants to look at him.

The thought comes unbidden, unannounced. It surges all the way from the tips of his fingers to the confines of his chest, running along his veins like

blood. It’s not an unfamiliar want, not really, nor a strange desire, and it is not unusual, not really, for him to do so, whether he’s painting or not.

But, it’s different, this time, for reasons he can’t quite pinpoint, and, Mydei, rather foolishly, he himself will admit, can’t help but feel like a thief sneaking under the cover of the night about to steal the most precious of treasures as his steps turn careful, silent, avoiding loud noises and abrupt awakenings while he makes his way towards Khaslana.

One step, two, and then three. Four, five, and then six.

And then he bends over the couch’s headrest.

There’s nothing particularly noteworthy in Khaslana’s sleeping expression, if he's being honest. Not in the way pale pink lips, bitten and chapped, part slightly as his cheek squashes on the pillow, not in the way the tip of his nose has gained a faint reddened hue thanks to the cold, nor in the tranquil softness of his face, and much less in the way a stray strand of white hair curls on his cheek.

Mydei is mesmerized, nevertheless.

Vulnerability, is the thing, is a strange sight on Khaslana.

His hand moves out of its own volition, out of pure, unadulterated emotion, and Mydei is still so captivated that he barely manages to catch himself just as his fingers come close to graze the man’s cheek.

There’s a second of hesitation, almost, encapsulated, contained and witnessed by the walls of his house. A second where Mydei almost, just almost, wishes to not have the kind of self-awareness and restraint that he does, because, now, he can not say that tucking the strand stray of hair behind Khaslana’s ear is anything other than a conscious decision.

Khaslana’s eyes twitch, long lashes fluttering like the wings of a butterfly as his head shifts towards him.

It would be terribly, deceivingly easy to say Mydei's heart stutters in his chest. A *beat, beat, be–at* too long, a *be–at* skipped. A rug pulled out his feet. A bucket of cold water splashing over him. Hand flying as if it had been burnt. Easy, yes, but untrue. Love is terrifying and love is wonderful, and there's an inherent fear, maybe, of it being caught so blatantly, so mundanely. But there's nothing of the sort as the deep blue of Khaslana's eyes peeks and peers up at him, as it is, Mydei doesn't even move his hand away from where it is now pressed against the side of Khaslana's face, and a part of him wonders what does that mean.

"Mydei?" Khaslana mumbles out. His voice is rough, and he's eyes aren't opened fully, almost as if he's debating whether to shake himself awake or simply burrow himself deeper in the blanket. He does not ask what he's doing, for some reason, and instead asks, "What hour is it?"

Mydei's fingers card through his hair. And that, too, is a conscious decision. "Early," He replies, quietly. His hair is soft. "Go back to sleep."

Khaslana blinks once, twice and, wordlessly, closes his eyes once again.

It's such a small action, but it undoes him.

Whatever butterflies might have been pullulating in Mydei's stomach and fluttering on the crevices of his throat fall and fly out of his mouth with each exhalation he gives. He can feel the pulsations of his heart spreading like wildfire all the way from his chest to the end of his fingertips, and he all but has to hold himself on the couch's headrest to avoid falling.

"I…" Mydei starts, stops. He's not sure what to say, not sure how to convey the enormity of what he's feeling, not even sure of what he's feeling, just knowing that it feels as if he's being pulled around by the seams only to reveal the raw of his insides. "Can I paint you?"

"Why are you asking?" Khaslana doesn't open his eyes. "You paint me all the time."

Mydei breathes. *Flip-flap,* make the butterflies. "Still."

He sighs as he burrows himself deeper into the blankets. “You are so very strange, did you know that?” He mumbles before cracking an eye open. “Catch me drooling and I am tossing my shoes into your washing machine.”

Mydei’s mouth twitches upwards.

His fluffy chimera slippers rest neatly at the side of the couch, and Mydei hijacks them back before walking to his art studio to retrieve a white canvas and his paint case with his ugly chimeras painted at the sides. He finds a stack of brushes held by a stretched-out white hair tie on top of one of the shelves of the bookshelf there, and he takes it out and uses it to tie his hair into a high ponytail.

When he goes back to the living room, Khaslana is already fast asleep, still in his home, still on his couch, still here.

It’s, well, not strange, Mydei thinks as he sits down a couple of steps away from the couch and props the canvas in between his legs, not quite, they are already far past that point, but there’s something about it that is making him heady, maybe. He’s overly-aware, from one moment to the other, that, were this situation have happened earlier, much, much earlier, when skin resembled marble and emptiness proved to be much more alluring than the blatant humanity held in between bottomless eyes, Khaslana would not have hesitated once in stepping outside even if the rain and the hail were nails and daggers; wouldn’t even have given Mydei the chance to offer his umbrella.

And now he’s here.

Time passes slowly, bit by bit, tick by tick, grains of sand falling one by one. The *‘clack, clack, clack’* of the hail outside has long stopped, and the rain outside no longer pitter-patters, but it has not yet stopped. A faint drizzle bathes the streets today. The beginning of the Month of Mourning is silent, but heavy.

The low *fwish* and *swish* of the brush pressing and dragging on the linen, however, isn't mournful—if anything, is almost reverent, gentle, as he goes over the soft strokes of the planes of Khaslana's expression.

Mydei is not yet done by the time Khaslana awakes. He's painting with loose swirls the strands and curls of his hair splayed across the pillow when his eyes flutter open.

"Morning."

He blinks a couple of times, shaking off the drowsiness before replying, belatedly, "Morning." And he yawns. "Did you finish?"

"How fast do you think I paint? It's barely even been," Mydei pauses. He places the brush on the table with a little '*clack*' and turns around. Khaslana's phone is a couple of steps behind him, left charging through the night. He stretches, practically laying on the floor and manages to tap it once with his middle finger. The time reads ten twenty[4]. "Two hours."

Mydei sits down once again. He picks up a new brush and mixes some colors in the plastic palette placed on the coffee table to match the wool blanket crumpled around Khaslana as he hums.

"What's the theme?"

"None." Mydei replies. "This isn't for the competition."

"It isn't…?"

There's a long beat before the rustle of fabric arises. Mydei's eyes shift upwards and sees Khaslana lifting the top of his body as he cranes his neck to try and catch sight of the canvas on his lap. His eyes aren't wide, but there's certainly an undertone of incredulousness around him.

Mydei drags himself towards him, twisting so that his back is against the couch and Khaslana has a clear view of the canvas as he goes over the repetitive patterns that create the blanket with his brush.

One, two, three strokes. He dips the brush in paint and does another three.

The silence isn't heavy, but it is charged with an unvoiced question in the air. Mydei already knows which one is it, and, so, he answers simply, "I wanted to."

"...Yes." Khaslana replies, quietly. Slowly, he lays back down. "I had a feeling you would say that."

Mydei's fingers twitch around the brush. He shifts his head sideways, and, this close, he can smell the scent of his own shampoo in Khaslana's hair, and it hits him all at once, the underlying intimacy of this moment, this everything. Khaslana in his home, in his clothes, in his life.

His, a treacherous part of his mind thinks. *Mine.*

He swallows. "You know me well, then."

Khaslana gives a half-hearted shrug. His left hand, ever gloved, sneaks from under the warmth of the blanket to pull lightly at a strand from his ponytail and, wordlessly, Mydei scoots closer. There's a pause, followed by a faint rustle before Mydei feels his hair tie being pulled off.

The brush nearly slips out of his hands.

"What are you doing?"

"It's weird seeing you without a braid." It's his excuse as he divides his hair into three sections. "Though, I can make you pigtails if you want."

"...The braid is fine." He breathes out and wonders if Khaslana understands just how significant what he's doing is.

Hair, in general, is important in kremonan tradition. It's a warrior's pride. A symbol of strength. A point of honor.

In the past, he had been taught, his people used to braid a section of their hair and only cut it whenever they lost in battle. Having it cut, not in between the strife and bloodshed, but in between deception and treachery,

became the worst kind of humiliation. As a result, touching a person's hair, doing a person's hair, became something akin to a ritual, reserved only to family, confidants, close friends and only *very* close friends, and—

Equals[5].

Ha! Oh, how far has Mydei fallen, to contemplate such thoughts, and he thinks of telling Khaslana this—laugh about it, even. But the laughter gets stuck in his throat, suffocated by fluttering butterflies, because he knows that, flighty, as Khaslana can be, he would stop immediately.

Love, if what he's feeling truly is that, makes you stupid, Mydei concludes, as the treacherous part of him that whispered *mine*, also whispers, *yours.*

"Mydei."

Flip-flap, make the butterflies. "What is it?"

"Why," He starts, stops. "Why do you paint?"

A blink.

"Right now?"

"In general, I mean."

Mydei thinks about it for a minute or two, maybe even three. Khaslana lets him. His hands are gentle as he twists the strands of his hair around each other.

"It used to be because of my mother." He says after a beat, and it feels strange, frankly, to admit this sort of thing. Has anybody ever asked him this question? Has Mydei himself? "She was a painter, back when she was alive, and I remember picking up her brushes and sitting myself next to her for hours on end." A memory comes unbidden, and Mydei can't help but chuckle. "I once painted over one of hers, you know. Made a very bad cat on top of a landscape that took her weeks to make."

Khaslana lets out an amused breath. "Was she angry?"

“...I don’t remember.” He replies, almost distantly. “But I know she framed it.”

“Oh, she liked it, then.”

Yeah, he supposed she did. Still, “It was always embarrassing to see, to be honest.”

“Do you have a photo?”

“Hmph. You just want to make fun of me.”

“A little bit.” Khaslana admits, tying the end of the braid and letting it fall on Mydei’s back. It’s a little loose, and a few strands escaped him here and there. He wonders if pointing that out would be enough to get him to do it again. “But I also want to see it.”

Mydei sighs. “There must be one, somewhere.”

“Mm.”

The moment stretches like bubblegum pulled between teeth as silence sweeps into his house like ants underneath the floorboards. It’s not heavy, though, and not charged either. Khaslana doesn’t prod nor doesn’t push as Mydei sits quietly in front of him, lost in thought, like a sailor left ashore.

A little *‘click, click’* arises from the staircase after a while, and Mydei cranes his neck long enough to see Kopopo The Third dragging his little feet as he makes his way down. He always gets drowsy with the cold, and Mydei watches as he disappears into the kitchen just to reemerge with his mouth and paws wet.

It takes him a second to notice Khaslana, but when he does, he pins Mydei with a surprisingly judgmental look, which is remarkable considering he’s a cat.

“...What?”

Kopopo The Third sniffs, lifting his little fuzzy chin haughtily before making his way towards them. With all the grace a spoiled cat can have, jumps onto the couch and pins Khaslana with the same judgemental look he gave Mydei.

He meows once[6].

Khaslana, strangely unpreoccupied considering all the time his cat has attempted to go for his jugular, tilts his head and asks, “Are you cold?”

It seems the temperature has significantly mellowed his cat out, or maybe he has finally started to warm up to Khaslana, because instead of getting hissy, Kopopo The Third simply makes a sound close to a scoff, and lays down in an empty spot in the couch, shoving himself into the wool blanket to continue sleeping.

Khaslana blinks owlishly, and, hesitantly, places a hand on top of his little fuzzy back.

Kopopo The Third meows sharply, but otherwise makes no move to bite his fingers off.

“Oh.” Khaslana lets out, a little amazed, maybe. “It’s been a while since a cat has let me pet it.”

A drop of paint falls to the floor.

Mydei looks down at the little dot of white. He makes no move to wipe it out, because then he will just have a bigger stain to clean afterwards, and places both the canvas and the brush on his coffee table before reclining once again on the couch’s welt. Khaslana keeps petting Kopopo The Third with careful movements.

It may be the weird sort of domesticity they have fallen into, or, more likely, the steadily growing trust that had grown bit by bit, that makes Mydei continue, “I didn’t paint for years after she died.”

Khaslana’s eyes shift to him.

“...How did it feel?” He asks. “Not painting, I mean.”

“Dying.” Mydei doesn’t even have to think about it, “It felt like dying a hundred times over.” To pick a brush felt like digging a nail into his hand, but to not pick it back felt as if the skin over his fingers was rotting and falling. The urge to paint clawed at him, and if there’s one thing he hated more than painting, was not doing it. But his mother was dead, his father mad with grief, and there wasn’t anything worth portraying, not until, ”My friends gifted me a box of watercolors some time after[7] and they all but forced me to do it again.”

Looking back, with all the trouble he gave them, it probably felt like reanimating a corpse.

“So, you paint for others?”

Mydei shakes his head. “No, not since I moved out of Kremnos.”

“Then, why?” He asks again.

And it is easy, maybe even embarrassingly so, to answer, this time, a truth carved in his heart brought to light by a flame lit up with enough care. Why do people create, in the first place? To be heard? To be seen? To connect? Does it matter? Maybe humanity lives to create, or it creates to live, create memories, create bonds, create sadness, create happiness and all the ugly things and ugly flaws that make humanity what it is.

Mydei paints to live, and he lives, “For myself.”

Ah, he wonders how he could have forgotten that. How could he have let that urge, that passion, that beat–ing heart, flicker like a flame in the wind. Loneliness, maybe, spreading up on him like a disease, like a weed in a garden, because living for himself and living by himself are two different things. But, nevertheless, ‘if’s’ and ‘almost’s’ are not things he tends to linger on about, yesterday has passed and tomorrow is to come, and, today, Khaslana throws back his head and laughs.

“How very much like you.” He says, between laugh and laugh. His eyes crinkle at the sides as he turns to see him, and Mydei’s fingers twitch. “I should have seen that coming.”

Mydei smiles and stands up, chest light. The little spot of white paint has dried on his floor.

“What do you want for breakfast, anyways?”

Chapter End Notes

FOOTNOTES

1. Just to reemerge five minutes later with a rather sheepish admission that he has no idea how to get Mydei’s shower to work. Back

2. Which Khaslana never actually gives back. Back

3. Along with a shovel, “just in case!” Back

4. Distantly, a part of Mydei can’t help but notice that his lock screen is the picture he took of the two kites, tangled high, high up into the sky. Back

5. Equals, because there is no word for ‘lover’ in the kremonan language. Back

6. He means to say, “What are you still doing here, uh?” Khaslana does not speak cat more than he did last time, which is unfortunate because it means all the ways Kopopo The Third has threatened him fail rather miserably. It has reached the point that he has considered giving up his rivalry with the parrot from the corner shop and have it relay the very important fact that he much prefers the chicken treats rather than the fish ones he has been giving him behind his owner’s back as of late. Back

7. He still keeps the case, a scratched, dirty, and cracked thing. He had thrown it into the trash when he had first received it, just to retrieve it

from under empty cans, rotting food, and crumpled paper late at night. Back

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These two are deadass so embarrasing to write sometimes. Yeah, I will caress your face gently as you sleep and let you braid my hair and carve a space out in my heart for you to live in no problem sure but I draw the line at saying 'I love you' like can guys please stop yearning for like five minutes and lock in?

Chapter 12: Before it gets the chance to bloom

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“What is it?”

The question is hushed, as all words uttered during the Month of Mourning tend to be, whispered and quiet, as to not disturb the heavy grief the gray days with their weeping clouds and howling winds carry along with them. It’s a cold afternoon of a day that does not matter, not really.

Mydei’s eyes shift to Khaslana’s calm expression and instead of answering him verbally, he simply turns his phone around, where the e-mail announcing the theme for the next installment reads a single word.

Nudity.

“...Ah.”

“Mm.”

The word doesn’t land on Khaslana with the aversion Mydei thought he would have. It does not hit him like a bucket of cold water thrown on him, and neither does it land like a stone thrown into a frozen lake, but, instead, it appears like the first fissure cracking through ice.

He doesn’t answer.

Mydei stares at him even as Khaslana’s own dim blue eyes lower. He does not push, not immediately, lets him trail the patterns littering the cheap plastic surface of the table absentmindedly as the rustle of the plastic sheet the restaurant had settled to compensate for the old mall’s lack of wall in a poor attempt to keep the rain and cold away fills in the gap of their conversation.

The place is empty because of that, save for them two, and it gives the space a strange quality. Dreamy, almost, what with the dozen empty tables, the dim yellow lights casting shadows on dozen empty chairs like ghosts sat in place, and the occasional caw of the little crow that had snuck in exclusively to terrorize the kitchen.

Khaslana goes to take a bite of his hamburger. The slice of tomato in it slides out and falls to his plate with a wet *‘splat!’,* followed by the meat and lettuce. He’s the type of person who can’t eat these sorts of things without them coming undone. It’s a little endearing.

He sighs, settles down the empty buns and starts reassembling it.

“I didn’t think they would have set a theme like this considering there are children in the competition.” It’s a non-answer to the underlying matter, but all the more telling because of it.

“They have a different theme.”

“Which is?”

“Beach.”

“Mm.”

A pause. A long, long pause. Distantly, the crow’s caw arises from the kitchen along with the sound of banging pots before the howling wind drowns them all out.

Mydei looks at him, brow furrowing, watches him pick a pickle and eat it on its own. *Lunatic,* his mind chimes in, but he pushes it down. It’s really not the time for petty squabbles.

“We don’t have to do this if you don’t want to.” He says at least.

“It’s fine.”

“Khaslana—”

“It’s fine.”

“Fine.” Mydei scoffs. “I remember you were very adamant that you ‘didn’t do nude’ when you first came to my home.”

One of his hands raises towards his mouth before he seems to think better of it and instead goes to pick at the sesame seeds scattered across the hamburger’s bun.

“That was then.”

“And now is different?”

“Yes.”

Mydei is not convinced, not really. He and Khaslana have very different ideas of what ‘fine’ means, and he has come to learn that, more often than not, whenever Khaslana says that something is fine, it is not.

He plucks one of Khaslana’s potato fries. “Have you ever modeled nude before to begin with?”

A beat.

“Once.” Khaslana replies. “Thus Burns the Dawn.”

“...Ah.”

On his tongue, the potato fry tastes stale. He swallows and it goes down like wet cardboard.

“Don’t look so grim. Nothing bad happened.” His eyes flicker. “He just—watched.”

It’s not a lie, of that, he’s sure. For all his averseness and secrecy, Khaslana is a very bad liar, and after all the time they had spent together, Mydei has come to know all his little tells. But there must be a reason *why* he was so adamant on the topic in the first place. A reason why he had deemed necessary to set that specific boundary.

He thinks of pinned butterflies and recurring dreams, of dying stars and burning fires, drowning corpses and crumpled statues, of a gleeful ‘will he come?’ and a hateful ‘don’t ever talk to me again’, and he wonders, intrinsically, intimately, how does Khaslana view Lygus’ painting of him[1].

He takes a sip of his drink to wash down the acrid taste in his mouth and says, “I mean it, Khaslana, we don’t have to do this.”

“I know. You never say things you don’t mean.” He answers, easily, casually. It’s not surprising, not really, the fact that Khaslana has come to know Mydei as intimately as Mydei has come to know Khaslana, but there’s something to be said, perhaps, about the off-handed way he admits his care, as if it wasn’t particularly worth anything—But it does matter, of course it does, otherwise the butterflies in his gut wouldn’t be flapping so frantically. “And, as I said before, it’s fine.”

Mydei clicks his tongue. “Stop forcing yourself.”

“I’m not.”

“Mm-hm. Try that again.”

A flicker of annoyance flashes across Khaslana’s face. He shifts one of the sesame seeds he had picked out from his palm to the pad of his thumb and flicks it at him with his middle finger. It lands on his shirt.

Mydei raises an eyebrow.

Khaslana sighs. “...Maybe a little.” He concedes, before letting the sesame seeds fall from his palm onto the white porcelain plate with a *‘click-clack-clack-clack’* like falling rain. The crow caws, the pots bang again, and the lights flicker, shifting shadows like shifting patrons. They said ghosts linger as the Month of Mourning cries.

He pushes his plate towards him.

His eyes flicker to the half-eaten hamburger and the portion of cold fries he hadn’t even touched. He takes the very badly re-assembled hamburger and

pushes the plate back towards him. Khaslana blinks, makes a face, but, obediently, picks one of the fries and starts eating it.

“Still.” He starts, pauses. “I think… I would like to try.”

“Why?”

Khaslana’s mouth opens, closes, and he swallows. His gaze drifts to the side before he forces himself to look Mydei in the eye.

“Because it’s you.”

Oh.

“How is it?”

Khaslana blinks slowly at him, rubbing absentmindedly the red silk sheet in Mydei’s arms with his index finger and thumb[2]. “I am not going to keel over and die if I touch cotton, you know.” He deadpans. “My skin just gets itchy.”

“Would you have preferred to deal with an allergic reaction for hours on end, then?”

“No. That sounds awful.”

Mydei doesn’t give a verbal response to that. He jostles the silk sheet in his arms pointedly and gives a rather judgmental look at Khaslana, who makes a rather stellar job of ignoring it even as he goes to gather the sheet in his own arms.

“What I am saying is that you worry too much, that’s all.”

“Worry.” Mydei repeats slowly, almost tasting the word on his tongue. It’s not the one he would use in this situation. He doesn’t actually think Khaslana is going to burst into flames as soon as he touches cotton, despite

what the man would lead you to believe. “Is it so unbelievable to think I don’t want you to be uncomfortable while we go about this?”

“...Not particularly, no.”

Mydei’s eyebrows furrow, confused, almost.

Khaslana’s mouth presses.

…Hm.

“Are you nervous?”

“No.” Khaslana says and slams closed the bathroom door on his face. The few pictures hung on his walls rattle and shake and, distantly, he manages to hear a couple of dull *‘thuds’* coming from his room.

He stares at the door, unimpressed.

“Khaslana—”

The *‘click’* of the door’s lock echoes *point-ed-ly.*

Mydei scoffs, still unimpressed.

Annoying, as it may be, he can’t really find it in himself to be properly mad at Khaslana for his snippy attitude. It’s a sensitive topic, that much is clear, to the point it almost even seems to have a *‘Do not touch!’* sign underlined in red. A part of him can’t help but wonder if this, all this, is a particularly wise choice, but, still, he’s not one to tell Khaslana what he should or should not be doing. The man can make his own decisions—and if he’s going through the effort of doing something that is clearly difficult for him, what can Mydei do other than commend his resilience? Self-destructive as it may be.

Besides, it would be a lie to say Mydei isn’t the least bit interested in this, *him.* He is not an entirely selfless being, neither is he entirely selfish, of course, but something in between.

The door is still closed.

He thinks, for a second, for a moment, on saying something reassuring, but figures it will only serve to rile Khaslana up even more, so he settles on a dry, “If you blow up the door’s hinges, I am making you fix it.”

“Don’t you want me to get the wobbly step while I am at it?”

Mydei opens his mouth, closes it and scowls. He doesn’t have a good answer to that. “Whatever.” He will fix that. “I will be waiting for you downstairs. Do you want anything to drink?”

“Coffee.” Comes the muffled reply. Mydei has barely gotten three steps in before a *‘click!’* echoes again. The door opens abruptly. Khaslana’s head pokes out, and he points a finger threateningly at him. “The good one, Mydei. The brand I brought. Not that Dirt Water thing you insist on giving me.”

“Ha! Maybe if you behaved, I would be more inclined to be nicer.”

“I’m a very well-behaved person.” He says, like a liar. “You just get mad easily.”

Mydei raises an eyebrow. Khaslana closes the door again. Somehow, it feels even more definitive than when he slammed it shut.

He goes to his own room, picks up the few books and few pictures that had fallen, before walking down to the kitchen. His hands are as firm and steady as ever as he goes through the motions, taking the pot, filling it with water, the *‘ts!’* of the stove, resisting the urge to take the bad coffee because the face Khaslana makes when he tastes it is always funny, yet, despite this, it feels like a hundred thousand ants walk and gnaw at the nerves under his skin.

He’s not jittery, not exactly, much less nervous, but there’s an undeniable surge of energy thrumming along his veins. A hard *ba-thump-thump-thump* pulsating at the end of his fingers. Anticipation, maybe.

It’s a little bit strange, almost, he remembers some of his classes back in art school, the quiet hum of nervous excitement washing over the room like a wave hitting shore when the model started to undress even as the professor stood on the corner with a metal pipe on hand he was very much not afraid to use at the first sign of any leering glance; and he remembers not particularly getting why. He hadn’t been moved, not really, not by the soft curves nor the hard muscles.

Then again, none of them had been Khaslana.

Five, ten, fifteen and twenty minutes pass. Time going tick-tock-tick as the coffee in his hand grows cold. A *pit,* then a *pat,* and the *pitter-patter* of the rain starts. The Month of Mourning cries and cries for the things that have ended, for the things that are ending, and for the things that will end.

Another five minutes pass by.

Mydei stands up.

A ‘*cre–ak’* arises faintly.

He picks up the cold cup and places it in the microwave. One minute. Long enough to warm it, not enough to boil it. It comes to life with a low electric hum as the cup spins and spins.

“And here I thought you had jumped out from the window or something.”

“...Sorry for the wait.” Khaslana murmurs back, so low it’s almost lost under the sound of the rain. Mydei has to strain his ears to hear him. “Should I go to the art studio?”

Mydei stops the timer with one second remaining so that the astringent *‘pip! pip! pip!’* of the microwave’s timer doesn’t grate through his ears like nails on a board. The cup is warm against his palm, and a low puff of white steam curls and disappears in the air.

He turns around.

Damningly, the first thing Mydei notes is the presence of the purple glove around his left hand with a twinge of disappointment, ever present, ever hiding, before he forces it down. It’s fine, he thinks, whatever Khaslana will give, he will take.

And take he does.

He tries not to be too shameless as his eyes roam over Khaslana, less so because he’s ashamed of his actions and more out of consideration for the other man, because even if his face isn’t flushed bright red, the way he avoids looking at him speaks volumes. Still, it’s hard, the dark red silk draped over Khaslana’s bare body compliments him nicely, contrasting temptingly against the paleness of his body. It makes him look elegant, almost regal, tantalizing. The red pools around his feet, bringing attention to the flashes of skin from his long, long legs peeking from under it.

Khaslana clears his throat, pressing his neatly folded change of clothes further into his chest. The movement makes some of the red silk slip off one of his shoulders.

Mydei lets out a low, low breath, deliberately.

“No.” He replies, and his voice comes out rougher than he intended. He takes a sip of the coffee to wash the sudden dryness of his own mouth, wincing at the acrid taste. He still doesn’t understand why people like this stuff.

Khaslana’s eyes shift to him, fleetingly, questioningly.

Mydei doesn’t answer his question verbally, instead, he walks past him as he makes a motion for him to follow.

There is a certain place in Mydei’s home mentioned only once through the course of this mundane story. Not, of course, out of a wish for secrecy, but, rather, out of a wish to be kept. A second heart, or perhaps just the other half of the one he has, situated right in front of his art studio, under the stairs, is kept in Mydei’s library.

In all fairness, to call it a library is a rather generous description. It's certainly not as grand and magnificent as the Library of Garbaniphoro, with its hundred billion books and hundred million shelves rising tall, high and proud, where his parents used to take him and where he had holed up like a mole following his mother’s death, but it is every bit as dear to him. A piece of his prior home he had brought along to the new one.

It’s a rather modest room that gets bigger as the stairs rise. It doesn’t have any windows, and the light that illuminates the terracotta bricks of the room is a dim, cozy, yellow thing. Inside, a soft black divan is pressed flush against the wall in front of the door, along with a small coffee table on top of a plush carpet. There’s also a comfy chair and a writing desk with a lamp, shoved at the right, with an ancient computer that resembles more an old TV that he hasn’t changed because he doesn’t use it all that much, a printer, a clock that doesn’t *tick* and neither does it *tock*, and some scattered crayons.

On the left, there’s five bookshelves fitted like pages from a book, along with a sixth one shoved to the very end wall that covers it all. They aren’t filled to the brim, Mydei is rather selective with the books he decides to keep. They vary from thrillers to mysteries, horrors, novels, epics, poems, fantasy, biographies, a few very cheesy romances and, of course, dozens of art books. He keeps only the ones that have managed to make enough of an impression on him, enough of a mark. Something that matters.

Not a lot have stepped foot inside this place. Mydei is as selective to those he lets in as the books he decides to keep with him. Kopopo the Third, of course, although he’s now banned; Krateros, an old friend of his parents that had helped him cover the tuition of art school and had attended his graduation in place of his father; and his friends from Kremnos[3].

And now Khaslana, who walks into the room as easily as he had walked into his heart—with ever silent steps.

Mydei places the cup of coffee on the little table with a quiet *‘tap.’*

“Pick something.” Mydei says, tranquil, as if he just hadn’t revealed himself bare to him. “I will get things ready.”

“It’s wonderful.” Khaslana breathes out.

Flip-flap, make the butterflies. “I’m glad you like it.”

Khaslana disappears between the shelves, one hand trailing over the book’s spines almost reverently, while Mydei goes to retrieve some stuff from the art studio. He brings two stools, places the wooden palette, a bunch of paints and a bunch of brushes, along with a cup without a handle filled with water on one of them. Then, he brings a blank canvas, a wooden easel and, against his will, Kopopo The Third, who makes a run to the divan even though he’s still strictly banned from this place. Little fuzzy bastard. He better not find dead mice on the shelves again[4].

“Have you read them all?” Khaslana calls, distantly, lost somewhere between the ink and the paper. Mydei hums an affirmative. There’s a faint rustle of cloth, and Mydei lifts his gaze to find Khaslana’s head peeking out from behind one of the shelves. He seems inclined to say something, but when he spots the easel and the white canvas placed on it, he asks, “Where should I sit?”

“The divan. I reckon it is comfier than the stool. Have you picked something?” Khaslana shakes his head, already making his way to the divan. “Pick something.” He repeats. “I will wait until you are ready. I can get started in the background in the meantime.”

Khaslana pauses. “The background, uh.”

There’s something strange in his voice when he says this—a little quiet, a little soft. He looks around his library once more, dull eyes roaming around every little corner, every little vein, before his gaze sets on Mydei once again. He must recognize something in this—the importance, the care, the piece of his heart that pulses a steady *ba-thump* that halts and skips when Khaslana takes a breath and brings a hand to pull the silk purple glove off the other.

He’s slow with it, methodical, almost, hesitant. He pulls at the glove’s fingers one by one in practiced motions, loosening the silk from where it clings and kisses at his skin before he drags it off.

Pitter-patter goes the rain, but it can’t be heard all the way down here, and the silence that falls over the room could almost be described as sepulchral.

Khaslana’s left arm is completely burnt.

All the way from the tip of each and every finger to the beginnings of his biceps, the pale expanse of his skin has been replaced with a bright red, angry red, burning red patch of swirling scars. Blistering and ugly, with decolored nails, and coarse-looking, like very cheap leather.

The clock doesn’t *tick*, and neither does it *tock*, but the weight of passing time is felt all the same. Heavy and crushing, tightening like a noose.

Khaslana’s burnt fingers twitch once, twice, before he pulls his arm towards his chest, and the movement pulls at his skin, stretches the red swirls, drags the scars in ways that look too *tight, tight, tight*, as if the skin was about to snap like a rubber band, rip apart like pulled plastic. His other hand, unmarred, pale, and flawless, goes knuckle-white as it crushes the silken glove in a death grip.

His gaze flickers from his arm to his face. Khaslana’s face is impassive, almost monotone, but not quite, not quite. His jaw is closed *tight, tight, tight* and his lips are sucked in slightly, as if he were digging teeth into it. Angry, he thinks, maybe. *Daring.*

Mydei’s eyes don’t soften.

Neither do they fall, nor do they narrow.

“Does it hurt?”

Khaslana blinks, shrugs, and lets go of his lips.

“I’m used to it.”

That’s not a no.

“I see.”

A pause.

Khaslana’s arm falls from his chest to his side. He blinks once, twice, thrice, and the beginnings of an answer form and die. He looks confused all of a sudden.

“...That’s all?”

“That’s all.”

“Oh.”

“Were you expecting something else?”

“You are not asking.”

“Do you want me to?”

“No.” Khaslana shakes his head, placing the glove on top of his pile of clothes he had set aside on the chair. “It’s rather ugly.”

Mydei raises an eyebrow. He’s not sure if Khaslana is referring to the story or the scar. Both, probably both. Still, “And it means you lived.”

Khaslana looks at him from the corner of his eye.

“I won’t be proud of it.”

“And I am not telling you to be.” Especially when he does not know the story behind it. “But you are alive, despite everything.”

“And should I be proud of that?” He replies, flatly, and immediately winces. “Don’t get me wrong, I don’t want to die, but to be proud of something as… simply *being*—“

“It requires strength." Mydei interrupts. “And of strength, you should be proud.”

Khaslana’s eyes lower and he sighs, walking with ever silent steps towards one of the bookshelves, and Mydei watches his slow march with ever piercing eyes, sitting down on the stool.

“I still don’t like it.”

No, of course not. Mydei is not foolish, nor idealistic, and much less romantic enough to think a few mere words will resolve the issue. But it doesn’t mean he thinks Khaslana hearing these sorts of words is useless.

“Are you ashamed?” He asks, out of mere curiosity.

“Ashamed!” Khaslana laughs, sharp and curt, like a blade cutting air. “Ha! Who do you think I am?” He shakes his head, still amused. “I just don’t like when people stare at me.”

Mydei frowns, somehow, despite the clock that doesn’t *tick*, and neither does it *tock*, and the all-encompassing silence that befalls his library, out of sight, out of this world, it feels as if suddenly all noise dies and time itself comes to a halt.

“Khaslana.” Mydei hears himself say, slowly. “Why do you model, then?”

All traces of amusement fall from his face, like a rock thrown into a frozen lake.

Time doesn’t tick. Time doesn’t tock. The rain falls outside, but its cries can’t be heard.

Khaslana doesn’t see him, eyes roaming through the spines of well-loved books.

“...I don’t know.”

Mydei looks at him.

“Liar.”

“I am not lying. I really don’t know. It’s just,” He pauses, pulls a book from one of the shelves and goes to read the back cover. “People asked.”

“And that was enough?”

“You already saw how people get with me—Felt it, even.”

Mydei lets out a low breath. “Was it always like that?”

Khaslana’s eyes shift to him before settling onto the books again. Quietly, he pulls another, reads the back cover, before placing it back. The book he had picked first remains nestled against his chest.

“No.” He replies, and, maybe, the silence, the solitude, the intimacy, of this little pocket of space peeled away his defenses like he had peeled off his clothes, because he continues, almost wistfully, almost painfully, “It started after I tried to get into art school, I think, and it wasn’t that bad at first. A few insults, thrown paint, stuff like that.” A pause. “The first to hit me was an old lady, struck me right in the jaw with her cane. Took a tooth out.” He pulls another book, though it doesn’t look as if he’s really registering any of the words on the back cover. “She was horrified—told me between tears she hadn’t even hit her kids once in her entire life.”

A pause, silence stretching like bubblegum held between teeth.

“Why—”

“People kept asking.” Khaslana interrupts him with a shrug. “It was easier. Though, of course, then Lygus appeared and—” A pause. He doesn’t finish that thought. “And then there was the whole *Nanook* thing,” He spits, waving the burnt hand[5]. “And it's just… I couldn’t do it anymore.”

A breath. One, two, three.

“Until me.”

Khaslana places the first book he had taken out back on the bookshelf, keeps the second one, and keeps looking at other titles. “Until you, yes.” He

hums, tilts his head. “Perhaps it was all to meet you in the end.”

He thinks it’s supposed to be a joke, but it falls a little bit too honest, a little bit too raw.

“To be seen, you mean.”

“Don’t do that.” Khaslana bites out immediately.

“Do what?”

“That. I hate that.”

“I’m only looking.”

Khaslana opens his mouth, closes it. His expression flickers. It’s not a good thing.

“How arrogant.”

“How do you want me?” Khaslana asks after a few more minutes pass.

“In whichever way you want.”

Khaslana blinks, frowns, and then nods. He moves towards the divan with a book in hand, sidestepping Kopopo The Third, who at some point had decided to move onto the carpet and simply cracks one eye open to glare at him for having disturbed his rest before falling back asleep.

He shifts from one position to the other, indecisive, before he settles in simply letting himself sink into the plushness of the seat, pulling his legs up, covering his groin.

“Ready?”

A breath.

And he lets the silk sheet fall completely off his body.

“...Ready.”

Whatever you give, I will take, Mydei had said.

I will give you everything, then, Khaslana had answered.

The grip he has around the brush goes tight, wood digging into the skin of his fingers. Butterflies flying rampant in his stomach. Khaslana is still tense, despite everything, and Mydei spends more time than he ought to mixing colors in the palette.

His mouth is dry even as he asks, “Which book did you pick?”

Khaslana lifts the book towards him. It’s a faded blue thing with pages that have started to yellow that reads in elegant calligraphy *‘An Executioner’s Last Sorrows.’*

“Grim.” Mydei says, although, it’s not a bad choice. “Won’t you read it to me?”

The weight of Khaslana’s gaze is heavy as it settles on him, scrutinizing, Mydei can’t help but know it even when he doesn’t look at him, too busy mixing colors still, dragging whites and grays together.

The pages of the book flutter open.

“I am bound to die in twenty days.” He starts, a little hesitantly. The cup of coffee on the table is half-full, still warm, though it doesn’t let out steam anymore. *“Drag myself to the execution ground and drive my own blade through my own chest. When I asked why I couldn’t be hanged, the count laughed and told me that there was simply no higher honor than to fall by my own hand. I don’t agree, of course, for there has never been honor in the way I live, much less love—and I heard the hangman say he did not wish to be haunted by such a wicked creature like me.”*

Mydei isn’t paying attention to the story, not really. Instead, he lets the soft cadence of Khaslana’s voice wash over him like a wave hitting shore. It’s

pleasant to hear, flows and drifts about in the nooks and crannies of his little library, and he wonders if, after this day comes to pass, he will come to find the words he said in between the ink and paper.

Little by little, the tension sweeps out of him like steam, and it's only when Khaslana seems to have forgotten he's being painted at all that Mydei presses the brush against the white linen with the softness of a kiss.

There's no sensuality to it, not even as Mydei traces the long lines that make Khaslana's long legs, his hips, his waist—and it feels all the more intimate because of it, almost terrifyingly so, the enormity of what he's been given.

"—But the sky did not resent me, no, it mourned me."

There's a certain reverence to Mydei's movements, his brushes, his strokes of paint, and it would be a lie, a complete, utter lie, to say said his reverence is fitting only for gods, because Khaslana is just a man, far from the divine, far from being perfect, and he's all the more beautiful for it.

Beautiful, he thinks, repeats, breathes, as he paints the burnt swirls and decolored nails of Khaslana's ash-filled arm, as he goes over the few birth marks that look like cracks over his chest, his crocked nose, his finger that he can't fully bend following a basketball game, the tiny gap between his teeth that can barely be seen, the little dots of red acne littering his shoulders like constellations, *you are beautiful.*

I want you, he thinks, as he goes over the arch of his neck, the sun imprinted there.

I desire you, he thinks, as he goes over his bitten lips.

I love you, he knows, as he paints his face.

He settles down the brush with a quiet *'clack.'* His heart is beat-beat-beating so fast it feels as though it might come out of his mouth any moment now, fall onto the floor with a wet *'splat'* and a flurry of butterflies for Khaslana to pick at.

Khaslana turns to him.

“Is it done?”

“Some details of the background are missing.” He replies. “But you don’t need to naked for that.”

“Can I see?”

Mydei nods.

Khaslana doesn’t go immediately, though. He closes the book and settles it down next to the empty cup before going to gather his clothes. Respectfully, Mydei averts his eyes when Khaslana goes to put on his underwear, and, for a few minutes, the only thing that fills the lack of noise is the faint rustle of clothes.

His shoes make a squelching sound against the ground as he wiggles his feet into them, and he doesn’t bother tying them as he starts to make his way towards him. The silken glove rests in the hollow of his elbow, and he’s in the middle of putting his black choker back around his neck when he lays eyes on the painting.

And the choker slips out of his hands.

It falls to the floor with a deaf sound.

Time doesn’t tick. Time doesn’t tock. The rain cries and cries with a pitter-patter sound. It filters through the gaps of the terracotta bricks like static in his ears.

“No.” He lets out, softly.

Mydei frowns. “Khaslana—”

“That’s not me.” He lets out, all so quietly. One of his hands touches his own cheek, as if he didn’t recognize himself, and his eyes look like stars about to die. “It can’t be.”

They said ghosts linger as the Month of Mourning cries. They like to haunt people, and, maybe, that's why when Monday comes, the one standing in the middle of the Irontomb's exhibition is not Khaslana.

But Lygus.

Chapter End Notes

FOOTNOTES

1. A mirror. One he can't seem to shatter. Back

2. It had been a rather spontaneous decision, a rather spontaneous want, perhaps a moment of greed. Mydei had intended to buy something in white, cream-colored, but the wine red had caught his attention, and when he had imagined Khaslana draped in it, his mouth had gone awfully, terribly dry. Back

3. His mother would have been the first to see it, were she to live, along with his father, were he to be sane. It's a fact he used to mourn as strongly as the Month of Mourning cries every year. He doesn't dwell much on it these days. He thinks his mother would have loved it, as for his father, well, he supposes it will be a scar that will always be a little tender—Such is life, such is a battlefield. You can't expect to walk past a battlefield unscathed, neither can you choose the wounds you get, but you can choose whether to let them bleed and die or let them scar and walk. Back

4. Mydei finds dead mice on the shelves again. Kopopo The Third insists he wasn't the one putting them there, but Mydei does not speak cat—which is better, because if Mydei knew he would call on the lie, and then the cat would find himself double grounded. Back

5. The Ruin Author's mansion had burned, and with it, it had taken a piece of Khaslana. There's only one person who knows this, however, and that's Castorice. She had found him in the smoking area of the hospital he had been shoved into, lighting matches and letting them burn all the way down to his fingertips, and he had admitted then,

voice hoarse, that he wished nothing more than having been burnt fully —It scared her, intrinsically, intimately, and, perhaps foreboding his imminent disappearance, she had given him the silk glove, so that Khaslana would stop cutting off his circulation with the bandages; so that he could remember that, someone somewhere out there, did not want him to die. Back

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Maybe the real curse that impedes us from being seen as human is the love we lost for ourselves along the way or whatever people like to say

Chapter 13: Waiting for rain

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It’s quiet.

Most days on The Irontomb are—Silent until the distant old toll of the cathedral's bell echoes and resonates through the industrialized walls hidden behind the art. Every hour, from eight to nine, nine to ten, ten to twelve, the bell cries for a minute and a half before it dies. It always skips eleven.

It’s a rather gray day, and the art gallery is empty, and in the exhibition room, only he and the curator stand.

Lygus tilts his head, and he’s perfectly polite as says, “Good morning, Mydeimos.”

Mydei does not have the same reservations.

“What do you want?”

“No need to be so crude now. I just came to appreciate the art.”

In between them, the painting of Khaslana that Mydei had decided to title *'You'* rests damningly, like the space where the sand and the ocean met.

“...The art.”

“Is it so unbelievable? Hm, I see his perception of me has greatly influenced yours.” Lygus shakes his head, as if the situation amused him to no end. “If I may give a word of advice, don’t let preconceived notions and biases blind you from the objective truth. After all, I, too, am an artist.”

Mydei’s eyes narrow. “Rest assured, curator, I am well aware of that fact.” How could he not?

Lygus nods, in approval, maybe, and his head shifts towards the painting. “It is a remarkable piece, I must admit.”

“Ha!”

Lygus smiles. “My compliment is sincere. The artistry of your technique is undeniable. The lighting is exceptional. The color composition, stunning—albeit soft, if you were to ask me. As for the subject,” His smile gets wider. “Vulnerability suits a thing like Khaslana so terribly well, wouldn’t you agree?”

Mydei’s face darkens.

The strange sort of helmet on top of the curator's head hides the look in his eyes as he regards *You;* hides the places where his gaze lingers, where it doesn’t, what it traces, what it doesn't. It’s unnerving, almost, and the uncertainty makes his palms itch and his jaw clench.

He just—watched, Khaslana said.

“I thought,” Mydei says, voice calm despite the fire licking at his ribcage, not falling for the bait. “You didn’t agree with the way I painted him.”

“And I don’t.” Lygus admits upfront. He’s still watching the painting. “But it is a well-known fact that stars shine the brightest before they die.”

Mydei’s eyes narrow. “Where is Khaslana?”

“I’m afraid, Mydeimos, I should be the one asking you that.”

“He hasn’t come?”

“Not that I know of, no—Has he left, already?” The curator asks. When Mydei does not reply, he sighs, patronizingly. “Ah, I can’t say I’m surprised about his behavior. He has always been like this, you see, flighty, like a bird with broken wings.” The corner of his lips lifts. “It’s a shame, really—flawed, as your renditions are, I had actually started to look forward to your works.”

In the distance, the old toll of the cathedral's bell arises with the solemnity of a death knell.

And, yet, Lygus' voice is strangely, eerily clear when he turns to face him just to ask,

"How much do you want for it?"

Mydei freezes.

Something cold and ugly spreads all the way from his chest to the end of his fingertips, crawls over into his throat and rots itself deep, deep, deep into his flesh like worms would dig into rotten fruit, making him taste bile.

Distantly, all so very distantly, as the old cathedral's toll cries, he hears himself let out an almost incredulous, "What?" He doesn't think he processed the words right.

"For the painting." Lygus clarifies, as if he had to. "How much do you want for it?"

"It's not on sale."

"Price is not a problem."

"How *dare* you?" Mydei spits, nails digging into his palms, heart roaring in his ears. He thinks he has never wanted to hurt somebody as badly as he does now. "After all you have done to him?"

And Lygus laughs.

It's a jarring sound, almost jovial, amused and bright. *Eureka!* He seems to laugh—with the sort of mad elation only a genius could have after coming up with a revelation. *Eureka!* And it mixes like blood in the water with the cathedral's old toll. *Ding*, then a *dong*. *Ding*, *dong*. Corpses without coffins and brushes without paint. All-consuming, all-alluring, all-devouring.

Khalsana's painting is still on the wall.

“Hah, fell in love with Galatea, didn’t you?”

Mydei frowns.

Galatea?

What nonsense is this man talking about?

“I’m not Pygmalion.” Mydei replies, with a clarity that surprises even him. His nails still dig into his palms and his jaw aches from how hard he clenched it. But his voice is steady as his heart when he says, “And he has never been Galatea. I didn’t—*create* Khaslana, I didn’t give him life.”

Lygus chuckles, tilts his head, and turns to the painting again.

“Didn’t you?”

“I just reminded him that he already had it.” Mydei replies, certain. It’s almost laughable, how little Lygus seems to understand. “If anything,” He says, and he, too, turns to the painting. His eyes linger on Khaslana’s face, trace his chapped lips, his ash-filled arm, his beautiful imperfections, his all-present humanity. “He was the one who gave my art life.”

“What a romantic thought.” Lygus crosses his arms. In the distance, the bell gives its last toll, but the sound still clings into space with desperate hands. “But it doesn’t change the fact that you are here, and he’s not.”

Mydei’s hands close into fists.

The stairs leading up to the tiny antique shop are covered with dead flowers.

Withered red petals fall quietly from the floor above this one, like the silent tears that haven’t rained ever since that day, that night, as if the Month of Mourning had finally exhausted all its wails, leaving behind merely the emptiness of grief. A faint *‘swish, swish’* comes from above as a woman with tired eyes pushes off the dead flowers with a broken broom[1].

Mydei is not a sentimental person, not really, but there's something about the sight that makes his fingers twitch. It's a shame he left his canvas at home. He will paint what he remembers later.

A burst of laughter comes from the top, followed by the frantic *'plap, plap, plap'* of rushing footsteps, and three kids run past him, crushing the flowers underneath their feet. One of them slips, the smallest, and very nearly kisses the ground, but the biggest one catches them first. After confirming they are right, they keep running with childish mirth.

He watches the space where they left for a second longer before turning around and keeps walking, one step at a time. The old man with wrinkled hands and a newsboy cap of always had commented on how strange it was to see him come alone.

Taped to the door of the antique shop, there's two sheets of paper. They both say, *'NOT A CYBERCAFE ANYMORE. STOP ASKING'* with the difference that one was printed, and the other made with childish scribbles, each letter made out of a different color and *'cybercafe'* spelled with an *'i'* instead.

After a moment of deliberation, Mydei takes off the one printed and leaves the other[2].

The little golden bell on top of the door chimes with a melodious little *'ding, ding'* as Mydei steps inside.

A faint, *'just a second'* comes from somewhere in between the bookshelves and the knick-knacks, nearly drowned by a muffled whirring sound. Mydei walks towards the direction it came, and he finds Theodoros standing on a tall step ladder that has seen better days, dusting off one of the top shelves with a pink rag that's almost black with grime.

"Oh, hey, it's you." Theodoros greets him without stopping in his movements. "Khas isn't here today—if that's what you came here for."

The corner of Mydei's mouth turns down. "Do you know where he is?"

“Mm? No, not particularly. Why?”

“I can’t find him.”

Theodoros’ motions start to halt ever so slowly as the words dawn on him, “You can’t…?” He repeats, trailing off and turning to see him with a rather complicated expression on his face. “He left?”

Mydei hesitates, for a second, before nodding, and Theodoros lets out a sigh.

“Since when?”

“A week and a half, maybe.” He replies, watching the man climb down. The ladder shakes and quakes precariously with every step he takes, and one of Mydei’s hands hovers, ready to catch him, in the air in case the old thing breaks on him. “You don’t seem surprised.” He notes.

Theodoros shakes his head, throwing the dirty rag over his shoulder, and his voice is resigned when he says, “He does that.”

“Leave?”

“Disappear.”

Wood in the pyre, ash in the wind. Khaslana has always been burning, had walked away from his house that night like a falling star without much of a goodbye, and Mydei wonders if all he’s going to see of him again will be nothing but cosmic dust, figures in the cigarette’s smoke. He’s here, and Khaslana is not. Bird with broken wings.

He shakes his head, pushing aside those thoughts.

“But he comes back, doesn’t he?”

Theodoros opens his mouth, closes it, and sighs, again. With a silent motion for him to follow, he leads Mydei to a door behind the counter and into a room that smells of wet paper and cinnamon, crammed with boxes upon

boxes upon boxes filled with antiques that reach high up into the ceiling like pillars.

It's—a mess, really. It doesn't have any sort of windows. The floor creaks with every step he takes, and the light bulb takes a whole minute to turn on after the flick is switched. There's a couch with a very ugly floral pattern that looks taken straight out of a horror movie, it is filled with books and stacks of papers. It is placed in front of a table that has a bunch of damaged artifacts, smashed mirrors, snapped quills, broken bracelets, discolored figurines made of clay, clocks without hands and hands without clocks. A very ugly vase painted with yellows and purples that must have been broken into a million pieces at some point rests in the middle—The little wooden doll of The Teacher sits next to it.

He wonders where the rest of her sisters are hiding this time.

A dehumidifier shoved in a corner whirls gratingly before Theodoros turns it off and makes his way into a tiny, ancient-looking kitchenette shoved against the wall. There's a dented metal thermos on it. "Make yourself at home."

Mydei looks around dubiously.

In slow, slow steps, careful so that none of the stacks of boxes come tumbling down on him, he makes his way towards the couch as Theodoros grabs two mugs. He pushes to the side some stacks of paper and places some books onto the table, all about history, and when there's enough space, he sits down. The springs dig into his butt.

"I don't—" The couch lets out a loud crack, and Mydei pauses. He waits a second, then two, and when the couch doesn't break, he continues. "I don't drink coffee."

"I know." Theodoros replies, opens a little cabinet door and takes a small box of chamomile tea sitting next to a badly taxidermied otter. "Khas told me—He talks a lot about you, actually."

"Really?"

“He likes you.”

“Oh.”

Mydei already knew that, of course, but hearing it still makes something in his chest grow warm, then hollow.

His eyes drift to the little doll of The Teacher. Her fiery red hair, her blue flower eyes, her reassuring smile, and wonders if she could give him any sort of guidance if he asked.

Then again, that’s why he's here, isn’t he?

“I didn’t.”

The words snap him out of his thoughts. His eyes shift back to Theodoros. He doesn’t reply, though, not because he’s offended. He lets the man collect his words, watches as he puts a tea bag in each cup and uncaps the thermos.

“Don’t get me wrong, you are a perfectly nice person. I know that now. But when Khas told me you were an artist… Well, I’m sure you know.” A pause. A faint ‘*glup, glup, glup*’ arises as water fills the cups. “Perhaps even better than me.”

“Because you don’t paint?”

“Maybe? I don’t know. I just never understood what made people so infatuated with Khaslana.”

“Infatuated.” Mydei repeats, tasting each and every syllable on his tongue before he chuckles, somewhat sardonically. He accepts the cup extended towards him—a china. With blue intricate cranes drawn on the delicate porcelain. “That’s a nice way to put it.”

“How would you put it, then?”

Mydei blinks.

He tilts his head down to see his own reflection in the cup, and a red petal falls onto the surface. Mydei watches the soft golden hues of the chamomile tea slowly dye the water and sweep into the petal before it falls down to the bottom, next to the little bag. Empty eyes and lonely nights, dying stars. Unfinished paintings left to rot next to the trash.

“Sinking.”

He then shakes his head, not unlike the way Kopopo The Third shakes himself after a bath, and a pile of withered petals fall out of his hair. One falls onto his knee, a white little thing that escaped the blood fallen in the Month of Strife. Mydei grabs it, rubs it with the pad of his thumb and his index finger before putting it in the pocket of his jacket.

He wonders if that makes him a little bit of a romanticist.

Theodoros sighs. He pulls a wooden stool from under the table and sits down.

“No, I still don’t understand.”

Mydei doesn’t believe in ignorance being bliss, not really, but he knows different people have different strengths, not everybody can swim against the current. And, so, he replies, “Perhaps it’s better that you don’t.”

“Perhaps.” Theodoros agrees, taking a sip out of his cup. Mydei mirrors the action and winces. The tea hasn’t stepped long enough. He settles it on the table. “It’s still a bit frustrating.”

“How so?”

“Because the only thing I can do is watch—It’s how I met him, actually.”

Mydei doesn’t reply.

“There used to be a tattoo shop here. Somewhere on the first floor. It used to be really popular, you know?” He starts after a beat. “The owner could conjure these intricate designs in the blink of an eye. He had some sort of synesthesia, I think. Ah, it doesn’t matter. The place was popular, the owner

nice, and then Khas came along—For the sun thing?" He makes a general motion in the direction of his neck. "And he just… changed. Nearly gouged one of Khas' eyes with a needle."

He must have made some sort of grimace at that because Theodoros offers him a sympathetic smile that doesn't quite last.

"...Yeah, it's a wonder how he didn't lose the thing."

"Were you there?"

"Passing by. Saw as it happened." He drums his fingers against the cup. "I, uh, I panicked and just threw the vase I was holding into the showcase. Made enough of a ruckus to alert security."

Mydei's eyes shift to the vase sitting on the table. There's bits of dried glue sticking through the cracks.

"Ugly thing, isn't it? Khaslana fixed it for me[3]."

Mydei passes a finger through the tiny little cracks, feeling the jagged ends and rugged patches of glue. "Must have taken him a lot of time."

"You should have seen his face when I told him it was an imitation."

Mydei can't help the laugh that bubbles out of him.

Theodoros laughs too, a little quieter, but just as fondly. "I remember I spent all day explaining the difference to him, and then he just kept coming back after that. Apparently, all this," He waves a hand around. "Was interesting to him."

Mydei's eyes roam through the little room. He stares at the piles of boxes, at the thick dusty old books, the little knick-knacks, the broken antiques, the little figure of The Teacher and wonders what exactly Khaslana saw in all this. A comfort, maybe, or perhaps simply an escape.

He grabs his cup and takes a sip. It's lukewarm now.

“You mentioned he had a tendency to disappear.”

“It’s just… something he does. Sometimes. I don’t know why.”

“What have you done? When he disappears, I mean.”

Theodoros winces.

“Nothing.”

“Nothing?”

“I *tried*, alright? I really did.” Theodoros snaps and then sighs deeply, as if all his energy drained out of him at once. “But I just—I just never knew where to look, much less what to do. I actually don’t think there’s much you can do in this situation, other than wait for him.”

“And if he never comes back?” Mydei asks, flatly.

“I’m sure he will.” He replies, quickly. “He likes you, after all.”

Briefly, Mydei thinks of fluttering butterflies and silken gloves. *Could you please tell him that I’m glad he’s alive?*

No, he doesn’t think just waiting is enough.

Next to the vase, the little Teacher smiles at him.

The Month of Mourning ends with a long, exhausted sigh, as frigid as the last exhalation of a dying man, and the coin Zagreus throws lands on tails. It’s bad luck. A chaotic start to a chaotic month. Up becomes down. Left becomes right. Entire plantations are set ablaze, but weeds grow either way. Salt in place of sugar, pineapples instead of carrots. The winds laugh as they steal hats and lift skirts.

And, yet, life goes on, as it always does. Morning comes, and the sun arrives, as it always does. Time passes by, and the night comes, as it always

does.

Mydei wakes up exactly at six, as he always does, stretches, goes to the bathroom and down to the kitchen. He serves Kopopo the Third his food and some water, tells him not to sink a paw into it, and sighs when his cat sinks both paws as he cooks breakfast. He changes, goes out running, and into the gym. He works out for an hour or two, runs back home, takes a bath; and so on, and so on. This or that, here and there. He goes through the same motions of a routine, of a life, with a sort of mundanity that feels—hollow.

Incomplete.

Lonely.

It's strange, almost, the way in which Khaslana had interlinked so intimately with his life without Mydei noticing. A little puzzle piece that fitted into an empty space Mydei hadn't realized there was, not only in his art, but in his life, in his heart.

And his presence lingers, is the thing, like the vestiges of a ghost, traces scattered like broken glass in his house. The brand of coffee he likes to drink rests next to a jar with chocolate chips on his kitchen cabinet. His art studio is filled with paintings of him, and little drops of paint lay like little planets around his couch. There are dried forget-me-nots resting on a glass box on his night desk, along with a very bad sketch of him made in pink. A well-loved black hoodie with the logo of a rock band is missing from his closet. Kopopo The Third does not eat the treats Mydei offers him and instead prefers to chew on the black choker Khaslana had left that night.

But he can not find him.

He searches for him, high and low, through the crannies of a routine, through the nooks of this city, through the places they had gone, through the people they know. But Castorice says she does not know where he is, and he has no idea where the green-haired man that had come to pick him up that far, far distant night could be. He does not answer his texts, and Mydei doesn't even try calling him, because Khaslana has never liked phone calls,

so he never picks up the phone as it is—Hell, Mydei doesn't even know where the other man lives[4].

And, so, life goes on, as it always does. The world does not stop spinning. It doesn't even tilt on its axis.

It just continues.

Mydei's paintings gain a bit of a melancholic edge during this time. Watercolor blues and acrylic grays. Vacant places, empty kitchens, lonely cats, and flying birds. He has a little blog he always uploads his paintings to, just so that his friends can see what he paints even when they are so far away[5], and Hephaestion calls him one day to tentatively ask if he's okay.

I am, it's what he answers, it's not even a lie, *it's just that someone is missing.*

It feels all the more prominent when he goes back to The Irontomb a couple of weeks afterwards to retrieve his painting on his own.

The man in the reception does not comment on Khaslana's absence as Mydei signs a little list to confirm he got the canvas back, instead, he simply *taps, taps, taps* a chewed pencil against a crossword missing only two words, and says,

"He comes every night, you know."

The pen in Mydei's hand slips right out of his fingers. It lands on the porcelain floor with a loud *'clack!'* like the first drop of rain against a window.

There's only one person he could be referring to, but Mydei still asks, mouth dry, "Who?"

"Your muse. He comes every night." The man at the reception says without looking up from the crossword. "Spends his time walking back and forth all the way from there," He makes a general motion to the exhibition room, "To there." He motions at the west wing, where *Thus Burns The Dawn*

rests. “Like some sort of ghost. It creeps me out, actually. Can you get him to stop?”

In the crossword, he writes *haunting*. It fits perfectly.

Mydei’s heart pounds in his ears. *Ba-thump*, it cries out, *ba-thump-thump-thump*. His fingers tighten around the painting in his arms.

“He probably won’t come today.”

What reason would he have?

The man’s eyes shift from the crossword to his face. His eyes, monotone things, linger a beat too long on his face, before turning to the painting in his arms and then to the west wing.

He sighs and takes out a small agenda with the image of *The Little Prince* from behind the reception and places it on the desk.

“Write down your number. I will call you if he does.”

Mydei blinks once, twice, before he bends down to pick the pen from the floor. He opens the small agenda in the page of today’s date and writes down his number along with his name between an appointment to go to an older sister’s ballet recital tomorrow at six and a reminder to call a beekeeper.

“Thank you.” Mydei replies. “Really.”

In the crossword, he writes *kindness*. It fits perfectly, and he reclines in his chair with a self-satisfied smile[6].

“Don’t mention it.”

He comes every night.

Four words. Simple on their own, and, yet, they seem to carry the entire world. It strikes him like lightning, harsh and violent, and leaves his body thrumming and crackling with energy, and it repeats, over and over and over again, echoing in his mind like a broken record.

He muses, with the same piercing calculation a war general would consider a strategy in battle, what to do with this information, what to do if he comes back, tonight, what to do if he doesn't. But all thoughts and plans vanish from his mind when a little *knock, knock* comes from his door.

He opens it.

"Did you guys break up?"

And immediately slams it closed.

Absolutely not.

Knock, knock, knock, comes from the door. "Mister Painter." Says the little girl with chalks, who keeps knock-knock-knocking *in-sis-tent-ly.* It sounds like a war drum. "Mister Painter, Mister Painter, Mister Painter. Open the door, Mister Painter. I know you are there, Mister Painter."

Mydei glares at the door resolutely. One minute, then two, and then three.

The little girl does not relent one bit.

"I'm not going to leave until you answer me, Mister Painter! I will sleep right here if I have to!"

"I will tell your mom you are behaving badly if you keep this up."

"She wants to know too!"

Knock, knock, knock, comes from the door.

Each and every single one of Mydei's survival instincts scream at him not to open the door, but, after five minutes, he relents—mostly because he feels bad about ignoring the little girl.

He opens the door again.

“We didn—”

“You guys broke up and didn’t even kiss?” Demands the kid who doesn’t eat their veggies.

Mydei closes the door again.

Slam! Slam! Slam!

He yanks the door open.

“Stop kicking—!”

“If you guys broke up, does it mean you are not going to need the shovel?” Asks the boy with the green spinning top. “Because the kind old lady says one of her friends is going to marry soon, and she told me to tell you that if you are not going to use it, then you might as well give it back so that she can give it to someone who will.”

Mydei stares blankly at them. He didn’t register a single word the boy said. He looks to the right, then to the left, and back to the kids.

“...Where is the other one?”

The kids blink at him.

“You know, uh,” He starts, then stops, and frowns, only now realizing he never actually got any of the kids' names—Do they even know his, come to think of it? “The girl with the purple spinning top?” He settles in.

The kid who doesn’t eat their veggies shrugs. “Around.”

“She will come.” Pipes the little girl with chalks.

“Don’t worry about it.” Adds the boy with the green spinning top. “Anyways, the shovel?”

Slowly, Mydei starts to close the door. All the kids stare at him as he does so, heads moving in rather unnerving synchrony like little owls praying down upon their prey. He leaves a tiny gap, looks at them through it for a long, long second, before closing his door and immediately opening it again.

The girl with the purple spinning top extends a dirty wrapper up at him.

Kids sure are terrifying.

Nevertheless, he accepts the dirty wrapper, blinking at the tiny piece of food left on it.

“What’s this?”

“An ice cream sandwich.” She answers. “My sister ate a lot of those when she broke up with her boyfriend. I thought it would make you feel better.”

“Didn’t you say she broke his windshield?”

“That was after.”

Mydei takes the little piece of ice cream sandwich between his fingers, does not mention that there are remains of ice cream all over the girl’s mouth, and, instead, replies with a rather heartful, “Thank you.” Before eating the remaining piece. It’s the thought that counts, he supposes.

She brightens. “Did it make you feel better?”

“Yes.”

“Great! Why did you guys break up?”

Mydei sighs, deeply.

“Why do you all think something happened between us, either way?”

“You have been all gloomy, Mister Painter.” Replies immediately the girl with the purple spinning top. “That’s why I brought you the ice cream.”

“And nobody has seen him come to your house for *years!”* Says the one with the green spinning top.

“It’s barely been a month—”

“Not even those *bastards*—Kids!” The kid who doesn’t eat their veggies squeaks out at the look Mydei gives him. “I meant kids! The kids of the other street—”

“Who are real bastards[7].” Interrupts the little girl with chalks without a single ounce of shame.

“Say they haven’t seen him come by either!”

Mydei frowns. “Kids shouldn’t be saying this kind of stuff.” Not that he really minds, but he does have a sense of responsibility, considering he’s the adult here. “Who taught you that word?”

Unceremoniously, four fingers point towards him.

“You call your cat that all the time.”

A *‘meow’* comes from behind him. Mydei turns his head around to see Kopopo The Third staring at him from the stairs, looking as if he agreed wholeheartedly with the kids. Hmph, fuzzy bastard.

…Ah.

“Don’t tell your parents about this.”

“I won’t. *If,”* The kid who doesn’t eat their veggies conditions, latching onto weakness like a shark that smells blood. “You tell me why you guys broke up.”

Ha! Does he really think he can intimidate Mydei with such threats? It’s almost cute. Sure, it would be annoying to have a bunch of angry parents lecturing him, but it’s not something he fears.

“Go on! Hmph, see if I care.”

The kid who doesn’t eat their veggies sputters, caught off-guard, but the girl with the purple spinning top pounces in his place, “Then, I will tell the kind old lady who lives next door.”

Mydei lasts approximately five seconds before he sighs and sits down. The kids cheer like a bloodthirsty crowd who just got their first kill. They would thrive on Kremnos.

“We didn’t break up.” All the kids let out a bunch of relieved sighs. “We were never even together in the first place.” All the kids let out a bunch of groans. Mydei frowns. “What?”

“Mister Painter,” The boy with the green spinning top says, placing a tiny hand on his shoulder, with all the wisdom a seven-year-old can muster, or ten. Twelve? He’s not sure. Mydei is very bad with children ages. “I think we are already past that point.”

He stares at the kid. “What are you talk—”

“Did you guys get into a fight?” Interrupts the kid who doesn’t eat their veggies.

Mydei opens his mouth, closes it, and decides to leave that other can of worms closed.

“No.” He answers instead. “No, we didn’t fight. It’s just—” He pauses. “It’s just…” His hands motions senseless patterns in the air before he drops them on his legs with a sigh.

How does he even begin to explain all that Khaslana has been through to a bunch of kids without horrifyingly traumatizing them in the process?

“It’s just?” The kids repeat, crowding him.

Mydei thinks for a second longer.

“Khaslana is someone who has been hurt. A lot. In the past. And I,” He frowns. He what? Mydei isn’t even sure exactly what he did, what he

didn’t. Khaslana hadn’t said anything. “Might have done something that… reminded him of that, I guess.”

The little girl with chalks shifts on her feet. “Hurt?”

“Yes.”

“How?”

Mydei resists the urge to wince. “Bad.” He replies, softly. “Very bad.”

“You scared him?”

And, ah, isn’t it so simple?

“I suppose I did.”

“Have you tried saying that you are sorry?” Asks the girl with the purple spinning top.

Mydei huffs, amused, almost, though it sounds bitter. “I haven’t done anything that warrants an apology.” He’s firm on that.

The kids turn to each other, looking confused. Hm, perhaps it’s a bit too complex of a concept for them to understand. He thinks for a second how to explain it to them, but the kid who doesn’t eat their veggies turns to him.

“So, he’s the one who should be apologizing?”

Mydei blinks, shrugs. He’s not sure.

The kids are not satisfied with this explanation.

“What do you mean—” The boy with the green spinning top copies his shrug. “That’s not an answer!”

“It’s—complicated.”

“Why?” Asks the girl with the purple spinning top.

Kids make way too profound questions, sometimes.

“I don’t know.” Mydei replies, and before any of them can berate him for his rather lackluster answer, he adds, “I just want him to come back to me.”

The kid who doesn’t eat their veggies puts his hand under his chin. “So, he should apologize.” He summarizes. “For leaving you—without a kiss, no less!”

“Why hasn’t he?” The boy with the green spinning top asks.

“Hmph! Didn’t you hear him? It’s because he’s scared!”

“But adults don’t get scared!”

“Then, what are horror movies for, *stupid?”* The girl with the purple spinning top scoffs.

“That doesn’t count!”

“Yes, it does!”

“Maybe he needs a push.” The kid who doesn’t eat their veggies continues. Mydei still wonders why he is so interested in his love life. “So, that he can stop being scared.” He nods, satisfied with his reasoning, and turns to Mydei. “You should kiss him.”

“No, that’s stupid.” The girl with the purple spinning top sniffs, insulted by the mere notion of her friend’s suggestion. “You should tell him that you love him!”

“It’s the same thing!”

“You should fight him!” Popes in the boy with the green spinning top. “That’s what my brother does with his best friend whenever they are mad. They beat each other and then they go for pizza.”

“And then he could use the shovel!”

“Why don’t you paint him something?”

The entire world seems to go silent, just for a second, just for a moment, Oronyx’s breath stuttering in her chest for a second too long before she exhales, long and exhausted, perhaps even surprised, as the words leave the little girl’s mouth, like a match in a dark room, like the first drop of rain after a drought.

“...What?” Mydei asks.

“Why don’t you paint him something?” Repeats the little girl, extending all her little chalks towards him. “You are a painter. That’s what you do, right? You paint.”

Mydei looks at her—Her, with her color-stained fingers and her scraped knees, with her smile with a missing tooth and wonder-filled eyes. She had drawn Khaslana, once, he remembers, and it’s surprising, how much she seems to understand at the same time she understands so little. Simple solutions to hard situations.

You don’t know what to say? Paint it.

You care? Show him.

He thinks of Khaslana, with his melancholic eyes and fragile heart, with his ash-filled arm and weight in his steps, he thinks of sleepless nights wandering on his own through the remnants of a coffin, past the isolation of a dead star, past the vulnerability of a beating heart.

The next entry for the competition none of them cared about fast approaches. The next to last one, and he thinks, briefly, of the face he would make if come to face an empty spot, empty eyes on sinking boats.

He thinks that, maybe, Khaslana does not know how to swim.

Mydei picks up the blue chalk from the little girl’s hands.

And he paints.

It’s in such manner that a rather strange painting comes to rest on the walls of The Irontomb. It doesn’t fit the theme set for this entry, and neither does it feature the muse. Instead, the picture on the canvas is of a rather unassuming home made out of warm terracotta reds, situated on middle of the seventh street of the tenth avenue of a place you don’t need to know the name of, in between the house of a man who only ever does cups without handles and teapots without spouts and the residence of kind old woman who bakes really nice cookies and most definitely killed her last three husbands.

It may be late night, or early morning, in the painting, but the light in the kitchen is turned on, a stark contrast to the blue rain made out of chalk falling around. The shadow of a man and of a cat can be seen standing against the glass, looking out, waiting for someone. Under the second stone step, one that remains perpetually wobbly, something glints like a star in the dark.

It is named, *I Left a Key For You.*

Chapter End Notes

FOOTNOTES

1. She will die in two days—from heartbreak, her mother will say, and her quaint little tea shop that doesn’t sell very good tea will come to be in her little brother’s hands. He doesn’t make very good tea either. Back

2. Theodoros doesn’t take it off either. The little kid always giggles at its sight every time they see it. Back

3. “I know there isn’t any worth in incomplete things,” He had said. He couldn’t have been older than seventeen. His hands had been filled with cuts, and his left eye was covered by one of those antiseptic patches. “But, it seemed important—and you broke it because of me…” Back

4. It’s just one of those things that never came up. Khaslana had always much preferred coming to Mydei’s house. To him, the cheap, little apartment on the fifth floor at the skirts of the city never felt like an actual home, and it’s not like it ever was particularly fitting to receive guests, either way. It was always a little bit too messy, a little bit too cold. It’s a safe place, all things considered, but Khaslana has never quite slept well there. Back

5. With the exception of the painting of Khaslana’s sleeping form—It felt a little bit too personal. A sight a little bit too his. Back

6. He frames it and places it right in the middle of his living room, so that everybody can see his achievement. Instead of returning to the cheap gossip magazines, filled with ambition, Mister Reception Man proceeds to try his hand at Sudoku. Back

7. Because they run a candy racketeering ring around the block and do not share their lot with other kids, considering ‘their’ street happens to be situated right next to the bus stop, Khaslana has found himself the unfortunate long-suffering victim to their schemes—not that he minds. He’s just worried about their dental health. Back

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[He's here, you know] Sent: 20:45 PM

[I know] Sent: 20:47 PM
[I will wait for him] Sent: 20:47 PM

Chapter 14: Flowers in the rain

Chapter Notes

> Content warning: Sex. It's nothing really freaky, I think, but if you want to know what to expect, click
>
> ▶ here!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

That night, it rains.

A faint thing, quiet, almost tender, so very unlike the mournful cries the sky let out some time ago. The little drops of water fall gently from the gray clouds like cosmic dust, shining like stars for less than a life, under the yellowing lights of the street lamps, before coming to rest on top of the petals of the flowers blooming along the way.

It's silent, outside, save from the '*splish-splash*' Mydei's steps let out as he strides through puddles with remnants of chalk and the snickering winds crumpling the black plastic bag in his hand filled with small packs of cat food, a pack of rice, some snacks and a milk cartoon. It's near the end of the month, by now, and he has to go get groceries soon enough, but for tonight, he had decided on merely grabbing a black umbrella and throwing some old pair of dirty shoes and making a last-minute trip to the store at the corner of the street before it closed. The shopkeeper had been less than pleased.

Splish-splash, echoes through the night, *splish-splash*, *splish-splash.*

Something glints from the corner of his eye. The key under the steps. He lifts his head from where he is tracing patterns through the floor just to find it is not where he left it, but where it belongs.

Right on Khaslana's hand.

The world does not stop. Oronyx does not find the moment important enough to let out a sigh, and so cosmic dust falls, the winds laugh, and shadows dance inside the houses around them. But Mydei does, of course, how could he not? His lips part, his breath catches, and the *beat-beat-beating* of his picturesque heart halts.

He looks—a bit like a ghost, truth be told. He, with his solitary self and melancholic face, standing at the edge of the wobbly stone step, staring at the door. The flickering yellow lights of the street lamps dim and cast shadows all around him. The silhouettes of the tree branches extend like hands about to pull him deeper into the night, into the place between the sea foam and the sand, the thread of nonexistence, the edge of the world.

And yet the tender look in Khaslana's eyes when he sees Mydei is so terribly, painstakingly human, all those thoughts turn into dust.

He's here.

He, with his purple glove and picked lips, with his flaws and virtues and untied shoes—the pair Mydei gave him, that day on the ravine. He doesn't have an umbrella, but the rain, light as it is, hasn't soaked him yet, but it has fluffed more of his hair.

The umbrella in his hand lowers.

"Hey," Mydei calls.

"…Hi," Khaslana replies.

As if seeing each other for the first time.

A laugh spills out of Mydei's chest, unbidden. It echoes and strays through the melancholy of the night like the chiming of a bell. He can't help it, not really. He doesn't want to help it, either.

He walks towards him with a *splish-splash, splish-splash.* The little specks of rain are cold against his skin.

"Why haven't you entered?"

Khaslana gives a half-hearted shrug. “You weren’t there,” he answers, quietly. “Seemed a bit rude.”

“Well,” Mydei closes the umbrella. “I’m here now.”

The key in his hand shines like a star under the lights. He has a pack of cigarettes in the other. It isn’t opened, but his thumb digs and digs into the plastic around the cheap little white box as if he wanted to.

“Come on. It’s freezing out here.”

Khaslana hesitates, gaze scattering to the dark before going back to Mydei. Searching. He does not know what he finds, the sort of expression he has, but it is enough for Khaslana to let out a breath, turn around, and put the key in the lock.

One click, and the door unlocks. Another, and it opens.

He takes one step to the side, perching precariously on the very edge of the stone step, intent on letting him pass. Mydei places a hand on the small of Khaslana’s back and leads him into their home, just to make sure he remains at his side when the door closes again.

Inside, he kicks off his drenched shoes and places them next to the door. Khaslana does the same, revealing a pair of horribly mismatched socks underneath. It makes his steps silent as he follows him into the kitchen, so, so terribly, awfully silent that Mydei could almost let himself believe he was never here—and he thinks, briefly, perhaps pretentiously, that if this is how Orpheus felt when he led Eurydice out of death, then it is no wonder he looked back.

It is a rather foolish wonder, admittedly. Mydei is not Orpheus as much as he isn’t Pygmalion, and he has no intentions of letting Khaslana vanish.

“I still have the coffee you like if you want some. Though,” he makes a general motion towards the pot on the stove, still oozing steam. “I made hot chocolate.”

“I’m fine. Thank you.”

Mydei still takes two cups out. One red, one blue. None of them has handles.

Khaslana sighs.

“...Hot chocolate.”

“Sit down, then.”

Once again, Khaslana hesitates.

Mydei lets out a faint scoff and pats the empty space on the kitchen counter beside him, between the sink and the stove, before he grabs a wooden ladle. In practiced motions, he fills both cups while Khaslana pushes himself up to sit on the counter with a *‘bam!’* as the heels of his feet collide against the wooden cabinets. He gives him the red cup and keeps the blue one.

The rain outside starts to pick up as tiny little fragments of stars fall to the ground. In the lull of silence that befalls them, it’s not the *pitter-patter* sound that accompanies it, but something that resembles static more.

He does not know what to do.

It’s a rather strange sensation, come to think of it. Mydei had spent some time wondering how things would go once Khaslana came back, what things he would do, what he would say. Not anxiously, not really, but with the sort of precision a war general would plan their movements. And, yet, right now, with the warmth of the cup sweeping into his hands, watching Khaslana kick his legs almost absentmindedly in the air, all plans have promptly evaporated from his mind and the fragments of what he can remember don’t seem right.

That’s alright, maybe.

A part of Mydei is happy just to let the moment be.

“I saw the painting,” Khaslana says, eventually, rolling the cup in his palms. Both the key and the pack of cigarettes rest beside him. “It was nice.”

Mydei raises an eyebrow. “Only nice?”

A sound close to a scoff comes out of his mouth.

“Are you fishing for compliments? You know it wasn’t just nice.”

“No,” Mydei replies, not arrogantly, but plainly. He knows of his skill, knows of the sentiments he poured on each stroke of paint. “But I want to know what you think of it.”

“Why?”

“I made it for you.”

Khaslana lets out a breath and takes a sip of his drink. It’s still steaming, white clouds curling in loops in the air, and there’s no chance he hadn’t burned both his tongue and throat horribly. Khaslana doesn’t flinch as he swallows, though, but he does lick his lips. Mydei wonders if the liquid stung against the new wounds he picked out.

“I know,” he answers, and it is not a lie. “I liked it.”

“Yeah?”

“...Don’t sound so smug about it.”

Mydei chuckles. “I did not mean to.” If anything, he would think it came out more as giddy, embarrassingly enough. “I’m just glad.”

Khaslana lets out a faint *‘hmph’* and then, almost off-handedly, as if it didn’t matter, “I do believe it’s a little—embellished, maybe. I don’t think Kopopo would bother with someone like me.”

“Do you still think he doesn’t like you?”

“I think he tolerates me.”

“He lets you pet him.”

“He’s a very strange cat. That’s all.” He takes another sip, still piping hot. “As strange as his owner, maybe.”

Mydei lets out a hum. “Perhaps that’s why he missed you, too.”

Khaslana’s eyes lower. His thumb goes over the rim of the red cup in his hand almost absentmindedly while he watches his own reflection in the water.

“I wasn’t gone for that long.”

“It felt that way.”

“I’m sorry.” It’s nearly a whisper. “It’s just…” He pauses, starts again. “I didn’t mean—” And yet again. “I shouldn’t have—” And one last time, before he repeats. “...Sorry.” He slides the key towards him. “Here’s your key.”

Mydei looks at it for a beat far, far too long.

He slides it back towards him.

“Why are you giving it to me? It’s yours. It’s always been yours.”

Khaslana’s voice is nearly flat, but not quite, when he replies, “But I left.”

“And you came back.”

“But I *left.*” He repeats, and his voice is nearly angry, but not quite. “How can you trust me with something so important? I left once, I could leave again.”

Something squeezes harshly against his ribcage, and Mydei has to let out a breath to avoid whatever that painful, tender *something* is to burst out of him like jagged crystals.

To *vanish* and to *leave* are two very different things. He has no intention of letting Khaslana do the first, not now, not ever—but if he ever truly ever wished to leave, if he ever truly decided he did not want to be with Mydei, he does not think he could stop him, wouldn't ever dream of clipping his wings.

Still, still, *still*, "And I would be happy to know you keep it with you even if you did so."

Just in case you change your mind.

Just in case you need a safe place.

Carry with you a piece of my heart.

Khaslana stares at him. His eyes, deep blue things, holding both the immensity of the sea and the sky, go through every inch of Mydei's face, piercing his very soul, searching for a lie, perhaps, or something he can't hope to understand.

Outside, the rain goes on, static falling like a television with a very bad signal, perhaps the channel it would be on would be a very bad one too.

Khaslana settles his cup to the side.

"I'm not in love with you."

Mydei's heart breaks into pieces.

Butterflies fall limply to the bottom of his stomach. Their little blue and white wings flutter once, twice, before the cold exhale of death takes them with it. The sensation extends past his stomach, past his arms, and all the way to the ends of his fingers. Static fills his ears. The world seems to have reduced to merely six words, echoing around like a broken echo, as if the gasp Oronyx let out made the moment repeat forever while Zagreus laughed.

The pieces of his heart beat and dig into his chest like pieces of broken glass, perhaps this is what dying feels like.

It’s a stupid, foolish thought, but love, ah, treacherous thing, has a way to make even the smartest of people turn into the foolest of fools.

Still, still, *still*, “I never said anything about love.”

“But you *did,”* Khaslana replies, vehemently. “But you *have*, ever since…” A pause, and his brow furrows, as if he didn’t quite know. “Ever since…”

Since when, exactly?

When did love become so deeply, intrinsically interconnected between them that now it is unfathomable to think of a time where it wasn’t there? Where is it impossible to pinpoint when it bloomed to life? How did that happen?

Does it even matter?

“It doesn’t matter.” It’s what Khaslana decides, but not for reasons Mydei would agree with.

He takes a sip of his drink. It’s not piping hot, but it is still warm enough to chase away the exhale of death, though the taste of chocolate feels nearly cloying. “I think it does,” he answers.

“It *doesn’t.”* His hand closes around the key, and there’s one fleeting, terrifying moment where Mydei thinks he’s going to throw it out, but he just clutches it tightly—tight enough that it might actually draw blood. “Because I am not in love with you.”

Mydei does not reply.

“I’m not,” he repeats, sounding more as if he was trying to convince himself, this time. “Stop looking at me like that[1]. I’m not. I’m really not.”

Mydei still does not reply.

Khaslana’s face twists into something ugly, for a second or two, before he sighs. His gloved hand lets go of the key and drifts towards the pack of cigarettes. He’s saying something or another, but Mydei is not listening to

him anymore, catching the slight shift of his body as he starts to the edge of the counter.

He sets down his own cup and, just as Khaslana hops off the counter, he cages him against it.

Khaslana lets out a sound that resembles a squeaky toy being stepped on, and his hands fly towards Mydei's chest to try to put some distance between them. Mydei doesn't budge one bit, tightening the hold he has on the counter when Khaslana pushes harder.

"Again," he demands.

Khaslana blinks once, twice. They are so close that Mydei could count each and every one of his fluttering lashes. "What?"

"Say it again. Just one more time. Say it, and I will believe you—let you go, if that's what you want."

Khaslana's eyes narrow and his head shifts to the side. "I am not—"

"*Look* at me," Mydei interrupts. He grabs his face and tilts his head back towards him before he places his hand back on the counter, right next to Khaslana's hip, while pretending he did not notice the way Khaslana's breath fully stopped. "When you say it."

Khaslana's mouth presses into a thin, thin line and raises his nose, pridefully, almost haughtily, at him.

"I—" He breaks off, gaze drifting before he forces himself to look back at Mydei. He tries again. "I am not—" And breaks again. He licks his lips, swallows, and one more time. "I do not—" He closes his eyes, and his face shifts into something softer, quieter, tender, like surrender. "I can't."

He lets himself fall, like a puppet whose strings have finally been cut off.

Mydei catches him, of course he does, brings one hand around his body and places the other in his hair, soft, slightly damp, as Khaslana hides his face in

the space between his neck and his shoulder. His exhalations are warm against his skin.

He closes his eyes and buries his nose in the mess of white curls.

He smells like rain.

“You are a very cruel man,” Khaslana whispers. “I never had a chance.”

Mydei sighs.

“You are so dramatic. It’s only love.”

“It’s unfair, that’s what it is.”

He twirls a curl of white hair around his finger and pulls it lightly. “Stop whining,” he demands, but it comes far too fondly. Under his ribcage, he can feel the little butterflies start to flutter around again, cautiously, hopefully, picking back together the scattered pieces of his heart. “It’s not like you ever gave me much of a chance either.”

“Don’t lie to me.”

“You know I am not.”

A pause. One of Khaslana’s hands comes to rest in Mydei’s chest, right over his heart.

“Perhaps that’s the worst part.”

“Is it?”

“Yes, because I'm an awful being, and you are just… so wonderful, Mydei.” He exhales, and when he talks again, it’s as if it pained him. “I don’t think I know how to love. Not anymore. Not with the ease it comes to you.”

“Ease.” The word tastes like chalk on his tongue. *Easy* would have been to look at the abyss below and let himself drown. *Easy* would have been to let him go. “I don’t know about that.”

“Really.”

“Love isn’t easy, no. It’s about the willingness to try, I think.”

“To have it?”

Mydei hugs him tighter.

“To keep it.”

Khaslana goes silent, for a minute or two, before he admits, quietly, “I wish you had met me earlier.” And he lets out a sound, amused, almost, but each word he lets out sounds as if he were grieving a dead man. “Ah, how would you have loved me back then.”

And Mydei replies, “But I love you now.”

The world does not stop, not even for the magnitude of his words, his confession, his fluttering heart, but that doesn’t matter, it never did, not like the man that peels away from his hold to look his face with such deep, buried longing in his deep, blue eyes it threatens to fall like shooting stars any minute now.

“And I will have you, awful parts and all,” he continues, “if you just let me.”

Khaslana’s breath stutters in his chest.

The strokes of conflict paint themselves over his expression, and his whole frame starts to tremble as he comes to odds with his own self. The beginnings of misery, of a life, of a curse in and of itself clashing with the terrible, selfish want to be loved.

To be happy.

And it seems Khaslana is all too eager to finally pull himself out of that abyss, because he answers, tentatively, tethering right on the edge. “Only if you let me have you too.”

And Mydei laughs, oh, how he laughs! Long and loud, he laughs, drowning out the static outside.

“Oh, Khaslana.” He smiles. “You have had me for a long time now.”

Khaslana kisses like someone who wants to be consumed and consume in return.

It’s nearly violent. Their teeth clatter harshly against each other. The force with which Khaslana surged forward sends Mydei slamming down onto the floor. It’s an ugly, desperate thing, nearly anguished, and Mydei doesn’t even think for a second of letting him go until all oxygen evaporates from their lungs.

When they part, a thin string of saliva connects them for a second longer before it breaks.

Khaslana pants heavily over him, overwhelmed, as if he has forgotten how to breathe. Chest rising up and down, up and down, harshly. His cheeks have gained a faint pink tint, and his eyes are glassy.

A bit of saliva sticks to his chin, and, instinctively, Mydei cleans it with his thumb.

Khaslana blinks once, twice, and one tear falls out of his eye, followed by another, and another, and another still, and then it is like he can’t stop. Little tears falling onto Mydei’s face like the *'pitty-patter'* rain.

And he laughs.

It starts small. A snicker, then a chuckle, and then a laugh. A little shaky around the edges but bright all the same, warm and free, even as he hiccups between breaths. It’s a beautiful sound.

Nothing will ever fit Khaslana quite as well as happiness does.

The urge to kiss him again surges through him like an electric current, but Mydei does not want to cut his happiness short. His hands cup Khaslana’s

face, feeling the vibrations of the sound at the edge of his fingertips before he pulls him down to kiss the tip of his nose.

Khaslana laughs harder. His ears redden.

Delighted at the revelation, Mydei peppers his face with kisses. He places one on his forehead, on the space between his eyes, on his eyelids, on his cheeks, on his tears. He makes him laugh so much that the sound etches itself into the quaint red walls of his kitchen and worms itself into the little gaps of his mended heart.

Only once Khaslana has calmed down, he kisses his lips.

It’s a gentle thing, this one, soft and tender. He leads it, this time, passes his tongue over the little nicks and scars adorning the dry tissue and feels Khaslana tremble all over before he parts his mouth for him. He tastes of hot chocolate with a little bit of ash, and Mydei thinks he can taste the remnants of his joy hidden between his teeth.

It’s contagious. Mydei chuckles into the kiss.

They part, for less than an instance, just to get enough air before they kiss again. The rain might have picked up, or it might have lessened. It doesn’t matter, the world outside does not exist, not for tonight, not when Khaslana starts to breathe heat into him with every kiss, like a furnace melting gold.

Hands start to roam. Mydei lets go of his face in favor of his waist, trailing past his ribs, and when he absentmindedly rubs circles in the skin exposed with his thumb, Khaslana shudders.

Sensitive, a part of his mind supplies, and the knowledge makes him heady.

They don’t go for another kiss when they part this time. Khaslana swallows, lips shiny and swollen, and tugs his shirt slightly in a tentative, almost shy, motion. It’s a silent petition, one Mydei understands, and understands with every beat of his heart.

Ah, but alas, he’s a rather cruel man, so he asks, “What is it?” Khaslana blushes, tugs again. Mydei remains unfazed. “I can’t understand you if you don’t use your words.”

“…You know what I want.”

“I do. I just want to hear you say it," he admits. Khaslana scrunches his nose. He can be so stubborn sometimes. “Indulge me this once, won’t you?”

Khaslana’s eyes flicker to the side, still flighty despite everything. Mydei keeps rubbing circles with his thumb on waist as he waits for him to gather himself. He’s in no real hurry.

Frankly, for Khaslana, Mydei would be more than willing to wait for the end of eternity itself.

He opens his mouth.

A harsh, almost petulant *‘meow!’* arises and pops their little bubble with the precision of a sharp needle. They both jolt, and when Mydei shifts his head to the side, he’s met with Kopopo The Third in all his fuzzy glory sitting a couple of meters away from them, giving them his back.

A second passes where nothing really happens. Kopopo The Third shifts his head to the side to watch them from the corner of his eye. Once he notices they are already looking at him, his head snaps forwards and he lets out another mewl[2].

Khaslana pushes himself off from where he’s laying on Mydei and sits down, straddling him, and reaches a hand towards his cat with a little *‘psps’* sound.

Kopopo The Third gives him a sideways glance, playing the part of a very haughty cat for approximately twenty seconds before he caves in and turns around. He walks towards Khaslana with languid steps, doing a very bad job of pretending he does not care, before coming to sit right next to him.

Khaslana blinks.

Kopopo The Third mewls at him.

Slowly, Khaslana brings the hand he had extended forwards towards a little fuzzy head, petting it lightly—*too* lightly for Kopopo The Third's liking, it seems, who lets out a growl and pushes his head further into his palm.

Khaslana freezes.

And then makes the rather bold decision to pick Kopopo The Third up into his arms. Miraculously, his menace of a cat, who has attempted to kill Khaslana at least four times, does not go for the jugular, but, instead, starts *purring*.

"Oh," Khaslana lets out and just… kind of holds Kopopo The Third against his chest, like a child that doesn't want to part with a very dear plush toy. His cat looks wholly unamused, but keeps purring nevertheless.

It's a terribly, awfully domestic sight. Mydei would not mind seeing it more often, getting used to it, and, for a while, he is content with simply laying on the floor and watching Khaslana squeeze his cat half to death, like a very gentle revenge, before he pushes himself up.

"Bedroom?" he asks. Khaslana blinks, and actually seems to consider the options, looking, for a second, more inclined to keep pampering Kopopo The Third. Mydei is not as ridiculous as to get jealous of a cat. He really isn't. "Come on," he continues, eyebrow twitching at the glare his cat sends him. "I want you."

An array of different emotions crosses Khaslana's expression, ranging all the way from disbelief to doubt, before settling into embarrassment. He stares at Mydei, seemingly at a loss on what to do next.

Mydei doesn't give him time to ponder much longer. He stands up, pulling Khaslana up with him. A faint impulse spreads through his body, almost childish, definitely love-sick. It makes the tips of his fingers twitch before he realizes there's no real need to restrain such things any longer.

Before Khaslana can even take one step forwards, Mydei bends slightly, passes an arm behind his knees and sweeps him into a bridal carry, taking a bit too much enjoyment in the startled sound he lets out as he starts to walk towards his room and Kopopo The Third jumps out of his arms.

He scoffs. “Show-off.”

“You like it,” he answers. Khaslana is not exactly subtle with how he’s squeezing one of his arms appreciably. Immediately, he lets go and tugs harshly at his braid. Mydei rolls his eyes. “Don’t be petty. You can carry me next time if you want.”

Khaslana goes quiet.

Outside, it might still be raining—he thinks it’s still raining, static and stars falling onto the streets outside. It still doesn’t matter, but he can’t help but wonder if it will make the flowers shine tomorrow.

“Next time…” Khaslana repeats, faintly. He twirls a strand of orange hair around his index finger and lets it rest there like a ring. “I would like that.”

The door to his room opens with a creak.

There is a strange sort of quiet intimacy in the action, a strange sort of trust, perhaps, one that’s always present in having someone come into your room and letting them see the basket of dirty laundry in the corner, the seal plush toy won in a fair resting on the bed, the books yet to be read.

Khaslana has never been in his room before, though he has caught glimpses, and his eyes go through every little piece with a sense of curiosity that is all too present; through the scratched yoga mat in the floor his cat much prefers instead of the scratching post next to it, through the little green plant sitting next to a few knick-knacks on the shelves, through the television on the wall he barely uses, through the few canvas and art supplies strewn along the floor. It’s a broad bedroom, truth be told, but is not something that could be described as luxurious, much less sumptuous, but, rather, cozy. A place where he lives, a place where he sleeps, a place that is his.

A place that could be theirs.

Something in his chest sings like a little bird at the thought.

“You kept those?”

His eyes drift down and follow Khaslana’s line of sight, right to his night desk, next to his bed, where a little glass box with pressed forget-me-nots rests, a little thing lost between the gaps of the story, a little footnote at the margins of a life.

Mydei hums and lowers Khaslana down into the bed gently. “I keep everything you give me,” he replies, throwing some of the pillows he’s pretty sure are made out of cotton onto the floor.

A pause.

“...You were a very ugly teenager,” Khaslana deflects.

Mydei doesn’t need to look to know he's referring to one of the pictures placed on the night table. The one with his high school basketball team where Mydei, all lanky limbs and muscle that had yet to be formed, gives a toothy smile that shows all of his red braces as he stands with his friends. Next to it, another picture where he is with his mother rests.

“I very much doubt you were any better.”

“I very much was.”

“Hm-hm. Were you this humble, too?”

“Yes.”

“Titans,” Mydei sighs, somewhat exasperated, even as he settles between Khaslana’s legs. “I would have hated your guts as a kid.”

“Out of jealousy, I’m sure,” he shoots back without missing a beat. Mydei bites Khaslana’s cheek, who lets out a very bland, “Ouch.”

“You are insufferable.”

Khaslana hesitates, for a second, as if unsure whether he’s really allowed to say it out loud, before he replies, “And you love me anyway.”

“Unfortunately,” he jokes. Khaslana scowls and tugs on his braid harshly. It is quickly becoming his favorite way to show his annoyance, it seems. It’s a bit endearing. It’s also a bit annoying. “Stop that.”

Khaslana does it again.

Mydei pulls on the two strands of hair sprouting out of his head. Khaslana’s hands fly to his head and glares up at him.

“Don’t look at me like that. You were the one who started.”

“I’m gonna leave,” he threatens.

Mydei laughs. “No, you won’t.” He places a kiss on the corner of his eye, where the skin is still reddened.

Khaslana opens his mouth, closes it, eyes softening. “No,” he admits. “I won’t.”

Meow!

One of Mydei’s eyes twitches.

He looks back to see Kopopo The Third staring at them from the door. It almost feels judging. *Do you guys really prefer doing this than paying attention to me?* His little eyes seem to say.

“Do you *mind?”* Mydei asks, wholly unamused.

The resulting meow he gets as an answer seems to mean *‘yes’*.

A tiny sound escapes past Khaslana’s lips. When Mydei looks back at him, he’s covering his mouth with a hand, shoulders shaking slightly under the effort not to laugh.

“This affects you too, you know,” he tells him.

Another meow, sharper this time.

Mydei groans and, with some effort, peels himself off from where he’s practically draped over Khaslana. In quick strides, he makes his way towards the door and picks his cat up, holding him at eye level.

“I love you, Kopopo The Third, I really do, but I need you to listen to me clearly, you little fuzzy bastard,” he says, and then shakes his cat in the air, punctuating each and every word so that he understands, *“Do. not. ruin. this. for. us.”*

Kopopo The Third makes a sound that could very well pass for a scoff. It’s still a very weird thing to hear coming from a cat.

“I get that you missed him—” Kopopo The Third yowls. Mydei clicks his tongue. “Don’t give me that. I know you did. You are not as slick as you think you are.”

A dejected mewl.

Mydei really does not have the heart to get properly pissed at his cat. He sighs, places a kiss on top of his little fuzzy head. “It’s just going to be a little while, alright? You just have to wait a little bit, go sleep on the coach, eat the parrot of the corner store or something. After we are done—”

“And we shower,” Khaslana chimes in.

Mydei thinks for a second.

“And we shower,” he agrees, placing Kopopo The Third on the floor outside his room. “You can come in. How does that sound?” A mewl. “No, we are not going to forget about you.” Another mewl. “Yes, I promise. Now, shoo[3].”

Kopopo The Third turns around. He takes a couple of steps, slowly, as if making sure he knows he’s doing him a favor, before he mewls one last

time and disappears down the stairs.

Mydei closes the door.

In retrospect, he should have done that from the start.

This time, when he settles back in the space between Khaslana's legs, he makes sure to press their hips flush together, relinquishing the surprised sound the other lets out. They are both not hard yet, but there's a quiet thrum of anticipation running rampant through Mydei's blood, lighting up every single cell in his body on fire.

But, he doesn't move, not yet.

His eyes settle on the tight, black little choker around Khaslana's neck, making some of his pale skin bulge out slightly. He bends down, placing a kiss on the margins of the sun tattoo, and, somewhat deviously, his teeth close around the edge of the choker, pulling on it slightly before letting it *'snap!'* back into place.

"Ah!" Khaslana cries out.

His hips twitch up involuntarily, rubbing right into Mydei's crotch, and the friction—faint, as it is, feels heavenly. He rolls his own hips, slowly, deliberately, seeking more.

Against the shell of Khaslana's ear, Mydei murmurs, "Alright?" And he feels more than he sees the nods he gets in response. It's not good enough, and he grinds down, harder, harsher, swallowing at the sharp intake of breath Khaslana takes. "Use your words, Khaslana."

"Why are you—*ah,*" he cuts himself off, gasping at the sensation of Mydei placing his mouth right under his jaw and *suck—ing* a hickey onto the area. "So intent on that?"

"I told you before," he replies, voice rough, feeling his cock come to life as he keeps grinding against Khaslana. "I just want to hear you say it."

Khaslana makes a sound and covers his face with his hands.

Mydei frowns. “None of that,” he tuts, grabbing his wrists. Despite his apparent embarrassment, it is with terrible ease that Khaslana lets him pin both hands at the side of his head. “I want to see you too.”

“That’s—a lot of demands.”

“You make me greedy,” he replies. The shade of red that extends through Khaslana’s face can’t be described as anything other than lovely. Distantly, Mydei wonders which colors he would have to mix to get the right shade. “Is that alright?”

Khaslana swallows and nods.

“Words, Khaslana.”

“Yes.” His voice cracks. Slowly, he starts to rock his own hips against Mydei, breath picking up. “It’s alright.”

One of his hands sneaks under his shirt. “And what about this?” He asks while scrapping one nipple with a nail.

A full-body shudder runs through Khaslana’s body. He nods, remembers himself, and answers, “That’s alright too.”

Mydei undoes one by one the buttons of Khaslana’s shirt, revealing bit by bit the pale expanse of his skin. He swallows even as he helps the other out of it and throws the piece of fabric carelessly onto the floor.

He has seen it before, of course, but it is, however, the first time he can allow himself to just take, shamelessly, wantonly, and he takes in the sight, drinks it like a parched man, eyes lingering on each and every birthmark littering his chest like cracks.

Underneath him, Khaslana squirms, self-conscious.

He traces a little mark situated under his ribcage with reverent fingers before bending down. He presses his tongue right where the bigger one ends, feeling Khaslana jolt as he drags the wet thing all the way from his hip to his chest.

“You are beautiful,” he whispers against his heart before taking a pink nipple into his mouth.

Khaslana keens, from the words, from the sensation, a mix of both. His back arches once Mydei starts to suck at it, and his hands dig into his scalp, not harshly, but anchoring. Fingers closing around strands of hair. The action only encourages him further, and he doubles his ministrations.

He flattens his tongue around the nub and laps at it gently, until the little thing stiffens and hardens. Then, he sucks harshly on it at the same time he pulls away, and the nipple slips out of his mouth with a wet *‘pop!’* He repeats the same process with the other, but he does not leave the other unattended, rolling the slick nub with his thumb.

“My—Mydei,” Khaslana stutters, voice barely a breath.

Mydei hums as an answer. The vibrations have Khaslana letting out a faint moan that goes straight to his cock.

He pulls back to admire his own handiwork. Khaslana’s nipples have turned from a faint pink to a deep red, shiny with saliva, glistening under the warm light of the lamp on his night desk. They raise and fall with every shaky breath he takes.

His eyes move on to latch onto the little desires painted in his expression. The blush on his face, prominent as ever, now extends further, further down, spilling like ink into his neck. His eyes, blue, not as in the sky, but as in the deep sea he holds in his eyes, are now hazy with want. His lips are parted, stretching the scars littered through them, and Mydei gives in to the urge to lick them, as if he could soothe them, make them his own, share battles long fought.

He does not know what sort of expression he’s making. Something wrecked, perhaps, pulled apart at the seams with need; or perhaps, something adoring, stitched back together with tenderness. Both, neither, everything, and nothing. Whatever it is, it is enough for Khaslana to reach towards his glove[4].

Mydei grabs his wrist.

Khaslana looks at him.

“May I?”

A butterfly comes out of Khaslana’s mouth when he answers, “Yes.”

He extends his arms towards him, expecting Mydei to pull on the delicate silk around his ash-filled arm. Mydei doesn’t. Instead, his fingers find the end of the glove, around his biceps, and sneak their way inside. He feels the skin, coarse, rough, like sandpaper or very cheap leather. Carefully, he starts to slide his hand up, pushing the fabric along with him, revealing bit by bit every inch of his skin, caressing it, until their palms slot together like puzzle pieces.

Khaslana’s fingers close around his hand.

He asks, “Can you feel anything with it?”

“Not really,” he replies.

It doesn’t stop Mydei from bringing his lips against his wrist.

He places a kiss there, lingers; feels the thrum of Khaslana’s pulse. *Ba-thump*, it goes.

Ba-thump.

Ba-thump.

Ba-thump-thump.

Ba-thump-thump-thump.

“It’s picking up,” he murmurs against the skin, feeling it beat widely, frantically, like a little jackrabbit drumming his feet against the floor. *Ba-thump-thump.*

The exhale Khaslana lets out comes out shaky, whole body trembling. His head shifts to the side, and his other hand, the free one, tugs on Mydei's shirt. A silent plea, an attempt to shut him up. Mydei decides to indulge him, this time.

He lets go of his hand. In one swift motion, takes off his own shirt and tosses it to the side.

Khaslana's eyes immediately lower.

He makes a very valiant attempt at pretending otherwise, though.

"You can see," Mydei says, not bothering to hide his amusement at the way Khaslana sputters. "You can touch, too, if you want," he teases.

One of Khaslana's eyes twitches. "And you call me insufferable..."

Still, he does settle both hands on his pecs. His eyes dart towards his face, not subtle in his search for reassurance, and Mydei nods.

He squeezes, experimentally. When that fails to bring any sort of meaningful reaction out of Mydei other than a raised eyebrow, he starts to knead at the muscle like some sort of pleased cat. It feels nice, although a little bit too light for it to be really pleasurable.

It's not until Khaslana pinches one of his nipples that he pulls the first real sound out of him.

Khaslana swallows.

Emboldened, he lifts himself slightly from where he is laying on the bed and brings his mouth around one of Mydei's own nipples. Mydei hums into the sensation. Khaslana's lips are not exactly soft, they are far too scarred for that, but the contrast feels nice against his skin. His mouth is warm, very warm, and even though his attempt at mimicking Mydei's prior actions is rather poor, he still manages to pull some sighs out of him. His chest has always been a rather sensitive place.

He lets himself indulge in the sensation for a minute or two, perhaps even three, before he snakes a hand between their bodies and squeezes Khaslana's length.

Khaslana moans and bites down. *Hard.*

A hot burst of white pain shoots up his nerves like an electric current. Sharp and sudden. It mixes like paint and water with the blazing heat, heat, heat pooled down in his gut and the line between pain and pleasure blur. He lets out a sound between a hiss and a moan.

Khaslana rips himself out of his chest, chest heaving. "I—"

"That's fine. I liked it," Mydei interrupts, nearly smashing Khaslana's face back between the valley of his chest. Khaslana keens like a dying animal. "You can keep going."

Khaslana peers up at him from where he's still pressed, lashes fluttering like the wings of a butterfly. He gives one small lick against the nipple he just bit. Soothing. Tender in a way he isn't with his own wounds.

And he bites down again.

"Ngh!"

Pleasure climbs up his spine almost violently.

Sounds spill free from his mouth as Khaslana fondles his chest harder, tugging and biting instead of licking and sucking. His eyes flutter close, cock straining in the confines of his pants.

A small, competitive spark lights up in his chest and, with trembling fingers, he manages to unbuckle the belt around Khaslana's pants after a few tries. He shoves a hand under the fabric, under his underwear, and fists Khaslana's length.

"Ah!" he cries out, eyes rolling up. He falls rather unceremoniously back into the bed with a dull *'plaff'* as he starts to jerk him off. "Myd–*ei*, wait—*ah, oh!"* his head falls back, neck arched like a swan.

Mydei’s eyes zero on it with the hunger of a starving lion.

The little black choker around his neck comes off with the same sharp *‘click!’* a loaded gun makes once the safety is taken off.

He places a kiss right in the middle of that burning sun, drinking in greedily the sigh Khaslana breathes out. But it cuts off sharply as Mydei brings his mouth to the edge of the little red string around his neck, where the skin is still tender thanks to the pressure, and he sucks.

He tugs on his pants. Against his skin, he grumbles, “Lift your hips.” Before he goes back to sucking reds and purples on the expanse of white.

Obediently, Khaslana does so.

It still takes some effort to free him of his clothes, however. What with Mydei completely unwilling to detach himself from his neck and Khaslana unable to do much aside clinging onto Mydei’s shoulder for dear life. He’s not used to pleasure, he can tell.

It’s endearing, if a bit depressive. He doesn’t stop to think about it much. The implications of it are more than guaranteed to turn him off.

Instead, he lets himself delve into the triumph of finally getting Khaslana’s pants, along with those terrible socks, off his body. In the same breath, he goes to take his, too, but as his fingers graze his own hips, he realizes something and pauses.

Completely.

Khaslana blinks once, twice, almost dazedly. “Why—” he starts, voice airy. “What is it?”

“...I don’t have any condoms.”

The silence that falls over the room is loud. Not judging—just, loud. Very loud. Uncomfortable. A little awkward.

Mydei sighs, passing a hand over his hair. He straightens up and takes a look at the clock on his night desk. The red numbers mark eight five. It's still raining outside.

He can still make a run for it, he decides, would take less than five minutes. Ten, perhaps, if the woman of the store at the corner of the street decides to hit him with the broom for disturbing her this late—*again.*

He shuffles backwards. Khaslana's hands shot out to grab his arms.

"Don't go."

Mydei looks at him. Khaslana holds his gaze. His eyes aren't pleading, nor fearful, but the red tint of his prior tears still clings to the edges.

It's a losing battle, Mydei realizes then, no chance of winning when he feels his heart soften and his own eyes linger on the high flush of his cheeks, the swollen lips, the array of possessive bruises on his neck.

He still tries.

"It won't take long."

"It already has," he replies. "I—I wasted too much time running already."

What a fool of a man. Still, "Khaslana." He gathers him into his arms. "I'm not going anywhere."

Khaslana throws his arms around him, pulls him even closer. Their chests collide against each other, hot, sweaty, a bit gross. The notion of pushing him off doesn't even cross his mind. "I want you to stay, anyway."

"Then, I will," he replies, then halts and winces. "...But I don't have any lubricant either."

Khaslana coughs, embarrassed. "...That's fine."

"Are you sure?"

“Yes.”

“It’s going to be a bit dry.”

“That’s fine.”

“It could be painful.”

Khaslana pauses, places a kiss on his neck. “You won’t hurt me.”

It’s the trust that undoes him—it’s always the trust, in the end. Mydei surges forwards, nearly smothering Khaslana under him as he captures his mouth against his in a searing kiss.

His hand closes once again around Khaslana’s now bare length. Khaslana moans in his mouth and Mydei swallows the sound down. He pumps his cock in slow, languid strokes, up and down, up and down, smearing bits of pre-cum gathering at the tip along the shaft to make the glide smoother. Wet, slick sounds filling the air as their breaths get heavier and heavier. Heat coiling deep.

It doesn’t take much for Khaslana’s little moans and breathy sounds to get higher and higher; whole body shaking like a leaf.

“Mydei,” he moans out. “I—Mydei, I am—I’m going to—”

Mydei circles his slit with his thumb.

Khaslana comes spilling into his palm immediately after, eyes rolling upwards and mouth left gaping open. Despite how loud he is, his orgasm is very nearly silent, voice cutting short as all breath leaves his lungs at once before he falls limply onto the bed.

Mydei swallows.

He wants more—much, much more. The heat pooled in his gut burns with favor, like molten golden melting, wishing for more, needing more. He wants him whole, wants to give himself in return.

As yours as you are mine, a part of his mind supplies, a part of his heart sings.

Khaslana's come is still warm in his hand. Sticky. Mydei gathers as much as he can into his palm, coats his fingers in it before slowly bringing his index down, down, down, right above the other man's rim, circling the little entrance.

Khaslana goes rigid.

"Alright?" Mydei asks.

He swallows. "Alright."

"Try to relax. It will hurt less that way," he says, and waits for Khaslana to nod before he starts to press his finger in. "Take a breath."

The first finger sinks with surprising ease. Khaslana makes a sharp sound at the back of his throat, body going tense like a bow's string, and he clenches down so hard that it borders on painful.

"It's fine," Khaslana says before Mydei even gets the chance to ask. His expression is pinched. "It's just—it feels weird." A pause. A breath. "You can move. I'm fine."

Mydei raises an eyebrow. He moves his finger back, just a fraction, just to prove a point when Khaslana lets out a low hiss, squeezing his eyes shut.

"Not a word, Mydeimos," he rasps out.

"Wasn't planning on it." He was definitely planning on it.

He shifts so that he's fully laying on his stomach, letting out a pleased hum when Khaslana parts his legs further for him without any prompting. The small pink opening twitches around his finger, swallowing it with something akin to greed even though it's a tight fit—*very* tight, warm, a little wet.

He lets out a deep breath, counts to three in his head when he feels his cock twitch, begging for attention. He's so hard he's almost dizzy, and the urge to rut himself into completion against the bed, to chase his own pleasure, is nearly madding. But he pushes that need down, restrains it, and redirects his attention back to Khaslana.

He will have him, soon enough—*wants* to have him. Every single prospect of fleeting indulgence pales against that need.

He caresses a pale thigh with his free hand, squeezes once, twice, maybe even thrice, feeling the powerful muscle underneath. Khaslana has rather thick thighs, strong ones. He places a kiss on one of them, slowly drags his tongue up, closer and closer towards his pelvis.

Until he notices a small little black dot pressed like ink into the skin of his inner thigh.

"Titans," Mydei breathes out. "You are a dream."

Whatever shy complaint Khaslana had dies on the tip of his tongue with a surprised 'ah!' when Mydei bites him, feeling the meat underneath yield under the pressure.

"You, *ngh,*" Khaslana tries, shaking when Mydei sucks until the skin is purple. "You really like leaving marks."

"I do," Mydei admits, and licks the hickey he left, pleased. "I'm an artist, after all."

"...You are embarrassing, that's what you are."

Mydei bites him again.

Khaslana's length is already at half-mast once Mydei turns to it. It's as pale as the rest of him, still dripping a few drops of pre-cum. Mydei presses his tongue against the base, feeling Khaslana's legs twitch, and maintaining eye contact, he licks all the length up towards the tip before swallowing it down in one go.

The end of his length bumps against his throat. He lets it rest there for a second longer. He bobs his head up and down, up and down, up and down a couple of times, before swirling his tongue around his cock, feeling it swell and slowly fill his mouth.

Slowly, Mydei starts to thrust his finger into Khaslana's hole.

"Mydei!"

His voice cracks around the syllables. Mydei opens his eyes, drinking in the sight of Khaslana's disheveled state with glee. He hums around the length, watching with rapt attention the way Khaslana's eyes roll to the back of his head and his head falls back into the pillows.

He does it again, just because, but ends up choking when Khaslana's hips jerk upwards.

"Sorry," he says—or tries to, at least. It's barely an exhalation. His hips twitch.

Mydei spits out his cock, coughing a couple of times. "That good, uh?" he asks, voice rough. Before he can reply, however, he brings another finger, the middle one, to his rim, pressing lightly. "Want to feel better?"

"Ah—*ah.*"

"Hm. I don't understand what that means."

"Aren't you enjoying this a little too much?" he asks, completely unamused.

Mydei is, yes. Can you blame him? "That's not a yes."

"Just shove that thing in!"

Mydei huffs, but obeys. Sort of. He's certainly not as careless as to just 'shove it in.' He does not wish to hurt Khaslana whatsoever. Besides, the cum he had coated his fingers with before has dried already.

He thinks for a second, gathers saliva in his mouth, and lets it fall on and around his hole. Khaslana lets out a mortified sound that, once again, resembles more a squeaky toy being crushed. His hands fly to cover his face, and Mydei lets him hide, this time. It was, admittedly, a rather vulgar action—even he feels embarrassed. So much for not wanting lube or anything that resembles it.

Tentatively, he pushes the finger inside. It doesn't sink as easily as the first one did, and Khaslana lets out a litany of sounds that edge more on the side of pain than pleasure. When Mydei asks if he's alright, he answers with a strained, "It burns."

Mydei litters him with attention in an attempt to distract him, sucks and bites the meat on his tights, swallows him down to the hilt. He's diligent in his task, attentive. Soon enough, Khaslana starts to unwind. Little hisses and harsh breaths replaced with breathless sighs and little *'ah, ah, ah's.'*

He still waits a moment longer before he starts moving them. In and out, in and out, in and out, at first, before he starts to move them in a scissoring motion, expanding, exploring. He curls them just so, and one of them seems to, at least, graze that hidden little bundle of nerves, because Khaslana lets out a high-pitched keen and his legs jerk violently.

So violently, in fact, that he accidentally kneecaps Mydei on the head with enough force to have him seeing stars.

A harsh curse slips out of his mouth as pain bursts from the side of his head. The world becomes a blur of colors and motion, stretching like bubblegum and dissolving like bubbles at the same time black spots sing and dance in the corner of his vision.

He lets himself be dragged up without a fuss, only registering the warmth that settles over his cheeks. One soft, the other coarse, but caring all the same. He blinks, blinks again, until Khaslana's face snaps into place like shapes from a kaleidoscope. He's saying something, or perhaps another, scarred lips moving in rapid fire.

…Just how ridiculous their situation can get? He wonders, then laughs.

“Did—Did I hit you too hard?” Khaslana’s expression turns apprehensive. “Are you alright? Should, uh, should I—”

“Sensitive, aren’t you?”

There’s a long, long pause.

Once Khaslana registers the words, he goes red with anger, or embarrassment, perhaps both. One of his hands flies to grab the closet thing he has, which, in this case, is Mydei’s seal plush toy[5]; and he starts hitting him with it.

Mydei laughs harder.

“Why are you the one getting mad?” he asks, attempting to wrestle the little thing out of his hands. “I was the one nearly sent to the hospital.”

“You are *fine,*” Khaslana snaps, punctuating each word with another hit. “It’s not like—”

Mydei kisses him. Chaste. A little peck. Just enough to get a taste. It’s enough for Khaslana to stop his plushy attempt at murder and lower the weapon.

“...I didn’t hurt you, did I?”

Mydei snorts. “No.”

“Sorry.”

“It’s fine,” he replies, “I like that you feel so strongly.”

“Wha—*ngh!*” A moan rips out of his chest right as Mydei presses his finger back into his entrance, along with a third, this time. Still careful, still gently, but not as slowly as before, now that he’s sure Khaslana can take it. “Wait, hold on, ah, I—”

Mydei kisses him again.

“Consider it revenge,” he says.

“I should have hit you har—ugh!”

“What was that?” Mydei chuckles. Khaslana gapes, whole body trembling as if he was being electrocuted while he presses against his prostate. “I don’t think I quite heard you.”

“You are *awful.”*

“And you love me anyway,” he replies, mirroring Khaslana’s words from earlier before he decides he has tormented him enough. He takes his fingers out. “Do you think you are ready?”

Khaslana heaves, breathes, and he swallows.

“Yes.”

Finally, Mydei goes to take off the rest of his clothes, ignoring the wet patch in his underwear before tossing them carelessly onto the floor. The feeling of cold air against his stiffness, hot, red and already dripping, has him sighing.

He closes a hand around it and he hisses. The sudden stimulation is very nearly painful after going so long ignored. Still, he collects the pre-cum gathered in the tip and spreads it along the shaft with languid movements, up and down, up and down, while moans and groans spill out of his mouth. Pleasure spreads along his nerves like lightning, like wildfire, all-encompassing, all-devouring, but it still is a bit too dry, a bit too chafe.

He spits into his hand.

Khaslana lets out a shaky exhale.

Mydei opens the eyes he hadn’t realized had fallen shut and his mouth goes dry.

Khaslana is a vision, underneath him, sinking in desire. Pale skin flushed red, littered with bites and hickeys; breathes coming in heavy pants as if he

couldn’t get enough air. His hair splays on the pillows, not like a halo, it’s far too messy for that, and he’s no god, but something so painfully human it clouds his blue eyes with a thin veil of need, of want, of lust.

His gaze latches onto Mydei’s length, tongue peeking out of his mouth as if he wanted a taste, and one of his hands rests above his pelvis, close to his own stiffness, as if the mere sight of Mydei’s pleasure was enough to bring him into completion. A little below it, his entrance, gaping, winks temptingly up at him.

Mydei nearly comes from the sight.

He bites the inside of his cheek so hard he tastes blood, breathing deeply, counting to five, ten, fifteen, and then twenty. He slicks the rest of his cock with slow, careful movements, overly aware of the way Khaslana’s eyes follow his every action. His hands tremble, almost jittery, and he thinks he might combust on the spot any minute now.

Another breath.

He drags one of the pillows and settles it under Khaslana’s hips before grabbing them. He lines up his cock towards his entrance, tip shy of entering, and turns to face him.

“Rea—” He coughs, clears his throat. His mouth is terribly, awfully dry and when he licks his lips the only thing he tastes is salt. “Ready?”

Khaslana squirms. His scarred hand closes around one of his wrists. He thinks the action ought to be grounding. So, Mydei holds it, brings it to his lips and kisses the back of his palm in quiet reassurance before interlocking their fingers together.

He nods.

Something warm, like candlelight, pools in his chest before dripping like heated wax towards the end of his gut.

Still, Mydei kisses his forehead. It also tastes of salt. “Words, Khaslana,” he reminds him in a whisper. “I need to know you want it.”

“I do,” he replies, also in a whisper, as if he didn’t want the world to hear, only Mydei. “I want you, Mydei.”

A hundred butterflies spill out of him with the next exhalation.

He starts to push in, slowly, carefully, feeling every single, agonizing inch sink into Khaslana’s warmth. Despite the amount of preparation, is still somewhat of a tight fit, and Mydei grits his teeth when he feels him squeeze and squeeze harder around him. Sweat runs down his temple before spilling onto Khaslana’s clavicles.

He’s only halfway in when Khaslana lets out a whimper.

Mydei stops immediately. “Too much?” He asks between breaths.

Khaslana shakes his head. “No, I’m fine,” he says, breathless again. He’s gripping Mydei’s hand so strongly it feels as if he might break a bone or two. “I’m fine. It’s just—it feels weird.”

“Weird how?”

“I don’t know. Weird.”

Mydei stares at him, doubtful. He thinks—reflects, really, back on all the little instances of tonight that have led him to this point, all the little moments. He thinks of Khaslana’s apparent inexperience, his hesitation, his embarrassment. His sensibility, even. He’s not used to pleasure.

A small, sudden moment of clarity overcomes him.

“Are you—is this your first time?” He asks. Khaslana attempts to kneecap him again, gentler, this time, though it only serves him to take Mydei deeper, and he lets out a strangled sound. “It is, isn’t it?”

Khaslana glares at him, tries to, at least. “So, what if it is?” He asks, defensive, somewhat embarrassed. “It wouldn’t have changed anything.”

“I would have insisted on the lube, for starters.”

He scoffs. “Funny.”

“I’m serious.”

“Wasn’t it obvious?” He sighs. “It’s not like there was anyone who I could trust this with.”

“...Until me.”

Khaslana looks at him. “I love you, Mydei.”

Oh, love.

The words hit him hard. He’s not sure why. Mydei already knows it, intrinsically, intimately, infinitely. But, there’s just something about this time, about it now, about hearing without any sort of fanfare, in the confines of his room, his life, a confession uttered said so plainly, so casually, so mundanely, as if it was second nature, that makes Mydei’s heart burst and spill out from his eyes.

Oh, love! What has it done to him? Why can’t he bring himself to resent it? How could he, when it makes him so happy?

Two hands settle on his cheeks again. One soft, one coarse like sandpaper scraped raw, and he is pulled down so that Khaslana, he who trusts Mydei enough to give him his whole being, can kiss away the wetness gathering at the corners of his eyes, make them his own.

“Khaslana,” his heart calls, and he places a kiss on his forehead. “My muse,” his soul calls, and he places a kiss on his nose. “My love,” Mydei calls, and he places a kiss on his lips. “Oh, how I adore you.”

It’s a gentle rhythm, what they settle into. Slow and tender. Lost, beneath the night. Insignificant, underneath the stars. Hidden, under the falling rain. The world won’t stop for them, it hasn’t before, and it won’t start now. Time will pass, and, in a couple of hours, the sun will arise, and none will know what else happened in that little room.

For there’s no need for any other witness than their own hearts.

Still, before the end comes, you may find yourself pleased to know that a rather mundane painting comes to rest on the walls of The Irontomb for the very last entry of a competition which a purple butterfly and her sister won —for those who wish to know. It is of a rather cozy kitchen of a rather unassuming home made out of warm terracotta reds. On the counter, there sat a rather simple man with a coffee cup without a handle in hand, saying something that, overall, simply does not matter, to another man making breakfast. They both look rather drowsy by the early morning, and even the cat stretching on the table, next to a pair of keys with matching keychains, looks much more inclined to simply turn tail and go back to sleep.

It is named, *Love*.

Chapter End Notes

FOOTNOTES

1. As if I had broken your heart. Back

2. “I’m also here, you know,” he means to say, nonchalantly, because it’s not that he cares or anything, not one bit, but, arguably, he’s the most important being in this house, and so it is crucial they know he’s here for no particular reason at all. Back

3. They both forget about the cat. Kopopo The Third is absolutely livid. Him! Forgotten! Can you believe that? Hmph! For them to earn his fuzzy forgiveness, he demands a lot of pets and a lot of treats for a month straight. A harsh sentence, indeed, but for those who know Kopopo The Third, they will all agree he let them go lightly for this awful transgression. If, by now, you have come around to finally speaking cat, then Kopopo The Third will admit that, alright, yes, sure, whatever, perhaps he does like the strange human that bleeds paint. He’s surprisingly warm, makes for a good heater, and it’s not like love isn’t a good look on his owner. The house was a little bit too big for just the two of them, anyway. Back

4. “Something stupid.” It’s what Khaslana would answer if you were to ask him, much to Mydei’s annoyance. Back

5. Made out of polyester, he checked. Back

I had no idea I had been puntuacting dialogue wrong! I tried doing it correctly this chapter, and I will be going through the other chapters to fix that in the next few days, but do forgive me if I get some wrong, I am still getting the hang of it. Now, having said that, that's all, folks! Thank you dearly for reading!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!